

**TOWN of BROOKLINE**  
Massachusetts  
**Walnut Hills Cemetery**

**Trustees**

Randolph Meiklejohn, Chair  
Lisa Farber  
Gerry Hayes  
Peggy Maguire  
Joslin Ham Murphy

**Parks and Open Space Division**

Alexandra Vecchio, Director

Meeting of the Walnut Hills Cemetery Trustees  
Wednesday, March 20, 2024  
9:30 AM- 10:30 AM  
Hybrid Meeting

**TO ATTEND IN PERSON, PLEASE GO TO THE FOLLOWING LOCATION:**

Brookline Town Hall, 333 Washington Street, Brookline, MA 02445, Room 111

**TO ATTEND VIRTUALLY, REGISTER IN ADVANCE FOR THIS WEBINAR:**

[https://brooklinema.zoomgov.com/webinar/register/WN\\_KVjmOF09QFSaRNzAZ\\_D5dQ](https://brooklinema.zoomgov.com/webinar/register/WN_KVjmOF09QFSaRNzAZ_D5dQ)

**TO ACCESS THE MEETING BY PHONE, DIAL:** US: +1 669 254 5252 or +1 646 828 7666

Webinar ID: 160 501 1693      Password: 86579452

International numbers available: <https://brooklinema.zoomgov.com/j/ucErySF4gM>

**Meeting Files Link**

<https://www.brooklinema.gov/DocumentCenter/Index/5197>

**AGENDA**

- 9:30 AM Welcome, Approval of the October 16, 2023 Meeting Minutes and the December 6, 2023 Meeting Minutes, and Signing of Deeds
- 9:35 AM Review, Discussion, and Possible Votes on the Fiscal Year 2025 Cemetery Rates
- 10:00 AM Discussion of Green Burials
- 10:10 AM Staff Update
- 10:30 AM Adjourn

# 1. Lot availability 2023

(From: John Ronan e-mails of 02/17/2023 and 03/03/2023)

| SECTION 21: |         |           |
|-------------|---------|-----------|
| Laid out:   | Sold    | Available |
|             | 2008-23 | 2023      |

| SECTION 18: |          |         |           |
|-------------|----------|---------|-----------|
| Laid out:   | Sold     | Sold    | Available |
|             | pre 2008 | 2008-23 | 2023      |

| VETERANS'   |
|-------------|
| SECTION 19: |
| Available   |
| 2023        |

| Not yet for sale |
|------------------|
| SECTION 22:      |
| Laid out:        |

Lot size Marker type

|                 |      |     |     |    |     |     |    |     |     |     |
|-----------------|------|-----|-----|----|-----|-----|----|-----|-----|-----|
| CASKET Upright  | 326  | 288 | 38  | *  |     |     |    |     |     |     |
| CASKET Flush    | 47   | 2   | 45  |    | 719 | 437 | 90 | 192 | 338 | 631 |
| CASKET Wall     | 56   | 32  | 24  | ** |     |     |    |     |     |     |
| Subtotal:       | 422  | 322 | 100 |    |     |     |    |     |     |     |
| CREMATION Flush | 690  | 24  |     |    |     |     |    |     |     |     |
| CREMATION Wall  | 49   | 7   |     |    |     |     |    |     |     |     |
| Subtotal:       | 739  | 31  | 708 |    |     |     |    |     |     |     |
| TOTAL           | 1161 | 353 | 808 |    | 719 | 437 | 90 | 192 | 338 | 631 |

\*John Ronan had not completely resolved these numbers; "available" might be only 29, of which 18 are "in process" or being held for prospective buyers.

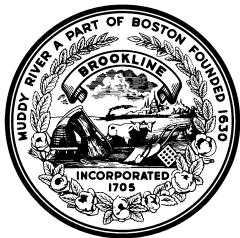
\*\* In this row, John had reported 26 "available", which is close to the 24 indicated here (net of 56 less 32).

## 2. Sales history, 2008-2023

(From: Excel worksheet prior to Sept. 2022 trustees meeting)

|                            |     | % of total | # in avg yr |
|----------------------------|-----|------------|-------------|
| Casket, upright, Sect. 21: | 322 | 73%        | 21          |
| Casket, flush, Sect. 18:   | 90  | 20%        | 6           |
| Cremation lots, Sect. 21:  | 31  | 7%         | 2           |
| Total                      | 443 | 100%       | 30          |

|                     |    |
|---------------------|----|
| # years 2008-2023 : | 15 |
| average lots/year   | 30 |



# TOWN of BROOKLINE

Massachusetts

## Walnut Hills Cemetery Old Burying Ground

### Trustees

Randolph, Meiklejohn, Chair  
Lisa Farber  
Gerard Hayes  
Peggy Maguire  
Joslin Ham Murphy

Director of Parks and Open Space  
Alexandra Vecchio

### CEMETERY RATES EFFECTIVE

JULY, 2020

|                                                            |          |
|------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| Single Grave- Full Body Upright Marker                     | \$2,575  |
| Double Grave – Full Body Upright Marker                    | \$5,150  |
| Four Grave Lot – Full Body Upright Marker                  | \$10,300 |
| Single Grave – Full Body Flat Marker                       | \$1,700  |
| Single Grave - Cremated Remains Flat Marker                | \$990    |
| Single Grave – Full Body Stone Wall Memorialization        | \$3,900  |
| Single Grave – Cremated Remains Stone Wall Memorialization | \$2,550  |

### Grave Opening

|                                    |         |
|------------------------------------|---------|
| Monday – Friday 7:30 AM to 3:30 PM | \$1,250 |
| Monday – Friday after 3:30 PM      | \$2,000 |
| Saturday & Holidays*               | \$2,000 |
| Sunday                             | \$2,300 |

### Urn Grave Opening

|                                    |       |
|------------------------------------|-------|
| Monday – Friday 7:30 AM to 3:30 PM | \$620 |
| Monday – Friday after 3:30 PM      | \$930 |
| Saturday, Sunday & Holidays*       | \$930 |

### Disinterment

\$2,300

### Foundation Setting for Headstones

\$160 per sq ft

Two grave lot (3ft x 1 ft) would be \$480. No more than 1 stone permitted  
Four grave lot (4 ft x 1 ft) would be \$640. No more than 2 stones permitted  
One-piece tablet (monolith) \$320 minimum at \$160sq ft

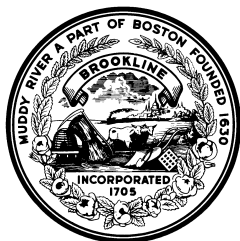
### Flat Marker Setting

Single grave (2 ft x 1 ft plus 4 in. deep) would be \$320 at \$160sq ft  
Double grave (3 ft x 1 ft plus 4 in. deep) would be \$480 at \$160 sq ft  
Oversize grave based on actual size at \$160 sq ft

\*Town Recognized Holidays: New Year's Day, Martin Luther's King Day, Washington's Birthday, Patriots' Day, Memorial Day, Bunker Hill Day, Juneteenth, Independence Day, Labor Day, Columbus Day, Veteran's Day, Thanksgiving Day and Christmas Day

96 Grove Street Brookline, Massachusetts 02445-6863  
Telephone: (617) 730-2179 Facsimile: (617) 739-7580

[2023-11-14 per JZW email: Rates in black were superseded in 2018 by rates in red.]



# **T O W N o f B R O O K L I N E**

*Massachusetts*

## **Walnut Hills Cemetery Old Burying Ground**

### **Trustees**

*Robert Cook, Chairman  
Nina Brown  
Gerard Hayes  
Peggy Maguire  
Joslin Ham Murphy*

### **Director of Parks and Open Space**

*Erin Chute Gallentine*

### **CEMETERY RATES EFFECTIVE**

**CURRENT/3%INCR**

|                                                            |          |                 |
|------------------------------------------------------------|----------|-----------------|
| Double Grave – Full Body Upright Marker                    | \$5000   | <b>\$5150</b>   |
| Four Grave Lot – Full Body Upright Marker                  | \$10,000 | <b>\$10,300</b> |
| Single Grave – Full Body Flat Marker                       | \$1650   | <b>\$1700</b>   |
| Single Grave - Cremated Remains Flat Marker                | \$990    | <b>SAME</b>     |
| Single Grave – Full Body Stone Wall Memorialization        | \$3800   | <b>3,900</b>    |
| Single Grave – Cremated Remains Stone Wall Memorialization | \$2550   | <b>SAME</b>     |

### **Grave Opening**

|                                    |        |               |
|------------------------------------|--------|---------------|
| Monday – Friday 7:30 AM to 3:30 PM | \$1200 | <b>\$1250</b> |
| Monday – Friday after 3:30 PM      | \$1900 | <b>\$2000</b> |
| Saturday & Holidays*               | \$1900 | <b>\$2000</b> |
| Sunday                             | \$2200 | <b>\$2300</b> |

### **Urn Grave Opening**

|                                    |       |              |
|------------------------------------|-------|--------------|
| Monday – Friday 7:30 AM to 3:30 PM | \$600 | <b>\$620</b> |
| Monday – Friday after 3:30 PM      | \$900 | <b>\$930</b> |
| Saturday, Sunday & Holidays*       | \$900 | <b>\$930</b> |

### **Disinterment**

**\$2200 \$2300**

### **Foundation Setting for Headstones**

**\$155/\$160 per sq ft**

Two grave lot (3 ft x 1 ft) would be \$465/**\$480**. No more than 1 stone permitted  
Four grave lot (4 ft x 1 ft) would be \$620/**\$640**. No more than 2 stones permitted  
One-piece tablet (monolith) \$310/**\$320** minimum at \$155/**\$160**sq ft

### **Flat Marker Setting**

Single grave (2 ft x 1 ft plus 4 in. deep) would be \$310/**\$320** at \$155/ **\$160**sq ft  
Double grave (3 ft x 1 ft plus 4 in. deep) would be \$465/**\$480** at \$155/**\$160** sq ft  
Oversize grave based on actual size at \$155/**\$160** sq ft

\*Town Recognized Holidays: New Year's Day, Martin Luther's King Day, Washington's Birthday, Patriots' Day, Memorial Day, Bunker Hill Day, Independence Day, Labor Day, Columbus Day, Veteran's Day, Thanksgiving Day and Christmas Day

96 Grove Street Brookline, Massachusetts 02445-6863  
Telephone: (617) 730-2179 Facsimile: (617) 739-7580

# Arlington, MA

## Purchase of New Grave

|                                   |            |
|-----------------------------------|------------|
| Section A-Z                       | \$3,250.00 |
| Section AA-HH                     | 2,000.00   |
| Section A-Z - Regular Depth Only  | 2,000.00   |
| Section AA-HH- Regular Depth Only | 1,250.00   |
| *Section A-Z-Urn Grave            | 500.00     |
| *Section AA-HH- Urn Grave         | 350.00     |
| Perpetual Care                    | 500.00     |

## SERVICES

### Openings

|                                      |           |
|--------------------------------------|-----------|
| Earth                                | \$1000.00 |
| Cremains                             | 300.00    |
| Veterans Lot –Earth burial           | 500.00    |
| Veterans Urn Grave – Cremains burial | 200.00    |
| **Stillborn & Public Lot             | 150.00    |
| Mock Burial                          | 200.00    |

### Additional Charges for Saturday, Holiday and after 3:00 pm

|                 |          |
|-----------------|----------|
| Earth Burial    | \$800.00 |
| Cremains Burial | 500.00   |
| Mock Burial     | 400.00   |

### Non-Resident at time of Death

#### Earth Burial & Cremains **\$500.00**

|                                                                                                                     |                            |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------|
| ***Disinterment of                                                                                                  |                            |
| Body                                                                                                                | \$5,000.00 Disinterment of |
| Cremains                                                                                                            | 500.00                     |
| Recording Fee                                                                                                       | 100.00                     |
| Foundations (Flat Rate)                                                                                             | 200.00                     |
| Receiving                                                                                                           |                            |
| Vault                                                                                                               | 50.00                      |
| (1 <sup>st</sup> month or any part thereof, \$2.00 per day each month thereafter, not to exceed \$50.00 per month.) |                            |
| Use of Chapel for funeral                                                                                           | 100.00                     |
| Use of Chapel for other functions                                                                                   | 300.00                     |
| Bush Removal per Lot                                                                                                | 75.00                      |



Belmont Cemetery  
121 Grove Street  
Belmont, MA 02478

Highland Meadow Cemetery  
700 Concord Avenue  
Belmont, MA 02478

**Fees for Services Effective September 1, 2008**  
**Established by:**

**BOARD OF CEMETERY COMMISSIONERS**  
**BELMONT, MASSACHUSETTS 02478**  
**Telephone: 617-993-2710 or 617-489-8287**  
**Email:**

**Grave Openings:**

|                                                 |           |
|-------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| Casket, regular depth or deep.....              | \$1,200.  |
| Veterans' section at Belmont Cemetery only..... | 1,000.    |
| Cremation.....                                  | 375.      |
| Infant or child .....                           | no charge |
| Disinterment .....                              | 1600.     |

(For all disinterments, a Funeral Director must be engaged to ensure compliance with relevant Massachusetts laws.

Disinterments are permitted May 15<sup>th</sup> through November 1<sup>st</sup>.

If reinterred in a Belmont cemetery, grave opening fees will apply)

**Additional Fees:**

|                                                                                                     |                 |         |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|---------|
| Saturday or Holiday interment.....                                                                  | Casket.....     | \$ 500. |
|                                                                                                     | Cremation ..... | 300.    |
| Overtime fees for Late Notification when received after<br>Noon on Friday for Monday interment..... |                 | 500.    |
| Casket interments arriving at or after 1:30 p.m.....                                                |                 | 325.    |
| Non Resident* .....                                                                                 |                 | 375.    |

**Foundation Installations:**

|                                      |                    |
|--------------------------------------|--------------------|
| Belmont Cemetery .....               | \$ 60. Per sq. ft. |
| Highland Meadow Cemetery             |                    |
| Cremation lots.... (24" X 12") ..... | \$ 120.            |
| Single lot..... (30" X 15") .....    | 187.               |
| Double lot..... (42" X 15") .....    | 262.               |

\*Non-Resident fee will not be applied for a decedent who is a former Belmont resident who moved from Belmont directly to a nursing home, and death occurred within three years.

# Highland Meadow Cemetery Pricing

Effective 6-1-2015

## Single, Phase One lot Pricing

| Zone          | For<br>Casket<br>Burial | For<br>Cremation<br>Burial |
|---------------|-------------------------|----------------------------|
| Meadow Zone   | \$ 4,000                | \$ 1,300                   |
| Woodland Zone | \$ 6,000                | \$ 2,000                   |
| Orchard Zone  | \$ 8,000                | \$ 2,600                   |

*Many lots have double depth  
capacity for two casket interments.*

The Cambridge Cemetery Fees are as follows:

| <b>Prices effective April 15, 2023</b> | <b>Price</b>       |
|----------------------------------------|--------------------|
| Single Grave (2 interments)            | \$2,000.00         |
| Cremation Lot (4 Graves)               | \$640.00           |
| Cremation Lot (2 Graves)               | \$320.00           |
| Recording Deed                         | \$20.00            |
| Interments                             | \$1,500.00         |
| Cremation Interment                    | \$320.00           |
| Foundations                            | \$90.00 per sq. ft |
| Foundations Cremation Lots (2 Graves)  | \$65.00            |
| Perpetual Care (per grave)             | \$500.00           |
| Perpetual Care (Cremation Lot)         | \$100.00           |
| Veteran's Lot                          | No Charge          |
| Interment of child under 8             | \$200.00           |
| Stillborn - Public Lot                 | \$100.00           |
| Stillborn - Private Lot                | \$150.00           |
| Lowering of remains                    | \$520.00           |
| Disinterment                           | \$2,000.00         |
| Overtime (Weekday after 2:00 PM)       | \$300.00           |
| Weekend (7:00 AM - 11:00 AM)           | \$500.00           |
| Weekend (11:00 AM - 2:00 PM)           | \$600.00           |
| Shrub Removal                          | \$75.00            |
| Cremation Mock Setup                   | \$100.00           |



**TOWN OF LEXINGTON CEMETERY  
NEW RATES AND SERVICE FEES  
EFFECTIVE JULY 1, 2022**

**GRAVE SALES**

|                                                         | <b><u>FEE</u></b> |
|---------------------------------------------------------|-------------------|
| Sale of 1 (One) Regular Grave                           | \$2,120.00        |
| 45% = \$954.00 (Payable to Town of Lexington)           |                   |
| 55% = \$1,166.00 (Payable to Trustees of Public Trusts) |                   |
| Sale of 1 (One) Infant Grave                            | \$480.00          |
| 45% = \$216.00 (Payable to Town of Lexington)           |                   |
| 55% = \$264.00 (Payable to Trustees of Public Trusts)   |                   |

**BURIAL FEES FOR RESIDENTS**

|                         |            |
|-------------------------|------------|
| Grave Opening           | \$1,090.00 |
| Infant Grave Opening    | \$290.00   |
| Cremation Burial        | \$410.00   |
| Infant Cremation Burial | \$170.00   |
| Green Burial            | \$1,090.00 |

**BURIAL FEES FOR NON-RESIDENTS**

|                  |            |
|------------------|------------|
| Grave Opening    | \$1,490.00 |
| Cremation Burial | \$510.00   |
| Green Burial     | \$1,490.00 |

**GRAVE BOXES/VAULTS**

**PURCHASED FROM TOWN**

|                                     |          |
|-------------------------------------|----------|
| Grave Box, including Installation   | \$345.00 |
| Grave Vault, including Installation | \$550.00 |

**OR**

**PURCHASED FROM OUTSIDE VENDOR**

|                                |          |
|--------------------------------|----------|
| Normal Weekday Supervision Fee | \$80.00  |
| After Hours, Weekend & Holiday |          |
| Supervision Fee                | \$180.00 |
| Installation Fee               | \$260.00 |

**MARKERS, URNS AND TENT (optional)**

|                                        | <b><u>FEE</u></b> |
|----------------------------------------|-------------------|
| Regular Marker Installation (2'x1'x4") | \$216.00          |
| Marker Removal                         | \$100.00          |
| Infant Marker Installation (16"x8")    | \$96.00           |
| Bronze Urn Installation                | \$48.00           |
| Aluminum Urn Installation              | \$30.00           |
| Town's Galvanized Urn & Installation   | \$42.00           |
| Tent                                   | \$100.00          |

**DISINTERMENTS**

|                                     |          |
|-------------------------------------|----------|
| Disinterment for a Body Burial      | \$920.00 |
| Disinterment for a Cremation Burial | \$160.00 |

**ADDITIONAL FEES**

|                                                |          |
|------------------------------------------------|----------|
| Saturday Burial                                | \$360.00 |
| Sunday & Holiday Burial                        | \$450.00 |
| Burial called in after 11 a.m. on a Friday     | \$360.00 |
| For a Monday Burial or *Tuesday Burial         |          |
| (*if Monday is a holiday)                      |          |
| Funeral Arrives at Cemetery after 2 p.m.       | \$180.00 |
| On a Weekday                                   |          |
| Next Day Interment (Weekday)                   | \$180.00 |
| Only 24 Hour Notice for Saturday/Sunday Burial | \$360.00 |

**Westview Cemetery 781 861-2717 or 2718**

**Adopted by the Board of Selectmen on June 5, 2017**

**WALTHAM CEMETERY DIVISION  
PRICE OF LOTS, GRAVES & SERVICES  
Effective May 1, 2019**

**WALTHAM RESIDENTS ONLY**

**Single Grave**

|                       |          |
|-----------------------|----------|
| Adult                 | 1,700.00 |
| Infant (under 1 year) | 350.00   |
| Stillborn             | 350.00   |

**Lots**

|             |          |
|-------------|----------|
| Two-grave   | 2,500.00 |
| Three-grave | 3,400.00 |
| Four-grave  | 4,050.00 |
| Six-grave   | 5,150.00 |

|                   |        |
|-------------------|--------|
| <b>Urn Garden</b> | 950.00 |
|-------------------|--------|

|                    |          |
|--------------------|----------|
| <b>Columbarium</b> | 3,000.00 |
|--------------------|----------|

**Interments**

**No Interments after 1:30 P.M.**

|                                             |          |
|---------------------------------------------|----------|
| Adult - Including Grass and Lowering Device | 1,100.00 |
| Saturday or Holiday extra charge            | 800.00   |
| Welfare                                     | 350.00   |
| Child - Infant or Stillborn                 | 225.00   |

**Cremated Remains**

**No Interments after 1:30 P.M.**

|                                  |        |
|----------------------------------|--------|
| Adult                            | 500.00 |
| Niche                            | 400.00 |
| Saturday or Holiday extra charge | 400.00 |
| Welfare - Cremation              | 200.00 |
| Baby                             | 150.00 |

**Graveside Services**

|                                            |        |
|--------------------------------------------|--------|
| Service with no Attendant prior to service | 200.00 |
|--------------------------------------------|--------|

**Mock Set Up**

|                                                                        |        |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------|
| Setup body for a graveside service with removal for a future cremation | 300.00 |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------|

**Removals**

|                                                                                 |          |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| Removing remains from one grave and interring in another grave in same cemetery | 2,800.00 |
| Removing remains from a grave to be interred in another cemetery                | 2,000.00 |
| Removing or returning an urn from a niche                                       | 400.00   |

**Foundations**

|                 |        |
|-----------------|--------|
| Per square foot | 100.00 |
| Minimum         | 85.00  |

**Other Services**

|                          |        |
|--------------------------|--------|
| Remove Bushes            | 50.00  |
| Remove Trees             | 300.00 |
| Genealogy (by mail only) | 35.00  |



# CITY OF WATERTOWN

DEPARTMENT OF PUBLIC WORKS

124 ORCHARD STREET

WATERTOWN, MASSACHUSETTS 02472

Tel: 617-972-6420

Fax: 617-972-6402

**Gregory M. St. Louis**  
SUPERINTENDENT

## RIDGELAWN CEMETERY CEMETERY CHARGES

|                                                                           | Land                 | Perp. Care | Total Cost |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------|------------|------------|
| SINGLE GRAVE 2 INTERMENTS                                                 | \$1050.00            | \$350.00   | \$1400.00  |
| NON-RESIDENT CHARGE                                                       | \$200.00             |            |            |
| FROM NURSING HOME                                                         | No additional charge |            |            |
| INTERMENT OPENING COST                                                    | \$800.00             |            |            |
| <b>ADDITIONAL CHARGE<br/>FOR SATURDAY, HOLIDAYS<br/>AND AFTER 2:00 PM</b> | <b>\$500.00</b>      |            |            |
| DISINTERMENT                                                              | \$1200.00            |            |            |
| <b>ADDITIONAL CHARGE<br/>FOR SATURDAY, HOLIDAYS<br/>AND AFTER 2:00 PM</b> | <b>\$500.00</b>      |            |            |
| DISINTERMENT & REINTERMENT                                                | \$2000.00            |            |            |
| STILLBORN                                                                 | \$150.00             |            |            |
| CREMATION                                                                 | \$300.00             |            |            |
| SINGLE GRAVE TO DOUBLE                                                    | \$525.00             |            |            |
| MOCK FUNERAL                                                              | \$400.00             |            |            |

### MARKER SIZE AND PRICE:

|                                  |           |
|----------------------------------|-----------|
| SINGLE GRAVE LOT 2'0 X 1'0 X 3'0 | \$300.00  |
| TWO GRAVE LOT 3'0 X 1'0 X 3'0    | \$300.00  |
| FLUSH MARKER 2'0 X 1'0           | \$ 60.00  |
| FLUSH VETERAN MARKER             | NO CHARGE |

Checks payable to the City of Watertown

1 – Check for land and opening

1 – Check for perpetual care

**TOWN OF WESTON  
COMMONWEALTH OF MASSACHUSETTS**

**LINWOOD CEMETERY**

**HOURS OF OPERATION  
AND  
FEE STRUCTURE**

**Interment charges:**

|                     |                  | <b><u>Interment<br/>Fee</u></b> |
|---------------------|------------------|---------------------------------|
| <b><u>Adult</u></b> |                  |                                 |
| Monday - Friday     | 8 A.M to 2 P.M.* | \$700.00                        |
| Saturday            | 8 A.M to 12 P.M. | \$950.00                        |

|                      |                  |          |
|----------------------|------------------|----------|
| <b><u>Infant</u></b> |                  |          |
| Monday - Friday      | 8 A.M to 2 P.M.* | \$150.00 |
| Saturday             | 8 A.M to 12 P.M. | \$200.00 |

|                         |                  |          |
|-------------------------|------------------|----------|
| <b><u>Cremation</u></b> |                  |          |
| Monday - Friday         | 8 A.M to 2 P.M.* | \$250.00 |
| Saturday                | 8 A.M to 12 P.M. | \$300.00 |

|                                             |                  |          |
|---------------------------------------------|------------------|----------|
| <b><u>Cremation – Scattering Garden</u></b> |                  |          |
| Monday - Friday                             | 8 A.M to 2 P.M.* | \$125.00 |
| Saturday                                    | 8 A.M to 12 P.M. | \$150.00 |

**Disinterment:** Monday through Friday only. \$2000.00

**Frost Removal**

There will be a fee for the removal of frost when applicable: casket - \$150.00, cremains - \$50.00

Interments are not made on Sunday, nor the following holidays: New Years Day, Presidents Day, Memorial Day, July Fourth, Labor Day, Columbus Day, Thanksgiving Day, Christmas Day, Veteran's Day, Patriots Day, Martin Luther King Day, December 24 after 11 A.M. and December 31 after 11 A.M.

\*In the event that a funeral party arrives at the cemetery after 2:00 P.M. Monday through Friday, there will be a minimum overtime charge of \$50.00 per half-hour. Prior approval from the Cemetery Superintendent must be obtained for arrivals after 2:00 P.M. In no case shall a burial take place after 3:00 P.M.

**Prices of Lots and Graves:**

| <b>Plots</b>      | <b>Lot charge</b> | <b>Perpetual Care</b> | <b>Total</b> |
|-------------------|-------------------|-----------------------|--------------|
| 2 grave - casket  | \$1440.00         | \$960.00              | \$2400.00    |
| 4 grave - casket  | \$2880.00         | \$1920.00             | \$4800.00    |
| Cremation Lot     | \$1050.00         | \$700.00              | \$1750.00    |
| Scattering Garden | \$525.00          | \$350.00              | \$875.00     |
| Recording fee     | \$5.00            |                       |              |

**Monument Foundation Fee :** \$120.00 per square foot.

# Town of Winchester

## WILDWOOD CEMETERY



### RATES FOR GRAVE LOTS FY-23 SPLIT

|                                                | <u>Lot Value</u> | <u>Perm. Care</u> | <u>Total</u> |
|------------------------------------------------|------------------|-------------------|--------------|
| Single Grave, One Interment, Monument Area     | \$1,100.00       | \$1,100.00        | \$2,200.00   |
| Single Grave, Two Interments, Monument Area    | \$1,600.00       | \$1,600.00        | \$3,200.00   |
| Single Grave, One Interment, Flat Marker Area  | \$ 825.00        | \$ 825.00         | \$1,650.00   |
| Single Grave, Two Interments, Flat Marker Area | \$1,250.00       | \$1,250.00        | \$2,500.00   |
| Change Grave from single-depth to double depth |                  |                   | \$1,700.00   |

### DELL GRAVES

|                                     |            |
|-------------------------------------|------------|
| Garden Path Niche (holds 1-4 urns)  | \$5,050.00 |
| Garden Slope Niche (holds 1-4 urns) | \$4,150.00 |
| Garden Memorial Niche (1 urn)       | \$1,200.00 |

*A former long-time resident (10 years+) may (with proof of residency) purchase up to two graves (one double-depth grave or one inurnment niche) at the current price. If you did not live in Town for 10 yrs. + you will have to pay double the current price.*

### FOUNDATION FEES

|               |           |
|---------------|-----------|
| For monuments | \$ 175.00 |
| For markers   | \$ 125.00 |

**RATES EFFECTIVE: July 18, 2022 BY VOTE OF THE SELECT BOARD**

# Town of Winchester

## WILDWOOD CEMETERY



### RATES FOR INTERMENT SERVICES

|                       |            |            |            |
|-----------------------|------------|------------|------------|
| INTERMENT ADULT/YOUTH | Weekday    | \$1,000.00 | additional |
|                       | After 1 PM | \$ 200.00  |            |
|                       | Saturday   | \$1,500.00 |            |
|                       | Sunday*    | \$2,000.00 |            |
| STILLBORN             | Weekday    | \$ 175.00  |            |
| CREMATION             | Weekday    | \$ 300.00  | additional |
|                       | After 2 PM | \$ 100.00  |            |
|                       | Saturday   | \$ 400.00  |            |
|                       | Sunday*    | \$ 500.00  |            |

### NON-RESIDENT FEE

|                                            |           |            |
|--------------------------------------------|-----------|------------|
| Non-resident at time of demise (full size) | \$ 200.00 | additional |
| Non-resident at time of demise (cremation) | \$ 100.00 | additional |

### DIS-INTERMENT

|                                           |            |           |
|-------------------------------------------|------------|-----------|
| Relocate to another cemetery - full size  | \$1,500.00 |           |
| Relocate to another cemetery - ashes      | \$ 300.00  |           |
| Re-inter in Wildwood Cemetery - full size | \$2,300.00 |           |
| Re-inter in Wildwood Cemetery - ashes     | \$ 600.00  |           |
| RECEIVING TOMB RENTAL                     | \$ 75.00   | per month |

\*Sunday and Holiday burials must be approved by the Director of Public Works  
**Please make checks/money orders payable to the "Town of Winchester"**

# Town of Winchester

## WILDWOOD CEMETERY



### RATES FOR COLUMBARIUM NICHE WALL AND INURNMENTS

|                                                                                                    |            |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| Top Two Rows (2 urns)                                                                              | \$1,795.00 |
| Middle Two Rows (2 urns)                                                                           | \$1,695.00 |
| Bottom Two Rows (2 urns)                                                                           | \$1,595.00 |
| <i>* additional \$300 non-resident fee to purchase price<br/>(10yr minimum residency required)</i> | \$ 300.00  |
| Inurnment - Residents-weekday                                                                      | \$ 150.00  |
| Inurnment - Residents-Saturday                                                                     | \$ 225.00  |
| Non-Resident - Inurnment                                                                           | \$ 100.00  |
| Re-Opening of Niche regular hours only                                                             | \$ 100.00  |
| Sunday or Holiday/ <i>need approval from DPW</i>                                                   | \$ 300.00  |

- Pre-need ok, no more than (2) niches/per family for purchase
- Engraving must be approved by Cemetery Office

**Please make checks/money orders payable to the "Town of Winchester"**

*EFFECTIVE: November 1, 2015 BY VOTE OF SELECTMEN*

## WINCHESTER - Niches

### Dell Graves

|                                          |         |
|------------------------------------------|---------|
| Garden Path Niche (holds 1-4 urns).....  | \$5,050 |
| Garden Slope Niche (holds 1-4 urns)..... | \$4,150 |
| Garden Memorial Niche (holds 1 urn)..... | \$1,200 |

### Columbarium Niches

|                                          |         |
|------------------------------------------|---------|
| Top four rows.....                       | \$1,795 |
| Middle four rows.....                    | \$1,695 |
| Bottom four rows.....                    | \$1,595 |
| Additional fee for former residents..... | \$300   |

### Inurnments

|                                          |       |
|------------------------------------------|-------|
| Weekday opening.....                     | \$150 |
| Saturday opening .....                   | \$225 |
| Sunday opening.....                      | \$300 |
| Each additional opening of niche.....    | \$100 |
| Additional fee for former residents..... | \$100 |

*Effective November 1, 2015  
Winchester Board of Selectmen*

### Rules and Requirements

Niches may be purchased by Winchester residents and former Winchester residents. A resident of Winchester is someone who lives within the town, is currently paying taxes on real estate property in Winchester and is named in the current Town List of Residents. A former Winchester resident is someone who lived in the town for ten (10) or more years.

Each niche will house two (2) standard-size urns (each 12" by 8" maximum). Limit of two (2) niches per family. Niche purchase by appointment only.

Forty-eight hour notice required for all services; Sunday opening requires office approval. Cremation certificate or burial permit required for each inurnment. Must include properly completed interment order with each inurnment. Must include either check or money order payable to "Town Of Winchester" for the entire amount due with each inurnment.

Engraving on supplied niche-panel piece only. Engraving must be approved by Cemetery office. All engraving costs are the responsibility of the niche owner.

Wildwood Cemetery and the Dell are open daily from dawn to dusk.

Fastening or adhering objects on Niche Wall surface, including flower holders and emblems, is prohibited.

### Information

James Gill, DPW Director  
James T. Shattuck, Wildwood Cemetery Coordinator  
Office phone hours: Monday to Friday, 7:00 AM – 3:00 PM  
Office staffed: Tuesday and Thursday, 8:00 AM – 4:00 PM  
Office phone: (781) 721-7142  
Fax: (781)721-7143

| City / Town<br>Cemetery<br>Current prices effective: | BROOKLINE<br>Walnut Hills<br>2018                                                                                      | ARLINGTON<br>Mt. Pleasant<br>[2021 or earlier]                                                               | BELMONT<br>Highland Meadow<br>2015                                                                                                               | CAMBRIDGE<br>Cambridge Cem.                                                                        | LEXINGTON<br>Westview<br>2017                                                                                   | WALTHAM<br>Mt. Feake, Grove Hill<br>2019                                                                                       | WATERTOWN<br>Ridgelawn                                                                                                                   | WESTON<br>Linwood<br>[2021 or earlier]                                                                        | WINCHESTER<br>Wildwood<br>2022                                                                                 |
|------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Full-body burial,<br>upright marker                  | \$2,575 single<br>(depth for 2 burials?)<br>\$5,150 double<br>\$10,300 quad                                            | \$3,250* A-Z section<br>\$2,000* AA-HH section<br>\$2,000* AZ "regular depth"<br>\$1,250* AA-HH "reg. depth" | Not offered.                                                                                                                                     | \$2,000*<br>("two interments")                                                                     | \$2,120* (1 regular grave)                                                                                      | \$1,700 (single grave lot)<br>\$2,500 (2-grave lot)<br>\$3,400 (3-grave lot)<br>\$4,050 (4-grave lot)<br>\$5,150 (6-grave lot) | \$1,400* (1 grave, 2 burials)                                                                                                            | \$2,400* "2-grave"<br>\$4,800 "4-grave"                                                                       | \$3,200 (1 grave, 2 burials)<br>\$2,200* (1 grave, 1 burial)                                                   |
| Full-body burial,<br>flat marker                     | \$1,700<br>(depth for 2 burials?)                                                                                      | [this type not listed]                                                                                       | \$8,000 Orchard Zone<br>\$6,000 Woodland Zone<br>\$4,000 Meadow Zone                                                                             | [this type not listed]                                                                             | [Regulations say it's available,<br>but no separate price listed.]                                              | [this type not listed]                                                                                                         | [this type not listed]                                                                                                                   | [this type not listed]                                                                                        | \$2,500 (1 grave, 2 burials)<br>\$1,650* (1 grave, 1 burial)                                                   |
| Cremation lot,<br>flat marker                        | \$990<br>(# of burials in it?)                                                                                         | \$500* A-Z section<br>\$350* AA-HH section                                                                   | \$2,600 Orchard Zone<br>\$2,000 Woodland Zone<br>\$1,300 Meadow Zone                                                                             | \$640** (4 graves)<br>\$320** (2 graves)                                                           | [Mentioned only in schedule<br>of service fees; smaller lot<br>might not be offered.]                           | \$950 ("Urn Garden")                                                                                                           | [this type not listed]                                                                                                                   | 1750**                                                                                                        | \$1,200 (1 urn, Dell Memorial)<br>\$4,150 (1-4 urns, Dell Slope)<br>\$5,050 (1-4 urns, Dell Path)              |
| Columbarium                                          | -                                                                                                                      | -                                                                                                            | -                                                                                                                                                | -                                                                                                  | -                                                                                                               | \$3,000                                                                                                                        | -                                                                                                                                        | -                                                                                                             | \$1,795 (2 urns, top rows)<br>\$1,695 (2 urns, middle rows)<br>\$1,595 (2 urns, bottom rows)                   |
| Notes:                                               | Not listed above, because<br>no comparables elsewhere:<br>\$3,900 full-body, wall mem.<br>\$2,550 cremation, wall mem. | plus fee for perpetual care:<br>*\$500                                                                       | Above all "single" but "many<br>lots have double depth"<br>Older cemetery, on Grove St.,<br>sold out in 1988; Highland<br>Meadow opened in 2007. | plus fees for perpetual care<br>and recording deed:<br>*\$520 (\$500 + 20)<br>**\$120 (\$100 + 20) | *Lot cost split:<br>45% to Town of Lexington<br>55% to Trustees of Public Tr.<br><br>Green Burial also offered. | -                                                                                                                              | *of which land is \$1,050,<br>perpetual care is \$350<br><br>Scattering garden offered for<br>cremated remains, @ \$875<br>(\$525 + 350) | *of which lot is \$1,440,<br>perpetual care is \$960<br>**of which lot is \$1,050,<br>perpetual care is \$700 | *1,700 to change single-depth<br>to double depth<br>Costs split 50-50 between<br>lot value and permanent care. |

Other nearby municipalities with apparently no active public cemetery:

Newton  
Wellesley  
Milton  
Needham  
Dedham  
Natick

|                                             |                    |                  | year      | 2010     | 2011 | 2012 | 2013     | 2014 | 2015     | % increase              | 2016    | 2017      | 2018     | % increase              | 2019 | 2020 | 2021 | 2022 | 2023 | 2024 | For total increase 2018 to 2024 (six years): |          |               |        |
|---------------------------------------------|--------------------|------------------|-----------|----------|------|------|----------|------|----------|-------------------------|---------|-----------|----------|-------------------------|------|------|------|------|------|------|----------------------------------------------|----------|---------------|--------|
|                                             |                    |                  | effective | 15-Jul   |      |      | 1-Jul    |      | 1-Jan    | from 2010:<br>(5 years) | 1-Jul   | 1-Jan     | 1-Jul    | from 2015:<br>(3 years) |      |      |      |      |      |      | 1%                                           | 2%       | 3%            | annual |
|                                             |                    |                  |           |          |      |      |          |      |          |                         |         |           |          |                         |      |      |      |      |      | 6.2% | 12.6%                                        | 19.4%    | 6-yr compound |        |
| Burial Lots                                 |                    |                  |           |          |      |      |          |      |          |                         |         |           |          |                         |      |      |      |      |      |      |                                              |          |               |        |
| type                                        | # graves           | marker           |           |          |      |      |          |      |          |                         |         |           |          |                         |      |      |      |      |      |      |                                              |          |               |        |
| full-body                                   | single             | upright          |           |          |      |      |          |      |          |                         |         |           |          |                         |      |      |      |      |      |      |                                              |          |               |        |
| full-body                                   | double             | upright          |           | \$5,000  |      |      | \$5,000  |      | \$5,000  |                         |         | \$5,000   | \$5,150  | 3%                      |      |      |      |      |      |      | \$5,467                                      | \$5,800  | \$6,149       |        |
| ful-body                                    | quad               | upright          |           | \$10,000 |      |      | \$10,000 |      | \$10,000 |                         |         | \$10,000  | \$10,300 | 3%                      |      |      |      |      |      |      | \$10,934                                     | \$11,599 | \$12,299      |        |
| full-body                                   | single             | flat             |           | \$1,500  |      |      | \$1,500  |      | \$1,650  | 10%                     |         | \$1,650   | \$1,700  | 3%                      |      |      |      |      |      |      | \$1,805                                      | \$1,914  | \$2,030       |        |
| cremated                                    | single             | flat             |           | \$990    |      |      | \$990    |      | \$990    |                         |         | \$990     | \$990    |                         |      |      |      |      |      |      | \$1,051                                      | \$1,115  | \$1,182       |        |
| cremated                                    | 12 ("6-grave lot") | flat             |           | \$6,000  |      |      |          |      |          |                         |         |           |          |                         |      |      |      |      |      |      |                                              |          |               |        |
| full body                                   | single             | wall             |           | \$3,600  |      |      | \$3,600  |      | \$3,800  | 6%                      |         | \$3,800   | \$3,900  | 3%                      |      |      |      |      |      |      | \$4,140                                      | \$4,392  | \$4,657       |        |
| cremated                                    | single             | wall             |           | \$2,400  |      |      | \$2,400  |      | \$2,550  | 6%                      |         | \$2,550   | \$2,550  |                         |      |      |      |      |      |      | \$2,707                                      | \$2,872  | \$3,045       |        |
| Veteran Lot                                 |                    |                  |           |          |      |      |          |      |          |                         |         |           |          |                         |      |      |      |      |      |      |                                              |          |               |        |
| full-body                                   | single             | flat             |           |          |      |      |          |      |          |                         |         | no charge |          |                         |      |      |      |      |      |      |                                              |          |               |        |
| cremated                                    | single             | [flat]           |           |          |      |      |          |      |          |                         |         | no charge |          |                         |      |      |      |      |      |      |                                              |          |               |        |
| Grave Opening                               |                    |                  |           |          |      |      |          |      |          |                         |         |           |          |                         |      |      |      |      |      |      |                                              |          |               |        |
| full-body                                   |                    | M-F 7:30-3:30    |           | \$1,050  |      |      | \$1,050  |      | \$1,200  | 14%                     | \$1,200 | \$1,200   | \$1,250  | 4%                      |      |      |      |      |      |      | \$1,327                                      | \$1,408  | \$1,493       |        |
| full-body                                   |                    | M-F after 3:30   |           | \$1,700  |      |      | \$1,700  |      | \$1,900  | 12%                     | \$1,900 | \$1,900   | \$2,000  | 5%                      |      |      |      |      |      |      | \$2,123                                      | \$2,252  | \$2,388       |        |
| full-body                                   |                    | Sat & Holidays   |           | \$1,700  |      |      | \$1,700  |      | \$1,900  | 12%                     | \$1,900 | \$1,900   | \$2,000  | 5%                      |      |      |      |      |      |      | \$2,123                                      | \$2,252  | \$2,388       |        |
| full-body                                   |                    | Sunday           |           | \$1,700  |      |      | \$2,000  |      | \$2,200  | 10%                     | \$2,200 | \$2,200   | \$2,300  | 5%                      |      |      |      |      |      |      | \$2,441                                      | \$2,590  | \$2,746       |        |
| urn grave                                   |                    | M-F 7:30-3:30    |           | \$550    |      |      | \$550    |      | \$600    | 9%                      | \$600   | \$600     | \$620    | 3%                      |      |      |      |      |      |      | \$658                                        | \$698    | \$740         |        |
| urn grave                                   |                    | M-F after 3:30   |           | \$840    |      |      | \$840    |      | \$900    | 7%                      | \$900   | \$900     | \$930    | 3%                      |      |      |      |      |      |      | \$987                                        | \$1,047  | \$1,110       |        |
| urn grave                                   |                    | Sat-Sun-Holidays |           | \$840    |      |      | \$840    |      | \$900    | 7%                      | \$900   | \$900     | \$930    | 3%                      |      |      |      |      |      |      | \$987                                        | \$1,047  | \$1,110       |        |
|                                             |                    |                  |           |          |      |      |          |      |          |                         |         |           |          |                         |      |      |      |      |      |      |                                              |          |               |        |
| Disinterment                                |                    |                  |           | \$2,000  |      |      | \$2,000  |      | \$2,200  | 10%                     | \$2,200 | \$2,200   | \$2,300  | 5%                      |      |      |      |      |      |      | \$2,441                                      | \$2,590  | \$2,746       |        |
| Foundation Setting for Headstones, per s.f. |                    |                  |           | \$140    |      |      | \$140    |      | \$155    | 11%                     | \$155   | \$155     | \$160    | 3%                      |      |      |      |      |      |      | \$170                                        | \$180    | \$191         |        |
| Flat Marker Setting, per s.f.               |                    |                  |           | \$140    |      |      | \$140    |      | \$155    | 11%                     | \$155   | \$155     | \$160    | 3%                      |      |      |      |      |      |      | \$170                                        | \$180    | \$191         |        |

For total increase 2018 to 2024 (six years):

1% 2% 3% annual  
6.2% 12.6% 19.4% 6-yr compound

|          |          |          |
|----------|----------|----------|
| \$5,467  | \$5,800  | \$6,149  |
| \$10,934 | \$11,599 | \$12,299 |
| \$1,805  | \$1,914  | \$2,030  |
| \$1,051  | \$1,115  | \$1,182  |
| \$4,140  | \$4,392  | \$4,657  |
| \$2,707  | \$2,872  | \$3,045  |

|         |         |         |
|---------|---------|---------|
| \$1,327 | \$1,408 | \$1,493 |
| \$2,123 | \$2,252 | \$2,388 |
| \$2,123 | \$2,252 | \$2,388 |
| \$2,441 | \$2,590 | \$2,746 |
| \$658   | \$698   | \$740   |
| \$987   | \$1,047 | \$1,110 |
| \$987   | \$1,047 | \$1,110 |

|         |         |         |
|---------|---------|---------|
| \$2,441 | \$2,590 | \$2,746 |
| \$170   | \$180   | \$191   |
| \$170   | \$180   | \$191   |



**TOWN of BROOKLINE**  
*Massachusetts*  
**Walnut Hills Cemetery**  
**Old Burying Ground**

**Trustees**

*Randolph Meiklejohn, Chair*  
*Lisa Farber*  
*Gerry Hayes*  
*Peggy Maguire*  
*Joslin Ham Murphy*

**Parks and Open Space Division**

*Alexandra Vecchio, Director*

**MEMORANDUM**

Date: December 5, 2023  
From: Randolph Meiklejohn, chair  
To: Trustees  
Cc: Alexandra Vecchio  
Re: Green burial study materials

This is an overview of the study materials on green burial that I have collected and am asking you all to read over the next few months. The topic has come up occasionally in our recent meetings and some of you have asked that we discuss it. In review of past meetings I found a mention of it in our March 10, 2021 minutes, by Commissioner Erin Chute, when she spoke in that meeting about future cemetery expansion and about the Town's evolving cemetery management practices.

Green burial is a relatively complex topic and I would like all the trustees to become more knowledgeable about it before we discuss its possible introduction at Walnut Hills. Given that Town staff are focused on basic operations at Walnut Hills while we have no cemetery supervisor, the trustees will have time in the near future for this learning. After our October meeting I looked for green burial resources available online, and the second page of this memo gives a short description of the ten that I have chosen. I will work with staff to get the digest of .pdf files distributed to you after the December meeting.

Your learning assignments:

- 1) Read documents 1 through 6, and have a look at the websites numbered 7, 8 and 9. If I can find a copy of #10, which is a book, I'll read it and see whether it's worth sharing.
- 2) On your own, find another publication, article or resource about green burial, if you can, to share with other trustees
- 3) On your own, visit a cemetery that has implemented green burial; take photographs and collect any other information you can (site plans, policies, pricing, management practices). This is probably best done in spring-summer-fall of 2024. I visited one in April 2023, at Green-Wood, a historic private cemetery in Brooklyn NY. Locally, Mt. Auburn Cemetery offers green burials as does the municipal Westview Cemetery in Lexington.

At our March 2024 meeting, let's plan to check in on how our study and research on this topic is going.

## GREEN BURIAL STUDY MATERIALS

1. “Frequently Asked Questions about Green Burial”, Green Burial Council, Inc., 2019. Seven pages. The Green Burial Council is a “dot-org” consisting of two non-profit entities. One is a 501-c-6 certification organization and standards publisher for the industry; the other is a 501-c-3 educational and outreach organization. Website: [greenburialcouncil.org](http://greenburialcouncil.org)
  2. “Offering Green Burial Options in Your Hybrid Cemetery”, Green Burial Council Inc. (Lee Webster), 2019-2022. Twelve pages of overview, and seven pages of “Hybrid Cemetery FAQs”. Offered on the GBC website thus: *“If you are a cemetery trustee, member of a cemetery or historical commission, selectman, town clerk, city registrar, town or city planner, public works superintendent, or county official in some capacity that oversees cemeteries, this is the how-to for you.”*
  3. “Green Burial in Massachusetts: Questions and Answers”, Green Burial Massachusetts, Inc, 2023. Two pages. GBM is a ‘statewide all-volunteer 501-c-3 nonprofit (as of 2016) whose guiding principle is to restore death to its rightful place in the cycle of life.’ Offices in Greenfield.
  4. “Natural Burials: Guidelines for Natural Burial at Mount Auburn Cemetery”, 8-page brochure. MAC, in Cambridge, was the first Massachusetts cemetery certified (2014) by the Green Burial Council. Website: [mountauburn.org/natural-burial](http://mountauburn.org/natural-burial).
  5. “Glossary of Green Burial Terms”, Green Burial Council, 2015. Seven pages.
  6. “Examples of Green Burial Rules in Massachusetts”, compiled June 2023 by Green Burial Massachusetts; ten pages. A digest of local regulations from fourteen Massachusetts municipalities, mostly small and/or rural ones, except for Lexington (Westview Cemetery, public), and Cambridge (Mt. Auburn Cemetery, private).
- Other information:
7. “Massachusetts Rules and Regulations” page of Green Burial Massachusetts website. This page includes links to five different areas of the Commonwealth of Massachusetts website [Mass.gov](http://Mass.gov), on topics related to cemeteries, burials, funerals etc.
  8. New Hampshire Funeral Resources and Education website, at [nhfuneral.org](http://nhfuneral.org). This website appears to feature mostly the advocacy and education work of executive director Lee Webster, self-described as a funeral reform advocate. She was past president of the Green Burial Council, among other leadership roles.
  9. Green Burial Massachusetts, Inc. “Reclaiming a Dying Tradition” overview at website home page. This site is the source of document #6 above; here is a two-page FAQ sheet and there is more on the site’s other pages. Website: [greenburialma.org](http://greenburialma.org)
  10. Changing Landscapes: Exploring the growth of ethical, compassionate, and environmentally sustainable green funeral practices. Book compiled and edited by Lee Webster; 292 pages. (Some content is available also for download from GBC website Publications page.) Available on Amazon in paperback.



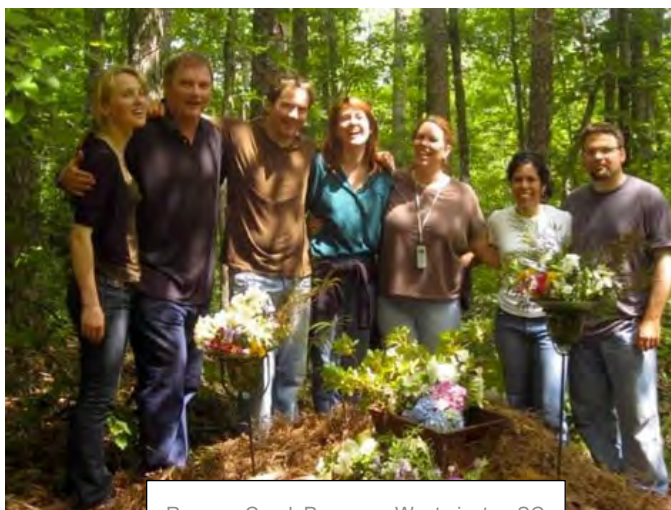
## Frequently Asked Questions About Green Burial

### Q. Is there a universal definition of green burials?

A. The Green Burial Council provides nuanced definitions of green burial in its [Glossary of Green Burial Terms](#). These terms have been devised and evaluated by leaders in the field at all levels. In terms of certification, each level—hybrid, natural, and conservation—must meet specific standards to qualify.

### Q. How can bodies be properly prepared for burial and what is a home funeral?

A. Home funerals, which allow for families to care for a decedent and all aspects of a funeral at home until the 1930s. Home funerals find family and friends, next of kin, or a legally designated agent retaining custody and control of the body for the time period between death and disposition (burial or cremation). This is sometimes referred to as *home vigil* or DIY funeral. A home funeral involves bathing and dressing the body and using dry ice, Techni-ice, or other cooling mechanism as a preservative; it commonly lasts 1-3 days. A *home funeral guide* may provide education and support either prior to or during this time period. It's important to care for the body using these techniques prior to burial. For more information, go to the [National Home Funeral Alliance](#).



Ramsey Creek Preserve, Westminster, SC

### Q. What are blended funerals?

A. Funerals that combine conventional funeral practices with home funeral and/or green burial practices; may include the use of a funeral director for certain aspects of care, such as obtaining, completing and filing paperwork or transporting the body. Families may have a home funeral without having a green burial and visa versa. Blended funerals offer families more options, especially when certain options are not available in their area. Most all GBC-approved funeral homes accommodate families wanting home funerals.

### Q. What is a home burial?

A. A home burial is exactly what it sounds like—a burial on a family's property. Home burials are legal in all but Arkansas, California, Indiana, Louisiana, Washington state, and the District of Columbia, with some states stating that burials must be in established cemeteries; however, one can establish a family cemetery on one's own property by following state and local regulations and/or filing for a special exception in all of these restrictive states except DC. Burial in a family cemetery on private property is limited to family members only. To learn more about state by state requirements, go to [Legal Requirements by State](#).

**Q. How is a grave liner different from a vault?**

**A.** A grave liner covers the sides and top of the casket where a vault is significantly more substantial, acting as a box for the box. Both are classified as outer burial containers. Neither is required by law, though cemeteries often require them to avoid grave subsidence. Neither is permitted in a green burial cemetery of any kind, as they both impede natural decomposition and introduce non-biodegradable materials into the earth.

**Q. What about inverting the outer container?**

**A.** Called 'butterdishing', this method may allow the body to be closer to the earth on the bottom surface, but still impedes and puts non-biodegradable artifacts in the ground. It is not an acceptable alternative to going without.

**Q. Since burial vaults are made from concrete, shouldn't they be considered green?**

**A.** While the concrete and metal in vaults may be considered "natural" to some, the manufacturing and transporting of vaults uses a tremendous amount of energy and causes significant carbon emission. In the US, vault manufacturing requires the production of 1.6 tons of reinforced concrete annually. No state or province legally requires vault purchase to implementation—individual cemeteries determine their own vault requirements.

**Q. What is required for a shroud burial? And are burial garments required?**

**A.** A shroud burial is usually just that — a body wrapped in a biodegradable shroud lowered into a grave. While burial garments may be used, often by followers of certain religious customs, they are neither required or discouraged as a matter of course. Some shroud burials also include a casket for ease of processions and lowering, but the main determining factor is the cemetery's own policy and guidelines, usually written into their bylaws.

**Q. How does a shrouded body get carried to the grave?**

**A.** Many cemeteries have a vehicle for moving shrouded and casketed bodies, including retrofitted golf carts, wagons, trailers, or other wheeled conveyances. Some families choose to conduct a procession with pall bearers, either on shoulder for a casket or with carrying handles on a shrouding board for shroud burials. (See [Opening, Closing and Maintenance of a Green Burial Grave](#))

**Q. How and who lowers the body?**

**A.** This depends on how the individual cemetery chooses to handle family participation and what mechanical devices are available. Some cemeteries continue to use excavators for digging and hydraulic machinery for lowering, while others pay employees to hand dig graves and allow the family, with direction if necessary, to lower the body themselves using shrouding boards, straps, or ropes. Sometimes family members wish to dig the grave themselves. Green burial operators should expect more family participation and be prepared with appropriate equipment—and liability waiver agreements built into their contract for services. (See [Opening, Closing and Maintenance of a Green Burial Grave](#))

**Q. What protects the cemetery from liability claims for injuries incurred during carrying, digging, lowering, and closing the grave?**

**A.** It is wise to require the next-of-kin to sign a liability waiver that indemnifies the cemetery and all of its employees from responsibility for injuries of anyone in their party during the funeral. This can be simple language included in the contract or a stand-alone agreement that is witnessed if possible. It is good practice to provide written instructions and warnings in a guidebook designed to educate the

family about cemetery rules and best practices when purchasing the plot and/or arranging the burial. (Coming soon [Sample Guidebook for Hybrid Cemetery Operators](#))

**Q. How deep does one place the body?**

**A.** Burial depth differs by state. For a comprehensive list by state of this and other requirements, go to [Legal Requirements by State](#). As a general rule, the ideal burial depth for optimal decomposition conditions is 3.5 – 4 feet from the bottom of the grave to the soil horizon, which also guarantees an 18-24 inch smell barrier that prevents animals, two and four legged both, from being able to smell anything. By adding the displaced soil to the top of the grave in a mound, that depth is doubled until it gradually settles.



From the Milwaukee Journal, 2.27.19  
Photo permission courtesy of Rick Rommel

**Q. What if the body is in bad condition?**

**A.** Included in the contract and/or guidebook should be explicit guidelines for the condition of the body when presented for burial, with the clear understanding that they will be turned away if those conditions are not met. Many families hire funeral directors for body preparation so it would be the professional's job to repair any damage or rectify any issues. If the family is in charge, bodies will most likely be coming for burial in a short enough period of time that these scenarios are unlikely, but if there were a problem, it would be their responsibility to address it by whatever means necessary. (Coming soon [Sample Guidebook](#))

**Q. Does the GBC recommend removing pacemakers, plates, screws, joint replacement hardware, gold or amalgam fillings or even metal zippers or buttons prior to burial?**

**A.** The GBC leaves it to individual cemeteries to determine what is required. However, we do advise that consideration be given to the invasive nature of removing any of these items from a body and balancing that with the potential for environmental damage.

**Q. Won't wild animals dig up corpses?**

**A.** No. Burials occur 3.5 feet under the ground with, at minimum, an 18-inch smell barrier. Animals are much more interested in living prey above ground than in working that hard. We're just not that delicious. (See [Real Answers to Questions Real People Ask](#))

**Q. Won't we be able to smell them?**

**A.** No. Same principles apply. And remember this from 5thgrade science? Humans have a dismal sense of smell compared to animals. If they can't detect bodies by scent, we surely won't be able to either. Wild boar are the most deep-digging of all wildlife and they typically max out at 12 inches. They are usually more interested in investigating the freshly turned soil and marking their territory. (See [Real Answers to Questions Real People Ask](#))

**Q. Do green burials contaminate the water table or drinking water?**

**A.** No. With burials at 3.5 feet deep, there is no danger of contaminating potable water that is found about 75 feet below the surface. Mandatory setbacks from known water sources also ensure that surface water is not at risk. (See [The Science Behind Green Burial](#))

**Q. Do unembalmed bodies pollute the ground with chemo or other drugs?**

**A.** Soil is the best natural filter there is, binding organic compounds and making them unable to travel. Microorganisms in the soil break down any chemical compounds that remain in the body. We lose more toxic chemicals during a day of living than a whole body will decomposing. A 2018 Recompose study done by the University of Washington found that chemicals, heavy metals, and other potential biochemical concerns met or exceeded EPA levels by a significant margin. Additionally, embalming does not remove toxins from anywhere in the body except the fluids that are removed during the process.

**Q. How long does it take for a body to completely decompose?**

**A.** Depending on soil type, oxygen availability, and moisture present, it takes on average 6 weeks to lose the majority of soft tissue through moisture absorption by the soil, and up to 2 years for complete decomposition. It may take up to twenty years for bones to absorb in moist soils. (See [The Science Behind Green Burial](#))

**Q. What soil conditions are the most favorable for green burial?**

**A.** Well drained soils with some clay content to absorb organic compounds, and an active biological presence of bacteria are ideal for promoting efficient decomposition. This allows for aerobic decay, followed by anaerobic decay, resulting in rich soils high in nitrogen content and organic compounds. (See [The Science Behind Green Burial](#))

**Q. Can bodies be buried in winter?**

**A.** Depending on frost levels and previous preparation of the gravesite, burial in winter is feasible. Various methods are available for snow removal and thawing ground in cold climates, including coal fires, use of heaters, and thermal blankets. Often digging graves ahead of time and filling them with straw, compost, or other organic material and then capping it for easy removal at need works well. (See [Opening, Closing and Maintenance of a Green Burial Grave](#))

**Q. What is done in the winter time if the cemetery is closed?**

**A.** Burials in cemeteries that choose not to bury in winter may have systems and facilities that house bodies until spring burial. All bodies respond well to being kept cool for the time needed, whether in a mausoleum, below grade facility, or other means of consistent cool temperatures. (See [Opening, Closing and Maintenance of a Green Burial Grave](#))

**Q. How close together should graves be dug?**

**A.** Burial density depends primarily on the type of cemetery and its space availability, and on the amount of burial land on the property that is usable. Wetlands, steep slopes, animal game trails and habitat, pristine areas, protected and sensitive flora areas, trees, boulders, and other factors mapped out during a Natural Resources Inventory will affect the total acreage practical for burial. Areas slated for restoration are also going to be off the table, at least for some period of time. Originally 20' x 20' for a gravesite was thought to be a reasonable guideline, but as we have had more experience we've

realized that footage can be significantly smaller, more in the range of 8-9' x 4'. Time is the second major factor. Somewhere in the region of 300 burials per open and unimpeded acre over a hundred year period would be the maximum; but more reasonably, it would be much less given the above considerations. Bottom line is that the land will determine the density on your specific property.

**Q. How does one mark the actual burial spot?**

**A.** Ideally, graves are marked by GPS, but these systems can be costly. Corner markers made of stone are acceptable, as are flat markers at the head. Metal spikes could be buried near the surface to allow a metal detector to locate the perimeter of the grave, a more cost-effective and durable method, depending on the metal used. Some other type of physical marker is possible as well, such as native plants, trees or shrubs, or a plain or engraved fieldstone.

**Q. What about memorialization?**

**A.** Green burial sections do not allow upright monuments. Instead, a flat marker, usually made of native stone, is at the head. Using concrete to set stones is frowned upon in a green section, as concrete has its own significant environmental downsides. Flat markers make finding the grave and mowing the area relatively easy. Maintenance consists of removing overgrowth, if wished. Some cemeteries choose to have no physical markers yet include the person's name and dates on a central cenotaph at the entrance. Some cemeteries allow installation art pieces situated throughout the cemetery.



Prairie Creek Conservation Cemetery, Gainesville, FL  
Photo courtesy of Melissa Hill

**Q. How are vaultless burials disinterred?**

**A.** Families are asked to sign a contract stating that they understand that their family member will not be disinterred unless legally ordered to do so by the State, and that the family will be responsible for any costs not born by the State should this be ordered. Good records and physical indicators of the perimeter are critical, though the shorter burial depth and proper preparation of the grave with evergreen boughs, compost, or other organic material may provide a soil roadmap.

**Q. What about grave robbing?**

**A.** Grave robbing as a way to make extra cash by providing cadavers for medical study ended by the early 1900's. Body donations now provide plenty for a variety of scientific research. Given the superstitions ingrained in us, plus the significant repercussions for violating anti-desecration laws, grave robbing has not been reported in decades in any cemetery, no less a green burial one. Additionally, if the grave is 3.5 -4 feet deep and the displaced soil is mounded above by 3-4 feet, it's highly unlikely that anyone is going to bother and mess. By the time the body has decomposed and it's down to bones, the grave may be pretty well blended into the environment. If concerned, consider locating the green

burial area nearer a central location instead of the periphery.

**Q. What do green burial plots cost?**

**A.** Green burial plots need not be different from conventional plot pricing. Although there is maintenance for both, it is different, not necessarily more or less intensive. In fact, not having to haul around heavy equipment, spread herbicides, pesticides, and fertilizers, mow and trim, or clean and repair headstones could mean big savings on perpetual care. What green burial families are paying for is the same thing anyone else is: real estate in a specific location. Whatever the going rate is in your cemetery or general region for a plot should apply universally.

**Q. Do green cemeteries reuse burial plots?**

**A.** There are no laws against reusing a plot. In many countries, graves are routinely “rented” and refilled at a later date, often removing the bones to an ossuary. Green burial cemeteries have the ability to reuse ground space in the future if desired.

**Q. Can cremated remains be scattered in green burial cemeteries?**

**A.** Because of the density and nonbiodegradable content of cremated remains, many green burial cemeteries do not allow scattering. Cremated remains consist of calcium phosphate and sodium and are heavy, apt to smother foliage on the surface. Underground cremated remains create what is essentially a nutrient-deficient salt lick that has no environmental benefits.

**Q. What does it mean if a cemetery is Green Burial Council certified?**

**A.** GBC certification allows consumers to be able to distinguish between the three types of cemeteries and understand that each has a different set of standards. It requires cemetery operators commit to a certain degree of transparency, accountability and third party oversight. And it prevents future owners from going back on whatever ecological or aesthetic promises have been made in the past, from limitations to burial density that protect a local ecosystem to prohibitions against the use of monuments that would negatively impact views. For more information on certifying with the GBC, go to [Why Certification Matters](#) and [Become Certified](#).

**Q. What's wrong with embalming?**

**A.** The Council does not think any end-of-life ritual, form of disposition, or mode of post-mortem preparation is "wrong". We are simply advocating for green services and products that help to minimize the environmental impact of our last acts. Embalming fluid is usually comprised of the carcinogen chemical formaldehyde, which has been proven to pose health risks in funeral homes. A [study by the National Cancer Institute released in late 2009](#) revealed that funeral directors have a much higher incidence of myeloid leukemia. Another study completed in 2015 by the [Journal of Neurology, Neurosurgery & Psychiatry](#) indicates a three times higher incidence of ALS, Lou Gherig's Disease, than in the general public. And the National Funeral Directors Association recently published NFDA Environmental Compliance officer Carol Lynn Green's opinion piece [Excising a Health Risk](#) where she predicts the end to embalming for safety reasons.

**Q. What about essential oils and green embalming fluid?**

**A.** Fortunately, there are now several formaldehyde-free embalming fluids, including one made entirely of nontoxic and biodegradable essential oils, which recently earned the GBC seal of approval. The sanitation and preservation of a decedent can almost always take place without the use of chemicals, as is done in just about every nation in the world. To find a green embalmer, go to [Funeral Home Providers](#) to locate a certified funeral director near you, or go to [Product Providers](#) to inquire of a product manufacturer.

**Q. How do I know that a particular product is suitable for a green burial?**

**A.** The GBC believes a casket, urn, or shroud is suitable for a green burial if it is made from materials and substances that are nontoxic and readily biodegradable. We also require that these products not be made from materials that are harvested in a manner that unnecessarily destroys habitat. See [Product Providers](#) before purchasing any green funeral product.

**Q. Doesn't cremation create a lot of pollution?**

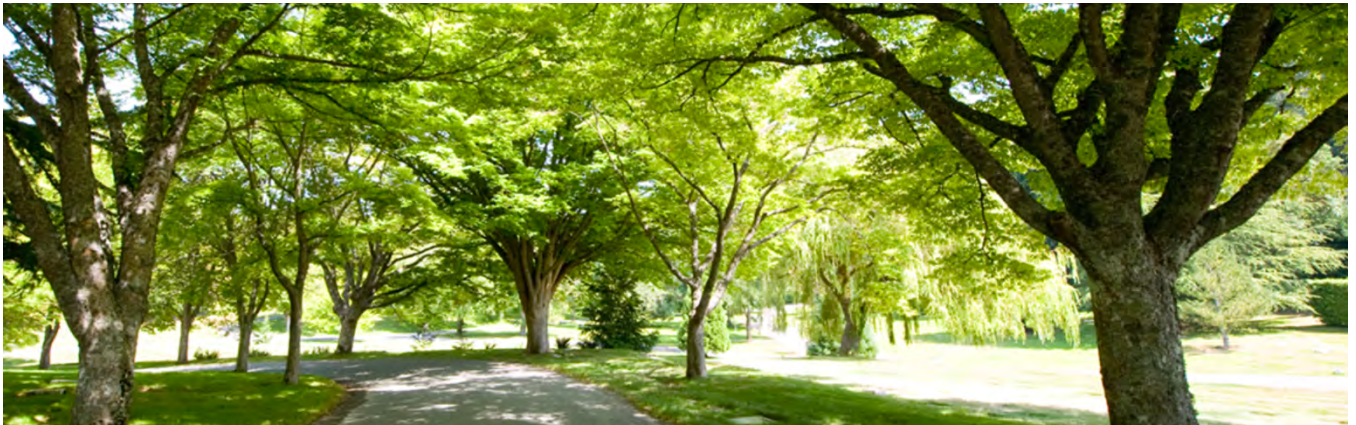
**A.** Cremation uses far fewer resources than conventional lawn burial with a vault but it certainly has an environmental impact. Cremation burns fossil fuels, and some older cremation facilities can use significantly more energy compared to newer ones. Mercury is also emitted when a person with dental amalgam fillings is cremated, but filtration devices that can fully mitigate mercury pollution have not been invented yet. While no standards yet exist that allow consumers to determine which cremation retorts produce fewer pollution and carbon emissions, there are several things that can be done to offset the carbon footprint of cremation, such as recycling medical parts, making a contribution to a carbon fund, or supporting ocean reef regrowth.

**Q. Why don't you certify cremation disposition programs?**

**A.** While a cremation disposition program may provide benefit by setting ecologically responsible standards for memorial reefs and scattering grounds, the amount of resources and effort required to responsibly establish and manage such programs come at the cost of utilizing resources to further the organization's main objectives: to encourage environmentally sustainable deathcare through its funeral home and product compliance program, and to preserve natural areas through green burial via its burial compliance program. Accordingly, we currently do not have a cremation disposition certification program.



# **Offering Green Burial Options in Your Hybrid Cemetery**



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# Offering Green Burial Options in Municipal Cemeteries

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## Introduction

If you are a cemetery trustee, member of a cemetery or historical commission, selectman, town clerk, city registrar, town or city planner, public works superintendent, or county official in some capacity that oversees cemeteries, it is likely that you will be approached about green burial if you haven't been already.

The materials included in this packet are intended to help orient you to the facts around green burial as a starting place for considering adding options in the area under your care. Many of the materials included here are in the public domain, developed for the Green Burial Council and published on their website [greenburialcouncil.org](https://greenburialcouncil.org) and in the book *Changing Landscapes: Exploring the growth of ethical, compassionate, and environmentally sustainable green funeral service* compiled and edited by Lee Webster for the GBC, available at Amazon.com.

Given the rapid rise in interest, many municipal officials feel unprepared to answer questions. They may be challenged by citizens with little knowledge of the concerns and responsibilities that officials, elected or otherwise, face while stewarding their town's cemeteries within the confines of budget, space, real estate values, mandatory state law, and various restrictions.

The following is also intended to address green burial from your point of view while exploring where there may be common ground that benefits both residents and town government. We understand that state and local laws and regulations vary, so please take what applies and is helpful and leave the rest.

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## Who Wants Green Burial?

In May of 2021, Kates-Boylston, publishers of several mainstream professional funeral magazines, released their most recent study that identified more than 91% of respondents as interested in more environmentally friendly funerals and burials, with a whopping 84.4% saying they would choose natural burial if it was available. The same study conducted in 2008 had indicated 43% interested.

In an earlier 2018 survey by the National Funeral Directors Association, "Just over half of respondents (53.8 percent) said they would be interested in exploring green memorialization options to reduce the environmental impact of end-of-life rituals." A similar study by AARP in 2007 had indicated 42% of those

canvassed were interested in green burial. Interestingly, 64% indicated interest in a FAMIC Harris Poll in 2015.

The same year, the Green Burial Council polled its provider green cemeteries and learned that an estimated 45% of the burials they handled would probably have been cremations, not conventional burials. The term “cremation conversion” was coined to explain the choice of natural disposition methods over cremation and its inherent environmental downsides of CO<sup>2</sup>, particulates, and heavy metals, particularly mercury emissions, plus reliance on vast quantities of fossil fuel consumption.

Here are some other observations gleaned from that survey:

- 73% of green cemetery operators said they had experienced growing demand since making it available
- 77% agreed that they have been profitable
- 72% indicated that they felt their families were “highly satisfied” with their experience, with all the rest saying they were just “satisfied”

What we have learned above all is that green burial cuts across all socio-economic lines. Anyone with a desire to leave the planet naturally or who enjoys nature in any capacity is a likely consumer. As Baby boomers direct their own parents’ funerals, no less their own, there is a growing swell of desire for simpler, more authentic, organic send-offs that culminate in natural burial.

And there is another factor that will influence whether they approach municipal cemeteries first: the fundamental human need for a sense of place. People want to be buried as close to “home” as possible, wherever that may be for them at any given time, and local cemeteries are far preferable to traveling many miles or to another state or region purely for the environmental benefits. Municipal hybrid cemeteries can play a vital role in strengthening community and meeting the needs of their residents by providing green space close by.

Local cemeteries can also take a greater role in building community by hosting life-affirming events, encouraging people to make a place of death a place of life again. Green burial grounds are the ideal venue for strengthening family and community bonds and educating about environmentally sensible option.

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## Historical Perspective

Some cemetery trustees find it difficult to imagine doing business differently, often having been involved for years in cemetery management according to bylaws written decades earlier. So much about what is legally required has become conflated with local regulations that it is not unusual to hear that vaults are required by law or that embalming is done for public health reasons, neither of which are true anywhere in the US or elsewhere in the world. Tanya Marsh,

the leading cemetery historian and legal expert from Wake Forest University, has written extensively about the evolution of burial and cremation that answers the larger world questions and details types of cemetery trends up to and through the current lawn cemetery (*Cemetery Law: The Common Law of Burying Grounds in the United States*, 2015, God's Acre Publishing). To get a little perspective on what has been happening in our town and city cemeteries that relates specifically to proposals for green burial practices, here is a quick synopsis:

**Prior to 1860** — Care of the dead was largely handled by families, church members, and the local birth midwife. Burial was either on private property on the farm or in church cemeteries, 4-5 feet down, in a pine casket made by the local cabinetmaker or someone handy, or a shroud made of old quilts, sheets, or other fabric. All materials were organic, and no impediments were added that would delay natural decomposition.

**1860 -1930** — Care of the dead migrated out of the hands of family members and into the storefronts of undertakers. The National Funeral Directors Association was formed in 1882 to promote embalming, experimented with on the southern battlefields of the Civil War, and establish a mortuary profession. The affluent began purchasing embalming for preservative reasons and increasingly for cosmetic purposes, and the middle class followed suit. It was common for the mortician to embalm the body and return it to the family home parlor for a vigil. Burial in rural areas continued as before; some cemeteries in crowded urban areas were moved out of the city limits. Early wooden vaults to assist in this effort were introduced, though they caused more safety hazards than they solved.

**1930** — Wilbert Haas, a German-American concrete business owner, toured the tomb of King Tut in Egypt the year it was opened to the public, which resulted in his brainstorm idea to encase caskets in concrete vaults to make burials closer, thus increasing burial density and revenue potential. He marketed the idea as providing protection from the elements for our loved ones for eternity—and protection to the living from the germ-ridden, restless souls inside. Cemeterians embraced the practice for its orderliness and hygiene promises, even after miasma theory that had been associated with the dank air of rotting corpses seeping through soil causing a threat to the health of the living was debunked and replaced by proven germ theory. Around the same time, town and city cemetery managers began writing bylaws to include vaults as a matter of course. Undertakers nee morticians, now calling themselves funeral directors, actively curried a reputation for professionalism akin to doctors and lawyers.

**1998 - present** — Green burial migrated to the US from the UK in South Carolina, with Dr. Billy Campbell and his wife Kimberley starting Ramsey Creek Conservation Burial Ground. Twenty-five years later, more than 350 green burial cemeteries are in operation, all with one significant practice in common: burial without vaults, biodegradable materials, and absence of toxic embalming fluids, the way we started out.

What we can glean from this goes against the mythology many of us have been taught. We now know that dead bodies are not automatically infectious, smelly, or dangerous. While concrete

vaults create maximum use of the land in the short term until the cemetery is filled up, make disinterment possible, and allow areas with poor soils to be utilized, natural burial allows for long term reuse of the land, maximum burial density without artifacts, sustainable management and restoration of poor soil areas. Most natural burial cemeteries disallow disinterment for any reason other than legally required exhumations for obvious reasons plus the unwritten compact between families and owners to keep a loved one's remains undisturbed for spiritual reasons. The fact that both embalming and vaults are not legally required at any governmental level speaks volumes about the false narrative of their necessity as a public health safeguard.

In fact, current practices have proven cumulatively dangerous, filling land with concrete, imported rainforest woods, bronze, steel, and other metals, toxic chemicals, and other things that create leachate and impede the natural decomposition of our organic bodies in soil that is ideal for the purpose of filtering, binding, and deactivating toxins. In studies designed to determine toxic plume from burials, it is clear that any dangers involved with burial are attributable to the things we put in the grave, with the exclusion of the body itself. [See *The Science of Green Burial*. An excerpt on soil and water is included in this packet.]

When we can move past these misunderstandings, we can put the "but we've always done it this way" mentality behind us and begin to be creative in finding ways to incorporate ethical, safe, environmentally responsible practices into our cemeteries.

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## Best Practices/Safety Concerns

For extensive practical directions specific to green burial cemetery operations that address both best practices and safety procedures, see *Opening, Closing, and Maintenance of a Green Burial Grave*. *On the Way to the Green Burial Cemetery: A Guide for Families* discusses other types of safety concerns and approaches the experience from the consumer side of things. Also see the additional FAQs assembled at the conclusion of this article. Leading cemetery operators and sextons contributed to these guides. Together they address the following general areas of concern, and much more:

- Four International health organizations' statements on public health safety of omitting embalming
  - Water and soil contamination
  - Animal disturbance
  - Safe procedures for carrying and lowering the deceased
  - Safe procedures for digging and filling the grave
  - Safe procedures for conducting graveside services
  - Maintenance procedures and priorities
  - Worker safety
-

## Hybrid Cemetery Models

There are currently four distinct types of hybrid cemetery models in the US, with more creative ways to utilize active and abandoned cemeteries in the works. Each takes into consideration the need to use space strategically, respect existing graves, and leave room for successive burials to extend the life of the cemetery.

### ***Natural Burial Section Within or Adjacent to a Conventional Cemetery***

The Catholic Church has been instrumental in showing the way toward sustainable green burial in their existing cemeteries due in part to full body burial doctrine [See *To Lie Down in Green Pastures: The Catholic Church and green burial*]. By creating a dedicated space within the property in general or in an adjacent lot for vaultless burial, maintenance consistency, access points, and a host of other potential complications may be avoided. What happens in green space with regard to chemical, pest, and nuisance animal control, along with maintenance schedules and chosen best practices, stays in that area, making it possible to budget and schedule accordingly. It is also aesthetically pleasing to many who want to be buried in a less manicured or tame place with others of the same ilk. Their sense of place is different from the usual, where people choose based on geographical proximity to home. For green burial families, sense of place has as much to do with what is above ground in direct connection to the grave space as in what town the burial occurs.

### ***Intermingled with Existing Conventional Burial Plots***

Some cemeteries are burying green between existing graves, many of which have no vaults or liners. Maintenance and care therefore follows the cemetery-wide protocol. People choosing this are often satisfied to have contributed to the environment by eschewing a vault and using a biodegradable container while being buried in a place of great meaning to them. There are opening and closing challenges in this scenario, particularly in historic cemeteries whose record keeping may be unreliable, which is often the case due to flooding, fires, and other reasons for records loss or confusion.

### ***Use of Marginal Property***

Another way to utilize space in cemeteries is to identify marginal property that cannot be used for conventional burial due to sloping or rugged topography. It is also a great way to use burial to bring an aesthetic creativity to the property, introducing elements of design that enhance the experience for mourners and visitors. One cemetery in New England has identified through testing that a significant area previously thought unusable can accommodate more than forty green burial graves in its first phase alone by following a swath of land that curves through the center of the cemetery. Another has designed a circular layout with a center fountain in an awkward corner lot area. Still another has done the work of having a soil and water resources inventory done on an area thought to be too close to wetlands and undesirable adjacent land, only to find that there is an environmentally beneficial opportunity for restoration and scenic area development that incorporates burial space. While contemplating the use or development of marginal lands, it is important to weigh cost against potential revenue, but to also weigh the benefits of public engagement at the same time.

### ***Abandoned Cemetery Restoration***

Cemeteries have an interesting legal life where abandonment is concerned. Who is to say whether a cemetery has had its identity destroyed, which is the essential legal criteria for determining an abandoned cemetery? Furthermore, it's hard for family members to understand that although their relative or ancestor may have purchased a plot, their ownership is an easement agreement or license to keep them in that space rather than ownership of the real estate itself. The process of having a cemetery deemed abandoned requires a court decision involving such terms as 'adverse possession' or 'notorious and hostile possession', neither of which is as bad as it sounds. Regardless of the complexity, these older cemeteries that predate consistent use of concrete vaults are being acquired for the purpose of restoration and burial, breathing new life into communities and remembering the interred, just as their families had hoped at the time they were buried.

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### **With Respect to Revenue**

Obviously, town officials are dedicated to responsibly ensuring the fiduciary health of their area, and cemeteries are no exception. Using land wisely and prudently is critical for thriving communities, and essential for fiscally successful cemetery balance sheets.

Some states have mandatory requirements for towns and cities to maintain active burial space for their residents, making it incumbent on selectmen, planning, zoning, cemetery, and other commissioners to plan well. It also means that when cemeteries reach capacity, the municipality is responsible for purchasing additional real estate that can accommodate burial which may or may not be in the same community. With many rural cemeteries maxing out existing space, the acquisition of real estate in desirable locations at a price the town or city can afford is becoming increasingly difficult.

Add to that the upkeep of historical and full cemeteries in addition to developing new space and the costs can add up exponentially, pinching an already strained municipal budget. In many areas of the country, abandoned cemeteries are taking their toll as they revert to municipal control and oversight once the profit has been realized by private owners, or the churches and religious institutions are no longer able to maintain them due to dwindling attendance.

Green burial plots were originally larger than standard plots to account for subsequent burials. We now know that we can bury closer to an earlier burial as long as we keep good physical and digital records and follow a rotation plan, giving each burial a chance to process before disturbing adjacent earth.

In a well-managed green burial cemetery, plots and opening and closing fees make the same demands on real estate, time, effort, and resources that conventional burials do. Charging the same price to bury without a vault as with one is fair, and contributes to keeping burial affordable for all, avoiding the dangers of elitism and selective attainability and accessibility that contributes to socio-economic inequality. Families choosing green burial will benefit from not having to purchase vaults and may find savings by providing their own burial containers or choosing biodegradable manufactured ones, significantly reducing financial pressures. Green burial is also responsible for converting some cremation candidates back to burial, who may have chosen cremation based on a wish to avoid prohibitive pricing of a full conventional funeral, reintroducing opportunities for connection through ritual associated with graveside services.

Burial plot pricing in a hybrid cemetery needs to be consistent with what each individual cemetery is charging for conventional plots for several reasons. First, real estate is real estate—people generally choose place above space. It comes down to location, and the market value of any location is driven by varying factors unique to that location, not what is going to occur on it, just like any other real estate transaction. The price of a piece of land does not change depending on whether a Victorian or a Craftsman house is going to be built on it. Likewise, it makes little sense to charge differently for a similar-sized plot in the same location. Maintenance for green burial graves is different and still necessary, so costs go toward whatever method of upkeep the cemetery chooses to perform; revenue is used differently, not one more than the other. Cost equalizing also ensures accessibility to all, not just for those who can afford it.

The pricing differential is found in lower baseline funeral costs. Environmental advantages, family participation, and return of meaningful ritual burial practices are an added boon to families and cemeteries alike, and savvy funeral directors will see an opening for providing appropriate goods and services that will be beneficial to both consumers and providers.

Despite the rise in cremation, burial space is still needed for cremated remains, and interment is required by the Catholic Church. Common practice is to sell plots for x number of full body burials and/or x number of cremation spots. What many natural burial cemeteries are doing to maximize space use and still generate revenue is to create a smaller cremated remains space, or communal tank, or a scattering garden, with the option of recording the loved one's name on a cenotaph at the entrance to the space rather than taking up larger plots that are mostly empty. This keeps costs down while encouraging responsible disposal of remains that are dense, composed of non-biodegradable elements calcium phosphate and sodium, and can negatively affect the environment when dumped or spread on foliage.

In short, green burial in an existing cemetery can be profitable in multiple ways while also meeting personal, cultural, and financial needs.

## Building Consensus

Chances are good that as a municipal or county official you have been approached by individuals in your area about providing green burial space. Those individuals are joining ranks with others to form green burial societies, alliances, conservation land trusts, nonprofits, and other groups dedicated to making green burial happen in their state or region or area. They come armed with statistics that lay out the environmental, health, land use, and cultural drawbacks of the current system and are demanding change, and it is deeply personal to them.

That said, they may not be savvy about the laws, the politics, or the realities of making these changes in their local cemeteries. They are looking to elected officials to be responsive to their requests. The potential for conflict is high, not just between the residents and officials, but neighbor to neighbor. Getting out ahead of the issues and exploring options is critical for municipal officials. So is building consensus when things are not as easy as they first seem. Since most of the following is not included in your job description, lean on those who are keen to promote the idea and let them take the lead doing the footwork.

Here are some ideas for stemming conflict and building consensus through inclusion:

- 1) Identify potential green burial spaces in your community through a feasibility study
- 2) Identify potential space with a natural resources inventory commissioned from a university or extension service
- 3) Identify space in existing cemeteries by reviewing plats and land use documents
- 4) Appoint a citizen-led committee of advocates to develop and execute a public awareness campaign
- 5) Form an ad hoc committee to design a community-based plan of proposed activities to be offered in the cemetery space, such as fun runs, dog days, yoga or tai chi, family gatherings, birdwatching, etc.
- 6) Have conversations early and often with potential property abutters
- 7) Develop budget projections that identify fiscal planning goals and possibilities
- 8) Host community forums in conjunction with interested community members to explain the law, the benefits and address concerns about green burial
- 9) Engage librarians, book store owners, movie theaters, senior centers and others to display books and host films that explain green burial
- 10) Enlist the aid of religious leaders, funeral directors, community outreach program leaders, educators, and anyone else who has a stake in the development of a green cemetery in your area
- 11) Solicit help in writing newspaper articles, warrants, bylaw language, and brochures or other materials for distribution
- 12) Tap local businesses for support, such as printers, to help with educational efforts

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## Sample Bylaw and Commission Language

Knowing what other hybrid cemeteries are doing is helpful, but having a prototype is even more so. Keep in mind that the examples below have been developed in the past couple of years and are still being edited and improved. For example, many cemetery officials are unaware of burial depths by state and may simply gloss over the old bylaw language not knowing that it was arbitrary policy, not law or even common sense or scientifically advisable. We advise using the following conservatively detailed template as a starting place for redesigning your cemetery bylaws but not be constrained by them when determining what best practices are for your cemetery. *[For a detailed list of what is required in your state, go to <http://www.nhfuneral.org/legal-requirements-by-state.html>]*

### Bylaws Template for Natural Burial Sections of Hybrid Cemeteries

#### **Rules & Regulations Natural Burial Section**

1. All lots sold are subject to the rules and regulations now in force or which the Cemetery Trustees may hereafter adopt. They shall be used for no other purpose than the burial of the human dead. All lots must be paid for in full before a deed is issued. Interment right holders wishing to transfer to the Natural Burial area shall be given a credit of the full purchase price of the traditional interment space.
2. No transfer of ownership or interest in any lot shall become valid until recorded with the Select Board's Office and such transfer or assignment is endorsed by the Cemetery Trustees. All lots must be sold back to the Town and the Town will sell to the new owner.
3. General Maintenance shall include: *[This section may be written to reflect the nature of the maintenance work you plan to provide. It may or may not include: grass cutting, filling depressions, reseeding, removal of fallen debris, annual brush hogging, or other services that are appropriate if you are not mowing.]*
4. The General Maintenance fee will be turned over to the Trustees of Trust Funds and any interest earned thereon will be used for general cemetery maintenance. Any excess will accumulate for such time, as the said Cemetery Trustees may deem expedient, or in their discretion to apply the same surplus, or any part thereof, from time to time, to ornamenting and preserving the grounds of the said cemetery.
5. Deceased persons shall not be embalmed or topically treated with sprays or compounds, unless with non-toxic products. Bodies accepted for burial shall be wrapped in a shroud, quilt or blanket, and/or placed in a burial container that includes a board, integrated or separate, for stability. Clothing is optional.
6. All materials used in the manufacturing or constructions of caskets, burial containers, shrouds, quilts, blankets, clothing, and urns shall be 100% biodegradable and non-toxic. Materials used must be plant derived, natural, animal, or biodegradable material, including the shell, liner, handles, fasteners, and adornments of any burial container, shroud, quilt, blanket, clothing or urn. Materials used in the manufacturing, construction,

and finishing of products used for burial shall not contain plastics, acrylics, or similar synthetic polymeric materials. Shrouds, quilts, and blankets used for burial without a casket shall have a natural wood backer (plywood and OSB are not acceptable) no less than 1/2" thick and the length of the body, to stabilize the decent during the burial process.

7. Vaults and liners (partial, inverted, or otherwise) are prohibited.

8. No enclosure of any nature, such as fences, copings, hedges or ditches, shall be allowed around any lots. Planting of trees and shrubs shall be prohibited. No inscriptions, statues, embellishments, effigies, artifacts, lights, wildlife feeders, wind chimes, flags, or artificial decorations of any kind will be permitted. Cut flower funeral tributes that have been removed from their containers may be buried with the deceased. All other funeral floral tributes may be taken home or they will be disposed of or recycled. Fresh cut flower remembrance tributes may be placed on the grave at any time, and will be removed by Cemetery personnel upon becoming unsightly. The cemetery reserves the right to determine whether live plantings may be accepted.

9. Grave markers are permitted but not required. Stones may not exceed 216 square inches (approximately 12 x 18 inches) in size and must lay flat. No foundations will be permitted. The marker must be constructed of a natural material. Only one memorial stone is permitted for each burial site. Stones may be engraved, but must remain simple in appearance. Photographs, electronics, sound, etc., is not permitted. The Cemetery may reject/remove, without notice, any memorials that do not meet the specifications.

10. Vehicles other than light machinery used to dig the graves are not permitted. Limited use of electric golf carts or similar light transport and people or animal drawn carts is permissible.

11. Disinterments are considered irretrievable. Next-of-kin must sign a waiver attesting to their understanding that the body will not be moved unless ordered by the State.

12. In order to protect and maintain the integrity and intent of the Natural Burial area, the Board of Trustees reserves the right to refuse the burial of any decedent for non-compliance of the Rules and Regulations as required in this section.

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*This article was written by Lee Webster for the Green Burial Council with the help of Suzanne Kelly of Rhinebeck Cemetery and author of Greening Death; Candace Currie, formerly of Mt Auburn Cemetery; and Patrick Healey, Green Mount Cemetery, Montpelier, VT*

## Hybrid Cemetery FAQs

### **Q. Is there a universal definition of green burials?**

**A.** The Green Burial Council provides nuanced definitions of green burial in its [Glossary of Green Burial Terms](#). These terms have been devised and evaluated by leaders in the field at all levels. In terms of certification, each level—hybrid, natural, and conservation—must meet specific standards to qualify. See [Green Burial Defined](#) for more Q&As about what constitutes green.

### **Q. Are hybrid areas mowed?**

**A.** It is entirely up to the cemetery officials to determine the appropriate or desirable methods of maintaining the green burial section. Some choose to make the area consistent with the conventional area by mowing, some choose various other ways of balancing access and sustainable management with aesthetics. Keep in mind that heavy machinery will compact soil, which could impact decomposition by reducing oxygen flow and water saturation rates.

### **Q. How are graves laid out in a green hybrid section?**

**A.** Plot location can be similar to conventional where families buy plots ahead of time or the decision may be made at the discretion of the sexton, depending on the cemetery's operating plan. Graves set side by side will require a rotation plan, potentially maximizing burial density in the long run. Many green burial cemeteries sell the right to be buried in a certain area but retain the ability to determine the exact location. This is particularly prevalent in woodland burial areas where tree roots, rock, ledge, water and other natural impediments may require the grave to be shifted a distance away from the original site. This also gives the cemetery the ability to prepare graves in fall for winter burial and to follow their own burial plot sequence through the area or the entire cemetery. This is made clear in the contract at the time of purchase.

### **Q. Are co-burials possible in a hybrid green cemetery?**

**A.** Depending on the choices made by the operators and trustees, the burial of one full body and the cremated remains of another may be acceptable. Dual occupancy of one grave is generally not feasible, but it is up to the cemetery operators to determine.

### **Q. What will be expected of the hybrid cemetery employees at the time of burial?**

**A.** Green burial services, though often more family participatory, do not differ greatly from conventional services. Funeral directors and clergy are often involved, directing and guiding the event as usual. If a professional is not involved, a family member educated by staff prior to the event should be designated to be in charge of walking patterns, protocols, and accepted behaviors. Some green burial operators are routinely on hand to manage and support the family, making sure things are tended to properly. In many cemeteries, the personal touch of the sexton or steward being present is an important part of the experience. Maintenance workers will want to fine tune caring for the area once the mourners have left.

### **Q. Should we be concerned with the collapsing of the grave?**

**A.** Grave subsidence at 3.5 feet is much less likely to occur than at 5 feet. Soil and

moisture are factors, but for the most part, graves can be dug at this depth without fear of collapse. In some soils, cemetery operators choose to lay in temporary plywood supports for the walls that are removed prior to the service. Wide wooden planks set on either edge of the grave provide surer footing for those doing the lowering and will help to prevent the edges from crumbling. When the weather is especially damp, a deeper reservoir dug at one end of the grave will collect excess water, further reinforcing the integrity of the grave.

**Q. How can bodies be properly prepared for burial and what is a home funeral?**

**A.** Home funerals, which allow for families to care for a decedent and all aspects of a funeral at home, were quite common in the US up until the 1930s. Home funerals find family and friends, next of kin, or a legally designated agent retaining custody and control of the body for the time period between death and disposition (burial or cremation). This is sometimes referred to as *home vigil* or DIY funeral. A home funeral involves bathing and dressing the body and using dry ice, Techni-ice, or other cooling mechanism as a preservative; it commonly lasts 1-3 days. A *home funeral guide* may provide education and support either prior to or during this time period. It's important to care for the body using these techniques prior to burial. For more information, go to the [National Home Funeral Alliance](#).

**Q. What are blended funerals?**

**A.** Funerals that combine conventional funeral practices with home funeral and/or green burial practices; may include the use of a funeral director for certain aspects of care, such as obtaining, completing and filing paperwork or transporting the body. Families may have a home funeral without having a green burial and visa versa. Blended funerals offer families more options, especially when certain options are not available in their area. Most all GBC-approved funeral homes accommodate families wanting home funerals.

**Q. What is a home burial?**

**A.** A home burial is exactly what it sounds like—a burial on a family's property. Home burials are legal in all but one state (Arkansas), with some states stating that burials must be in established cemeteries; however, one can establish a family cemetery on one's own property by following state and local regulations. Burial in a family cemetery on private property is limited to family members only. To learn more about state by state requirements, go to [Legal Requirements by State](#).

**Q. How is a grave liner different from a vault?**

**A.** A grave liner covers the sides and top of the casket where a vault is significantly more substantial, acting as a box for the box. Both are classified as outer burial containers. Neither is required by law, though cemeteries often require them to avoid grave subsidence. Neither is permitted in a green burial cemetery of any kind, as they both impede natural decomposition and introduce non-biodegradable materials into the earth.

**Q. What about inverting the outer container?**

**A.** Called 'butterdishing', this method may allow the body to be closer to the earth on the bottom surface, but still impedes and puts non-biodegradable artifacts in the ground. It is not an acceptable alternative to going without.

**Q. Since burial vaults are made from concrete, shouldn't they be considered green?**

**A.** While the concrete and metal in vaults may be considered "natural" to some, the

manufacturing and transporting of vaults uses a tremendous amount of energy and causes significant carbon emission. In the US, vault manufacturing requires the production of 1.6 tons of reinforced concrete annually. No state or province legally requires vault purchase to implementation—individual cemeteries determine their own vault requirements.

**Q. How does a shrouded body get carried to the grave?**

**A.** Many cemeteries have a vehicle for moving shrouded and casketed bodies, including retrofitted golf carts, wagons, trailers, or other wheeled conveyances. Some families choose to conduct a processional with pall bearers, either on shoulder for a casket or with carrying handles on a shrouding board for shroud burials. (See [Opening, Closing and Maintenance of a Green Burial Grave](#))

**Q. How and who lowers the body?**

**A.** This depends on how the individual cemetery chooses to handle family participation and what mechanical devices are available. Some cemeteries continue to use excavators for digging and hydraulic machinery for lowering, while others pay employees to hand dig graves and allow the family, with direction if necessary, to lower the body themselves using shrouding boards, straps, or ropes. Sometimes family members wish to dig the grave themselves. Green burial operators should expect more family participation and be prepared with appropriate equipment—and liability waiver agreements built into their contract for services. (See [Opening, Closing and Maintenance of a Green Burial Grave](#))

**Q. What protects the cemetery from liability claims for injuries incurred during carrying, digging, lowering, and closing the grave?**

**A.** It is wise to require the next-of-kin to sign a liability waiver that indemnifies the cemetery and all of its employees from responsibility for injuries of anyone in their party during the funeral. This can be simple language included in the contract or a stand-alone agreement that is witnessed if possible. It is good practice to provide written instructions and warnings in a guidebook designed to educate the family about cemetery rules and best practices when purchasing the plot and/or arranging the burial. (See [Sample Guidebook for Hybrid Cemetery Operators](#))

**Q. How deep does one place the body?**

**A.** Burial depth differs by state. For a comprehensive list by state of this and other requirements, go to <http://www.nhfuneral.org/legal-requirements-by-state.html>. As a general rule, the ideal burial depth for optimal decomposition conditions is 3.5 – 4 feet from the bottom of the grave to the soil horizon, which also guarantees an 18-24 inch smell barrier that prevents animals, two and four legged both, from being able to smell anything. By adding the displaced soil to the top of the grave in a mound, that depth is doubled until it gradually settles.

**Q. What if the body is in bad condition?**

**A.** Included in the contract and/or guidebook should be explicit guidelines for the condition of the body when presented for burial, with the clear understanding that they will be turned away if those conditions are not met. Many families hire funeral directors for body preparation so it would be the professional's job to repair any damage or rectify any issues. If the family is in charge, bodies will most likely be coming for burial in a short enough period of time that these scenarios are unlikely, but if there were a problem, it would be their responsibility to address it by whatever means necessary. (See [Sample Guidebook](#))

**Q. Won't wild animals dig up corpses?**

**A.** No. Burials occur 3.5 feet under the ground with, at minimum, an 18-inch smell barrier. Animals are much more interested in living prey above ground than in working that hard. We're just not that delicious. (See [Real Answers to Questions Real People Ask](#))

**Q. Won't we be able to smell them?**

**A.** No. Same principles apply. And remember this from 5th grade science? Humans have a dismal sense of smell compared to animals. If they can't smell bodies, we surely won't be able to either. Wild boar are the most deep-digging of all wildlife and they typically max out at 12 inches. (See [Real Answers to Questions Real People Ask](#))

**Q. Do green burials contaminate the water table or drinking water?**

**A.** No. With burials at 3.5 feet deep, there is no danger of contaminating potable water that is found about 75 feet below the surface. Mandatory setbacks from known water sources also ensure that surface water is not at risk. (See [The Science Behind Green Burial](#))

**Q. Do unembalmed bodies pollute the ground with chemo or other drugs?**

**A.** Soil is the best natural filter there is, binding organic compounds and making them unable to travel. Microorganisms in the soil break down any chemical compounds that remain in the body. We lose more toxic chemicals during a day of living than a whole body will decomposing. A 2018 Recompose study done by the University of Washington found that chemicals, heavy metals, and other potential biochemical concerns met or exceeded EPA levels by a significant margin. A recent study found dangerous levels of radiopharmaceuticals in crematories, endangering workers. Additionally, embalming does not remove toxins from anywhere in the body except the fluids that are removed during the process. (See [Radiation Contamination Following Cremation of a Deceased Patient Treated with a Radiopharmaceutical](#), Yu, Rule, Sio, et al, *Journal of the American Medical Association*, February 26, 2019)

**Q. How long does it take for a body to completely decompose?**

**A.** Depending on soil type, oxygen availability, and moisture present, it takes on average 6 weeks to lose the majority of soft tissue through moisture absorption by the soil, and up to 2 years for complete decomposition. It may take up to twenty years for bones to absorb in moist soils. (See [The Science Behind Green Burial](#))

**Q. What soil conditions are the most favorable for green burial?**

**A.** Well drained soils with some clay content to absorb organic compounds, and an active biological presence of bacteria are ideal for promoting efficient decomposition. This allows for aerobic decay, followed by anaerobic decay, resulting in rich soils high in nitrogen content and organic compounds. (See [The Science Behind Green Burial](#)). The following list is not conclusive but gives a good general description of optimum conditions for burial:

- On gentle slopes
- On bedrock with clay, low permeability mineral content between 20 and 40%
- Bottom of grave 1.5 meters or 5 feet above maximum seasonal groundwater level
- Surround with buffer zones of trees and shrubs
- Install appropriate stormwater drainage

- Require biodegradable containers without potential contaminants or chemicals

**Q. Can bodies be buried in winter?**

**A.** Depending on frost levels and previous preparation of the gravesite, burial in winter is feasible. Various methods are available for snow removal and thawing ground in cold climates, including coal fires, use of heaters, and thermal blankets. Often digging graves ahead of time and filling them with straw, compost, or other organic material and then capping it for easy removal at need works well. (See [Opening, Closing and Maintenance of a Green Burial Grave](#))

**Q. What is done in the winter time if the cemetery is closed?**

**A.** Burials in cemeteries that choose not to bury in winter may have systems and facilities that house bodies until spring burial. All bodies respond well to being kept cool for the time needed, whether in a mausoleum, below grade facility, or other means of consistent cool temperatures. (See [Opening, Closing and Maintenance of a Green Burial Grave](#))

**Q. How does one mark the actual burial spot?**

**A.** Ideally, graves are marked by GPS, but these systems can be costly. Corner markers made of stone are acceptable, as are flat markers at the head. Metal spikes could be buried near the surface to allow a metal detector to locate the perimeter of the grave, a more cost-effective and durable method, depending on the metal used. Some other type of physical marker is possible as well, such as native plants, trees or shrubs, or a plain or engraved fieldstone.

**Q. What about memorialization?**

**A.** Green burial sections do not allow upright monuments. Instead, a flat marker, usually made of native stone, is at the head. Using concrete to set stones is frowned upon in a green section, as concrete has its own significant environmental downsides. Flat markers make finding the grave and mowing the area relatively easy. Maintenance consists of removing overgrowth, if wished. Some cemeteries choose to have no physical markers yet include the person's name and dates on a central cenotaph at the entrance. Some cemeteries allow installation art pieces situated throughout the cemetery.

**Q. How are vaultless burials disinterred?**

**A.** Families are asked to sign a contract stating that they understand that their family member will not be disinterred unless legally ordered to do so by the State, and that the family will be responsible for any costs not born by the State should this be ordered. Good records and physical indicators of the perimeter are critical, though the shorter burial depth and proper preparation of the grave with evergreen boughs, compost, or other organic material may provide a soil roadmap.

**Q. What about grave robbing?**

**A.** Grave robbing as a way to make extra cash by providing cadavers for medical study ended by the early 1900's. Body donations now provide plenty for a variety of scientific research. Given the superstitions ingrained in us, plus the significant repercussions for violating anti-desecration laws, grave robbing has not been reported in decades in any cemetery, no less a green burial one. Additionally, if the grave is 3.5 -4 feet deep and the displaced soil is mounded above by 3-4 feet,

it's highly unlikely that anyone is going to bother and mess. By the time the body has decomposed and it's down to bones, the grave may be pretty well blended into the environment. If concerned, consider locating the green burial area nearer a central location instead of the periphery.

**Q. What do green burial plots cost?**

**A.** Green burial plots need not be different from conventional plot pricing. Although there is maintenance for both, it is different, not necessarily more or less intensive. In fact, not having to haul around heavy equipment, spread herbicides, pesticides, and fertilizers, mow and trim, or clean and repair headstones could mean big savings on perpetual care. What green burial families are paying for is the same thing anyone else is: real estate in a specific location. Whatever the going rate is in your cemetery or general region for a plot should apply universally.

**Q. Do green cemeteries reuse burial plots?**

**A.** There are no laws against reusing a plot, but there is the right of sepulchre, or "right to undisturbed repose" in the US. In many countries, graves are routinely "rented" and refilled at a later date, often removing the bones to an ossuary. Green burial cemeteries may have the ability to reuse ground space in the future.

**Q. Can cremated remains be scattered in green burial cemeteries?**

**A.** Because of the density and nonbiodegradable content of cremated remains, many green burial cemeteries do not allow scattering. Cremated remains consist of calcium phosphate and sodium and are heavy, apt to smother foliage on the surface. Underground cremated remains create what is essentially a nutrient-deficient salt lick that has no environmental benefits. Cremated remains that are scattered on vegetation will likely have a detrimental effect on the soil and surrounding microenvironment and may contribute to phosphorus run-off that can create algae bloom in waterways that kills fish, marine life, and water plants.

**Q. What does it mean if a cemetery is Green Burial Council certified?**

**A.** GBC certification allows consumers to be able to distinguish between the three types of cemeteries and understand that each has a different set of standards. It requires cemetery operators commit to a certain degree of transparency, accountability and third party oversight. And it prevents future owners from going back on whatever ecological or aesthetic promises have been made in the past, from limitations to burial density that protect a local ecosystem to prohibitions against the use of monuments that would negatively impact views. For more information on certifying with the GBC, go to [Why Certification Matters](#) and [Become Certified](#).

**Q. What's wrong with embalming?**

**A.** The Council does not think any end-of-life ritual, form of disposition, or mode of post-mortem preparation is "wrong". We are simply advocating for green services and products that help to minimize the environmental impact of our last acts. Embalming fluid is usually comprised of the carcinogen chemical formaldehyde, which has been proven to pose health risks in funeral homes.

A [study by the National Cancer Institute released in late 2009](#) revealed that funeral directors have a much higher incidence of myeloid leukemia. Another study completed in 2015 by the [Journal of Neurology, Neurosurgery & Psychiatry](#) indicates a three times higher incidence of ALS, Lou Gherig's Disease,

than in the general public. And the National Funeral Directors Association recently published NFDA Environmental Compliance officer Carol Lynn Green's opinion piece [Excising a Health Risk](#) where she predicts the end to embalming for safety reasons.

**Q. What about essential oils and green embalming fluid?**

**A.** Fortunately, there are now several formaldehyde-free embalming fluids, including one made entirely of nontoxic and biodegradable essential oils, which recently earned the GBC seal of approval. The sanitation and preservation of a decedent can almost always take place without the use of chemicals, as is done in just about every nation in the world. To find a green embalmer, go to [Funeral Home Providers](#) to locate a certified funeral director near you, or go to [Product Providers](#) to inquire of a product manufacturer.

**Q. How do I know that a particular product is suitable for a green burial?**

**A.** The GBC believes a casket, urn, or shroud is suitable for a green burial if it is made from materials and substances that are nontoxic and readily biodegradable. We also require that these products not be made from materials that are harvested in a manner that unnecessarily destroys habitat. See [Product Providers](#) before purchasing any green funeral product.

**Q. Doesn't cremation create a lot of pollution?**

**A.** Cremation uses far fewer resources than almost any other disposition option but it certainly has an environmental impact. Cremation burns fossil fuels, and some older cremation facilities can use significantly more energy compared to newer ones. Mercury is also emitted when a person with dental amalgam fillings is cremated, but filtration devices that can fully mitigate mercury pollution have not been invented yet. While no standards yet exist that allow consumers to determine which cremation retorts produce the most pollution and carbon emissions, there are several things that can be done to offset the carbon footprint of cremation, such as recycling medical parts, making a contribution to a carbon fund, or supporting ocean reef regrowth.

**Q. Why don't you certify cremation disposition programs?**

**A.** While a cremation disposition program may provide benefit by setting ecologically responsible standards for memorial reefs and scattering grounds, the amount of resources and effort required to responsibly establish and manage such programs come at the cost of utilizing resources to further the organization's main objectives: to encourage environmentally sustainable deathcare through its funeral home and product compliance program, and to preserve natural areas through green burial via its burial compliance program. Accordingly, we currently do not have a cremation disposition certification program.

**For more information, go to:**

**[greenburialcouncil.org](http://greenburialcouncil.org)>education>multimedia>GBC Publications**

**or**

**[NHfuneral.org](http://NHfuneral.org)>Resources>Writings and Forms**

# Green Burial in Massachusetts

## Questions & Answers

### ***What Is Green Burial?***

Green burial is a way of returning bodies to the earth after death. Called “green” burial for its ecological soundness, it is also commonly known as natural burial.

A green or natural burial uses no embalming, no metal casket, and no burial liner or vault; the marker, if used, is typically flat and level with the ground. Proponents often refer to it as “traditional” burial because it reclaims the more natural way in which nearly all were buried prior to the Civil War—one that is still used by much of the world’s population. Because only biodegradable materials are used, in green burial a human body and its burial container enrich the soil.

### ***How Is this Different from Conventional Burial?***

For some, conventional burial—with embalming, metal or hardwood casket, and burial vault—offers comfort and predictability. But it can be very expensive, often at a time when families can least afford the expense. It also inhibits decomposition of the body and creates “landfills” of non-biodegradable and sometimes hazardous materials. By one estimate, we bury each year approximately:

- 4.3 million gallons of embalming fluid;
- 64,500 tons of steel, 2,700 tons of copper and bronze, and 20-plus million board feet of hardwoods, much of it tropical (for caskets); and
- 1.6-plus million tons of reinforced concrete and another 14,000 tons of steel, for burial vaults and foundations (*Green Burial Council 2014*).

In addition, we need to consider the resources consumed (water, fossil fuels) and byproducts produced (carbon dioxide, heavy metals, heat) in the manufacturing of these buried materials.

### ***What About Cremation?***

Cremation is generally much less expensive than conventional burial. It permits greater flexibility, as cremated remains may be buried or scattered at the family’s convenience. Alternatively, cremated remains may be incorporated into various art forms, placed in coral reef balls, or even shot into space.

However, cremation requires sufficient fossil fuel to sustain a temperature of 1400° - 1700° F. for about 90 minutes to four hours, depending upon the manufacturer and age of the equipment. Cremation also produces a variety of air pollutants—particulate matter, carbon monoxide, mercury and dioxin, among others—resulting partly from the substances burned and partly from the combustion process itself.

In the context of an individual’s lifetime use of fossil fuels, a single cremation has a relatively small carbon footprint. Nationwide, however, the energy consumed by cremations in one year would drive a car to the moon over 2,500 times (*Green Burial Council 2014*).

What about using the “ashes” as fertilizer in a memorial garden or to plant a tree? Unfortunately, cremated remains have high pH and salt levels, which can be harmful or even deadly to plant life.

### ***How Does Green Burial Work?***

With green burial, a body is not embalmed. Refrigeration, dry ice or ice packs will cool the body if immediate burial is not possible or desired (see [www.homefuneralalliance.org](http://www.homefuneralalliance.org) for more information on home wakes). The body is enclosed in a biodegradable container, such as a pine box, a cardboard coffin, or a natural-fiber shroud, and placed directly into the earth rather than into a concrete “outer burial container.”

A flat memorial stone may be used, or a tree or other planting may serve as a grave marker, often in combination with some form of computer mapping such as GPS. Burial at a depth of 3½ to 4 feet will permit access by aerobic bacteria to enhance decomposition.



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## Why Might I Want a Green Burial?

Any burial that uses green techniques will help to conserve resources, protect groundwater, and return bodily nutrients to the soil. For many people, protection of our resources is reason enough to want a more ecologically friendly exit.

For proponents of dedicated natural burial grounds in the U.S., though, green burial is much more than a benign form of burial. It is also a way of actively pursuing land preservation and restoration, in meadow or woodland settings where people can hike and picnic as well as bury loved ones.

We at Green Burial Massachusetts aim to open one or more burial grounds that will conserve land as well as restore death to its rightful place in the cycle of life.

## Is Green Burial an Option in Massachusetts?

If you have sufficient land, it may be possible to have a green burial on your own property. You'll need to get approval ahead of time from your local board of health.

Towns and private cemeteries are increasingly permitting natural burial, essentially by not requiring use of a burial vault.

See the crowdsourced database on our website ([www.greenburialma.org](http://www.greenburialma.org)) for a listing of the towns we know of in which a green burial is possible. As we learn of other towns and cities where natural burial is available, we'll add them to the database. If you know of one that should be added, we invite you to send it in!

We do not have a dedicated green cemetery in Massachusetts yet, but we are working on it. See the Valley Conservation Cemetery Project ([www.conservationcemeteryma.org](http://www.conservationcemeteryma.org)). New York has one (Greensprings Natural Cemetery Preserve, near Ithaca; (607) 564-7577; [www.naturalburial.org](http://www.naturalburial.org)). Maine has two (Cedar Brook Burial Ground, near Portland; (207) 637-2085; [www.mainegreencemetery.com](http://www.mainegreencemetery.com); and Baldwin Hill Conservation Cemetery, Fayette, ME, about a three hour drive north of Boston; (207) 377-2848; [www.baldwinhillcemetery.org](http://www.baldwinhillcemetery.org))

## Resources:

*Final Rights: Reclaiming the American Way of Death*, by Joshua Slocum and Lisa Carlson. Hinesburg, Vt.: Upper Access Books (2011).

*Going Out Green: One Man's Adventure Planning His Own Burial*, by Bob Butz. Traverse City, Mich.: Spirituality & Health Books (2009).

*Grave Matters: A Journey through the Modern Funeral Industry to a Natural Way of Burial*, by Mark Harris. New York: Scribner (2007).

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Funeral Consumers Alliance—a non-profit organization dedicated to protecting a consumer's right to choose a meaningful, dignified, affordable funeral. [www.funerals.org](http://www.funerals.org); (802) 865-8300.

Massachusetts Funeral Consumers Portal— provides links to the two Massachusetts affiliates of the national Funeral Consumers Alliance, in Western Massachusetts (FCAWM) and Eastern Massachusetts (FCAEM). <https://funeralsma.org>; (413) 376-4747 or (617) 859-7990.

Green Burial Council—established in 2005 to provide information, establish standards, and build networks for making burial sustainable, meaningful and economically viable. [www.greenburialcouncil.org](http://www.greenburialcouncil.org); (888) 966-3330.

Ramsey Creek Preserve, in Westminster, SC—the first green cemetery in the United States, established in 1998 by Memorial Ecosystems Inc. [www.ramseycreekpreserve.com](http://www.ramseycreekpreserve.com); (864) 647-7798.

Updated January 2023

## What Can I Do to Further Green Burial in Massachusetts?

- Call the cemetery you're thinking of using and ask whether green burial is permitted. If it's privately owned, speak to someone on its board of directors. If it's a municipal cemetery, speak to the local Cemetery Commission.
- Cemetery Commissions often lack members. Why not volunteer to serve on yours?
- Similarly, call any funeral home you're considering and ask whether they will assist with a green burial. Cemeteries and funeral directors need to hear that this is something people want.
- Opt for a "greener" burial, even if your cemetery requires a vault: skip the embalming; choose a coffin made of local softwood (pine is good) or another biodegradable container; ask to invert the vault, omitting the lid, so the body and its container rest directly on the earth.
- Host a talk by a Green Burial Massachusetts speaker to increase awareness of and support for this ecologically friendly burial option.
- If you have land that might be suitable for this purpose, consider donating it to GBM. We are incorporated as a nonprofit.
- Join us! GBM is actively working with land trusts to establish one or more conservation cemeteries in Massachusetts. We welcome your energy, talents and skills.



Green Burial Massachusetts is a statewide, all-volunteer 501(c)(3) nonprofit whose mission is twofold: to start the first green cemetery open to all in Massachusetts, and to educate the public about green burial.

**For additional resources, check out our website!**  
[www.greenburialma.org](http://www.greenburialma.org)

## MOUNT AUBURN CEMETERY



# NATURAL BURIALS



GUIDELINES FOR NATURAL BURIAL AT MOUNT AUBURN CEMETERY

MOUNT AUBURN CEMETERY WAS FOUNDED IN 1831 ON THE SAME IDEOLOGY THAT IS FOUND IN THE NATURAL BURIAL MOVEMENT TODAY. JACOB BIGELOW, ONE OF MOUNT AUBURN'S FOUNDERS, FERVENTLY AND ELOQUENTLY WROTE ABOUT THE NATURAL PROCESS OF DECOMPOSITION:

*“The elements which have once moved and circulated in living frames do not become extinct nor useless after death: they offer themselves as the materials from which other living frames are to be constructed.”*



## NATURAL BURIALS AT MOUNT AUBURN CEMETERY

Natural or ‘green’ burial – which requires that everything going into the grave is biodegradable – is welcome at Mount Auburn Cemetery.

### ***How does Mount Auburn define natural burial?***

A natural burial at Mount Auburn is placed into a grave that is approximately four feet in depth and not lined with a concrete box, sometimes referred to as a grave liner.

Most of these grave sites are located within the ‘historic core’ where they are surrounded by mature trees and monuments from the 19th and early 20th centuries.

Monuments are generally not allowed with natural burials, but many of these locations allow for memorial plaques on existing trees or associated with newly planted trees and shrubs.

Each grave is given a unique number, indicated by an aluminum marker placed at the foot of the grave.

At the time of burial, a lowering device with a framework around all edges of the grave is required for safety and liability reasons. This device is removed prior to closing the grave.

# PLANNING AHEAD

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DO YOU PLAN TO BE WRAPPED IN A SHROUD OR BURIED IN A SIMPLE WOODEN CASKET? WILL YOU BE UTILIZING THE SERVICES OF A FUNERAL DIRECTOR OR ARE YOU PLANNING FOR A HOME FUNERAL?

AS YOU MAKE PLANS FOR YOUR OWN FUNERAL, OR PLAN FOR THE FUNERAL OF A FAMILY MEMBER OR A FRIEND, PLEASE KEEP MOUNT AUBURN'S NATURAL BURIAL POLICIES IN MIND. THESE GUIDELINES HAVE BEEN CREATED IN PARTNERSHIP WITH BOTH LOCAL FUNERAL DIRECTORS AND NATURAL DEATH CARE ADVOCATES TO ENSURE THAT WE ARE PROVIDING OUR CLIENTS WITH FLEXIBLE OPTIONS.

## BURIAL CONTAINERS

Mount Auburn allows the use of shrouds, simple wooden caskets, or any other biodegradable container.

### Caskets

Wooden caskets must be free of toxic materials; they should be held together with wooden dowels and non-toxic glues. Caskets made of wicker, bamboo, and other natural materials are also permitted as long as they are free of toxic paints and varnishes. A handmade casket cannot exceed the size of a standard casket. If an oversized casket is required, please notify Mount Auburn to ensure that the grave can be expanded to the casket's dimensions.

### Shrouds

A shrouded body is allowed. A shrouding board must be used for transporting and lowering the body into the grave. The shrouding board will be used to stabilize the body on the lowering device and will subsequently be placed into the grave along with the body.

- ★ *Please note that even if the shroud has straps sewn into it for the purpose of lowering the body into the grave, Mount Auburn's lowering device will be used.*

## PREPARING THE BODY

### **It's important to keep the body cool.**

While cooling the body will slow down the decomposition process, there is no way to prevent this natural process from occurring.

**Mount Auburn recommends burial within four days from the time of death.** Regardless of the time frame, Mount Auburn will not accept any body if the outer container – casket or shroud – shows any signs of bodily fluids.

Whether a body is prepared for burial by the family, a licensed funeral director, or someone trained in natural death care, Mount Auburn insists that the container holding or shroud wrapping the body be free of any visible bodily fluids. (This requirement is also true for acceptance into Mount Auburn's crematory.) In the event of visible bodily fluids, Mount Auburn will request that the family or funeral director who presented the body for burial take the body off site to clean and prepare the body again. Burial may then be scheduled for later in the same day or for the next day.

## TRANSPORTING THE BODY

Mount Auburn recommends that the body arrive in a closed vehicle such as a hearse or a van; not an open pick-up truck. State law currently allows for either a funeral director or a non-paid family member or friend to provide this service.



# BURIAL

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OUR STAFF WILL ASSIST WITH THE SCHEDULING OF THE BURIAL, WILL GREET YOUR FUNERAL GUESTS AT OUR ENTRANCE GATE AND LEAD THEM AS A GROUP TO THE BURIAL SITE, AND WILL ASSIST THE FAMILY WITH ANY LEVEL OF INVOLVEMENT THEY WISH TO HAVE IN THE ACTUAL BURIAL.

ULTIMATELY, OUR GOAL IS TO PROVIDE THE BEST POSSIBLE EXPERIENCE FOR EVERYONE ATTENDING A BURIAL SERVICE AT THE CEMETERY.

## SCHEDULING THE BURIAL

In general, funerals must be scheduled 48 hours in advance by contacting the administrative office at 617-547-7105.

## PROCESSING TO THE CEMETERY

You may arrive at the cemetery in procession (typically led by a funeral director) or your family may chose to meet and gather for the burial at the Cemetery. In both instances, Mount Auburn personnel will lead the procession from our Mount Auburn Street entrance to the grave site.

## MOVING THE BODY TO THE GRAVE

Pall bearers (typically, Mount Auburn staff and/or funeral directors) will transfer the shrouded body or casket from the vehicle to a rolling bier. Family and friends may escort the body alongside the bier as it rolls. Mount Auburn staff will transfer the body from the bier to the lowering device set over the grave prior to the family's arrival.



## LOWERING DEVICE

For safety, Mount Auburn will use a lowering device at the grave. This device ensures a gentle lowering into the grave. It is a quiet, mechanical device that lowers a body using canvas straps, which may also be buried with the body (typically, they are removed by Mount Auburn's interment crew after the body has been lowered). Mount Auburn allows a family member or a friend to turn the handle that begins the lowering process.

*Please see the Planning Ahead section for more information about the use of our lowering device with shrouded bodies.*

## FLOWERS

Families may place single stem flowers in the grave after the body has been lowered. In keeping with our floral tribute policies, any flower arrangements left on top of the grave, once it has been filled, will be removed on the fifth day after burial.

## BURIAL

If requested, Mount Auburn will provide shovels and enough soil for families to symbolically participate in the burial of the casket or shroud. Mount Auburn's staff will complete the closing of the grave using mechanical equipment after the family leaves.



In 2014, Mount Auburn Cemetery became the first cemetery in Massachusetts certified by the Green Burial Council.

## **MOUNT AUBURN CEMETERY**

580 Mount Auburn Street | Cambridge, MA 02138

617-547-7105 | [info@mountauburn.org](mailto:info@mountauburn.org)

**[www.mountauburn.org](http://www.mountauburn.org)**

## **Glossary of Green Burial Terms**

(copied from Green Burial Council website; pdf version would not download)

***Adapted vegetation*** Non-invasive, beneficial plants (not noxious weeds) that have adapted to the specific locality; provides habitat and requires little or no maintenance.

***At need arrangements*** Decisions and purchases made at the time of death rather than in advance, including selection of gravesite, burial container, type of service, etc. (see also *pre-need arrangements*).

***Back country*** A remote, undeveloped area, intentionally preserved as wilderness to provide intact habitat for wildlife. While it may be accessible on foot, it is not maintained via trails or other access routes and is categorized in land management plans as a protected ecosystem

***Baseline Document*** A report that describes the existing, pre-development environmental conditions of a site.

***Best Practices*** A professional method or procedure, accepted or prescribed as being the most effective way to achieve stated goals. Established techniques or methodologies that, through experience and research, have proven to lead to a desired result. Also known as best management practices.

***Bier*** A raised device or platform that holds the casket, either during a vigil or funeral service.

***Biodegradable*** Items that can break down into natural materials in the environment without causing harm and are capable of being decomposed by bacteria or other living organisms.

***Burial Containers*** Caskets and shrouds capable of being decomposed or biodegraded by bacteria or other living organisms; often made of plant or animal fiber (wicker, sea grass, paper, linen, cotton, wool, willow, bamboo, etc.). Metals, glues, resins, plastics, and other synthetics that are non-biodegradable are not recommended.

***Blended funerals*** Funerals that combine conventional funeral practices with home funeral and/or green burial practices; may include the use of a funeral director for certain aspects of care, such as obtaining, completing and filing paperwork or transporting the body. Families may have a home funeral without having a green burial and visa versa. Blended funerals offer families more options, especially when certain options are not available in their area.

***Burial Density*** The size, depth, ratio, and distance of burial plots from each other in an acre of a cemetery. Green burial plots are typically larger than conventional burial plots and are determined by terrain.

***Burial Ground, Cemetery, Preserve*** Burial ground, cemetery, and preserve are all different names used in relation to conservation burial grounds.

***Burial Plot, Burial Space*** The space in which a body is buried.

***Carrying Capacity*** The number of people, animals, or crops which a region can support without environmental degradation.

***Caskets*** Containers for the dead, previously called coffins. The terminology appears to have evolved as a marketing tool to emphasize the precious cargo. “Casket” (from Middle English *casse*, and Anglo-Norman French, *cassette*) was originally used to denote a small ornamental box, case, or chest for carrying jewels, letters or other valuable items. Conventional caskets are built of steel, copper, and other metals, fiberglass, and exotic woods. Many are dressed with symbolic or religious icons, jewels, engravings, fittings, or trimming (fabric lining).

***Casket carts, carriages, or wagons*** A non-motorized means of transporting the body to the gravesite.

***Celebrant*** A professional trained in designing and officiating at customized ceremonies that reflect the needs, beliefs, and values of the person being honored. Many celebrants are trained in non-denominational and/or interfaith rituals. Many clergy are celebrants but not all celebrants are ordained clergy.

**Cenotaph** A monument, wall, bench, stone, or other structure engraved with the name(s) of the dead; often placed in a central location in a cemetery and used in place of an individual grave marker.

**Clergy** A person ordained to perform specific religious duties; the duties and titles vary among religions (minister, brother/sister, pastor, rector, priest, deacon, apostle, bishop, chaplain, rabbi, etc.)

**Coffins** Six- or eight-sided containers for the dead used for burial or cremation. Eight-sided coffins, also called “toe-pinchers,” may be designed to conserve wood or to emphasize the shape of the human inside (wide shoulders tapering to small feet). Plain pine boxes tend to be thought of as coffins, though there is no limitation. Derived from the Greek word *kophinos*, meaning “basket.”

**Committal service** An elective ritual that occurs after a funeral service ideally at the graveside; literally “committing the body or ashes to the earth and the care of God”

**Companion grave** A grave in which two bodies are buried side by side in the same unit.

**Conservation** The act of preserving, protecting, or restoring the natural environment, natural ecosystems, vegetation, and wildlife.

**Conservation Burial Ground** A type of natural cemetery that is established in partnership with a conservation organization and includes a conservation management plan that upholds best practices, and provides perpetual protection of the land according to a conservation easement or deed restriction.

**Conservation Easement** A voluntary legal agreement between a landowner and a land trust (or government agency) that permanently limits the uses of the land in order to protect its conservation values.

**Conservation Management Plan** A working plan that is a tool for identifying and implementing the practices needed to properly manage a conservation property.

**Conservation Objectives** Objectives which seek to identify values of the land that are important to preserving and restoring native habitat, hosting species, watersheds, and other defining features that support ecological, biological, and human communities.

**Conservation Organizations** Nonprofits and governmental entities organized to acquire, monitor, and manage land, rivers, forests, and other natural resources in order to preserve and protect them through prudent management.

**Conservation Policies** Set of internal rules aimed at conserving or restoring a declining species, a community, an ecosystem, or a natural or semi-natural site.

**Conservation Values** Evaluation of a property for its conservation features and resources—such as wildlife and plant habitat, connectivity, water quality, working lands—that deserve preservation or protection through deliberate action.

**Contiguous** Sharing a common border; touching.

**Conventional cemetery** A cemetery that requires the use of a concrete or fiberglass grave liner and a hard-bottom casket; also known as a “lawn cemetery” or a “modern cemetery.” Prior to the establishment of modern cemeteries, most burial occurred in churchyards or on family land and was environmentally friendly. Modern cemetery requirements are dictated by “convention” rather than law.

**Cremation** The process of reducing the body of the deceased to bone fragments and ashes by the use of high heat; the cremation of an average body uses enough natural gas and electricity to produce 140 lbs. of CO<sub>2</sub>.

**Cultural Resources** Historic, scenic, and recreational assets of significant value, such as: evidence of early cellar holes, barns, outbuildings, orchards, agricultural buildings or artifacts, or recreational structures; vista views, water frontage, unique natural features, or sky views; logging or other forestry or agricultural roads or pathways for

walking or hiking. [See Natural Resources Inventory]

**Decedent** The dead person

**Decomposition** The breakdown of the body by natural means (soil, water, heat and microbes in balance); natural decomposition, the goal of green burial, occurs when no chemicals or non-biodegradable elements (steel, resins, fabrics, cement vaults) impede the process or attempt to preserve the body.

**Deed restrictions** Private agreement listed in the deed that restricts the use of the land. [See *Conservation easements*]

**Dry ice** The solid form of carbon dioxide; may be used to cool and preserve a body temporarily during a *home funeral(home vigil)*. Dry ice must be handled carefully to avoid skin burns and requires good ventilation due to off-gassing of CO<sub>2</sub>.

**Eco-friendly** Products and practices designed to have a range of effects on the environment, from being beneficial to being the least damaging available option

**Ecological Assessment (EcIA)** A document that provides information, guidance, and support for changes in land management regarding agricultural, forestry, and other activities; may be conducted on its own or as part of a broader environmental assessment that identifies and evaluates the possible impact on ecosystems and assists in formulating plans that ensure best biodiversity outcomes. [See *Best Management Practices*]

**Ecologically appropriate features** Natural, inanimate elements of the landscape such as rocks, water features, native or adapted vegetation, and un-vegetated ground.

**Ecological Objectives** Objectives that seek to understand the nature of environmental influences on individual organisms, their populations, and communities. Ecological objectives are the measurable actions that support realization of stated ecological goals.

**Embalming** The process of removing blood and fluids from the dead body and inserting preservatives, surfactants, solvents, and coloration to slow decomposition and improve looks for a period of up to two weeks. Organs are punctured and drained of fluid with the use of a sharp instrument called a trocar; waste is disposed of in a standard septic system or municipal wastewater treatment plant.

**Embalming fluid** An array of chemicals, including benzene, methanol, ethyl alcohol, and ethylene glycol (antifreeze). Formaldehyde, which constitutes anywhere from 5 to 29% of the solution, is associated with increased risk of ALS (Amyotrophic Lateral Sclerosis), leukemia, lymph hematopoietic malignancies, and brain cancer in embalmers.

**Endemic** Refers to a species whose natural range is restricted to a particular area.

**Endowment Fund** A fund required by most states for long-term cemetery maintenance; some cemeteries call it a “perpetual care fund”, “care and maintenance trust fund”, or “long-term restoration fund”.

**Excavation** The act of digging a grave.

**Fieldstone** A naturally formed stone harvested directly from the earth on or near the cemetery property; they may be engraved, left in their natural form on a grave surface, and not polished or set in footings.

**Flora** The plants of a particular region, habitat, or geological period.

**Geographic Information System (GIS)** The system used to capture, track, and record grave locations by source data, including latitude, longitude and elevation coordinates.

**Geology** The branch of science that deals with the history of the earth, especially as recorded in rocks.

**Global Positioning System (GPS)** A radio navigation system utilizing satellites that is often used in green cemeteries in lieu of monuments to establish and map grave location. GPS is accurate in all weather conditions and all hours of the day, making it universally accessible in most locations.

**Grave Decoration** Items placed or arranged to enhance the appearance of the grave. Site appropriate native plantings are not considered decoration, but help fulfill grieving families' need to "leave a mark" that makes the grave prettier. However, true grave decorations that do not fit in with a natural aesthetic are discouraged (some conservation burial sites do not allow them at all). This includes coping (surrounding the grave with an oval of stone), holiday decorations, beer or liquor bottles, framed photos, etc. Cut flowers are encouraged, but not those that contain invasive seeds. Other acceptable grave decorations include transient items such as bird nests, etc.

**Grave Liner** An outer burial container that only covers the top and side of the casket, usually made of plastic, fiberglass, or metal. [See Outer Burial Container]

**Green Burial** A way of caring for the dead with minimal environmental impact that aids in the conservation of natural resources, reduction of carbon emissions, protection of worker health, and the restoration and/or preservation of habitat. Green burial necessitates the use of non-toxic and biodegradable materials, such as caskets, shrouds, and urns.

**Green Burial Ground** Green burial ground or a green burial cemetery is a generalized term often used synonymously with natural burial ground.

**Green burial movement** The growing interest in, development of, and grassroots advocacy for, green (natural) burial throughout the world.

**Green cemetery** See *Green Burial Ground*.

**Green embalming fluid** A biodegradable, non-toxic, non-carcinogenic, and formaldehyde-free alternative to conventional embalming fluid. The process of embalming is the same regardless of which fluid is used.

**Green embalming or professional green body preparation** The services provided by a funeral director that will culminate in a green burial; non-invasive, natural means of cleansing and preparing the body. If embalming is necessary or requested, the GBC approves an essential oil-based product.

**Green funeral** A general term used to describe post-death care, from death to disposition, using only natural means (nontoxic preservation techniques and organic materials with minimal carbon footprint); sometimes confused with the term "home funeral," "green burial," or "home burial."

**Green-washing** The act of deceptively marketing goods or services by hiding dubious aspects of their environmental profile. In the case of green burial, the full picture of environmentally sound practices is important. Using a casket of organic materials but made by using fossil fuels and child labor and transported 3000 miles to its destination is not considered "green" (environmentally sound).

**Habitat conservation** A land management practice that conserves, protects and restores habitat for plants and wildlife; an essential element of conservation burial practices.

**Hemp ropes or straps** Naturally made assistive devices for lowering coffins and shrouded bodies into the ground during natural burial, usually involving family and friends.

**Home burial** The practice of full body interment on residential land, usually in a rural setting. Local zoning and health department regulations apply, as do state-approved setbacks for known sources of water, buildings and highways. Often these are considered family cemeteries and must be established and reported as such to government agencies and are usually restricted to blood relatives or extended family.

**Home funeral** The process of family and friends, next of kin, or designated agent retaining custody and control of the body for the time period between death and disposition (burial or cremation); sometimes referred to as *home vigil* or DIY funeral. A home funeral involves bathing and dressing the body and using dry ice, Techni-ice, or other cooling mechanism as a preservative; it commonly lasts 1-3 days. A *home funeral guide* may provide education and support either prior to or during this time period.

**Home funeral movement** The growing interest in, grassroots advocacy for, and support of, home funeral; the home funeral movement started in the 1980's.

**Home vigil** A home vigil is similar to a home funeral; the terms may be used interchangeably. A home vigil may refer to the practice of family and friends sitting with the body continuously while lying in honor in the home, or it may simply refer to the time period from death to disposition.

**Hybrid Burial Ground** A cemetery that allows vaults and offers green burial.

**Hydrology** The branch of science concerned with the properties of the earth's water, and especially its movement in relation to land.

**Integrated Pest Management (IPM) System** A system in which biological, cultural, mechanical/physical and/or chemical factors are evaluated to create a long-term pest management plan that minimizes danger to people, property, and the environment; frequently used in green burial cemeteries to enhance the environmental mission.

**Interment** Burial of the full body or the cremated remains of the deceased in a grave.

**Invasive Plants** Plants that grow so profusely that they take over. Usually not native, though there are some natives which can take over in areas that have been altered. Being non-native does not mean that a plant is invasive.

**Islamic burial** Any of a number of burial practices common to the Islamic faith, depending on the sect, including: collective bathing of the body, shrouding of the body, prayer (*salah*), unfettered burial of the shrouded body in the grave within 24 hours, and positioning of the head facing towards Mecca. Cremation is forbidden to Muslims.

**Jewish burial** Any of a number of burial practices common to the Jewish faith, including: burial within one day of death, wrapping the body in a white linen shroud made without knots, using a plain, wooden coffin containing no metal, and providing for direct contact with the earth (achieved by drilling holes in the bottom of the coffin, using a bottomless vault, or having a green burial).

**Landscaping** In the context of conservation burial should focus on ecological restoration and design. To the extent possible, infrastructure should be green. Plant material should be site appropriate in terms of habitat and locale, with a focus on local cultivars.

**Life cycle assessment or analysis** The analysis of the potential impact on the environment of a particular product, process or service over its lifespan, including its extraction, production, distribution, consumption, and disposal.

**Life cycle costing (LCC)** The accounting process used to evaluate the economic possibilities of products or systems over their useful lives by evaluating the cost of operation and maintenance.

**Lowering device** A mechanical device used in a conventional cemetery that aids in lowering a casket into the ground. *Hemp ropes or straps* are often used for this purpose in a green burial.

**Meadow burial** Burial in a field-like setting where grasses are allowed to grow and are mowing occurs once a year; a green burial practice.

**Memorialization** The process of honoring the dead by marking where a burial has taken place; can include an engraved headstone or stone monument with a written account of the person being commemorated, a QR code, a photo, object, or in the case of a green or natural burial, a fieldstone, wooden bench, tree, shrub, or sculptural art using natural materials. Memorialization in conservation burial grounds is minimal, consists of natural materials,

and preferably those derived from the conserved property.

**Memorial Markers** Memorials/grave markers in conservation burial can be live as in memorial vegetation; inert as in stones, benches or naming opportunities; or virtual memorials based on GPS that provides more than names and dates. These memorials can be site specific to the graves themselves or at some distance (as in a cenotaph or memorial wall with names inscribed). In all cases, the memorials should not detract from a natural aesthetic, and if possible should be ecologically functional and appropriate to the ecological and geological context.

**Memorial service** A gathering of mourners at which the body is not present.

**Monitoring** The act of observing, checking, or keeping a continuous record of something. Easement monitoring is conducted on a scheduled basis to observe the condition of the conservation easement property to determine whether it is in compliance with easement terms.

**Native Plants** Plants that are indigenous to a specific habitat. Native plants include those species understood as indigenous, occurring in natural associations in habitats that existed prior to significant human impacts and alterations of the landscape.

**Natural Burial Ground** A type of cemetery that allows full body interment in the ground, without embalming, using a biodegradable container, and without a grave liner or vault. Cremated remains and pet remains may be accepted in natural burial grounds.

**Natural Resources Inventory** A document that inventories the natural resources of an area, collects the data in a usable format and interprets the findings. Natural resource inventories provide solid baseline data for long-term monitoring and management and allow for comparisons between existing and desired conditions.

**Natural viewing** The viewing of an un-embalmed body; typically the body has been prepared for viewing in the home or in an outdoor setting.

**Opening and closing** The digging and filling of a grave, the fee for which is separate from that of the burial plot. Some green cemeteries allow families to assist in digging the grave, though many cemeteries prefer a groundskeeper to perform this task for the protection of surrounding vegetation and for safety and liability reasons. Many green cemeteries allow or encourage families to replace the soil layers (fill the grave) as a part of the graveside ceremony.

**Outer Burial Container** An outer burial container is either a burial vault or a grave liner that encases a casket or shrouded body. Both are used to support the soil around the casket from subsidence in most non-green burial cemeteries to minimize cemetery maintenance by keeping the lawn flat for mowing. [See Vault and Grave Liner]

**Permaculture** Agricultural systems and principles that are sustainable and self-sufficient; working with natural forces in land management and conservation to minimize labor and maximize efficiency without depleting the land.

**Plat map** A specialized map that identifies where all the plots will be located. Some green cemeteries do not follow a rigid placement of *plots* on a *plat* grid.

**Plot** The space in which a body is buried.

**Preneed arrangements** Arrangements made prior to death, including gravesite selection. *Preneed arrangements* can be made without pre-paying, although funeral homes and cemeteries usually encourage pre-paying; consumer protection groups recommend not paying.

**Regional harvesting** The practice of acquiring materials generated from within a 500-mile radius of the job site through harvesting, extraction or processing.

**Restoration Ecology** The practice of renewing, restoring, or assisting in the recovery and management of degraded, damaged, or destroyed ecosystems and habitat. Restoration cemeteries may have areas in need of environmental restoration of plant systems, or need supplementation to provide optimum habitat for wildlife to restore the proper

balance to the ecosystem within and surrounding the burial ground. Along with improving biodiversity, restoration ecology also involves developing sustainable cultural practices and providing regional and historical context.

**Restored green cemetery** An un-used or unkempt cemetery that has been purchased, gifted or otherwise transferred to be revitalized and repurposed through green burial; it may have been historical, abandoned, filled up, underfunded, or reverted from private to municipal.

**Serial burial** The practice of re-using burial space after a determined length of time, usually 20-30 years, *ad infinitum*. This practice is common in other countries; there are no known laws against it in the US. By contrast, conventional US cemeteries may allow a one-time *double depth* burial where a spouse is buried on top of an existing grave.

**Shrouding board** A board designed to securely carry a shroud-wrapped body to the grave; also known as a body board or trundle coffin. The board may be simple or ornate, and may be buried with the body or removed prior to interment for re-use.

**Shroud** Fabric cloth or sheet that is wrapped around the deceased for burial; often shrouds have a built-in rigid board for carrying, or are carried on a *shrouding board*.

**Sustainable agriculture** Food, fiber, or other plant or animal farming techniques that support the environmental mission and contribute to the financial health of a green burial cemetery.

**Techni-Ice** An effective, non-toxic, reusable dry ice replacement used to cool the body of the deceased; it is purchased in plastic sheets, activated and frozen. Unlike *dry ice*, it does not off-gas or cause vapors or condensation, and can be re-used indefinitely

**Vault** A container made of concrete, plastic or metal, that encloses a coffin or casket to help prevent a grave from sinking and provide some protection from the elements. The vault is installed into the grave. At the burial, the casket is placed inside the vault and sealed. Generally, outer burial containers are not required by state or local laws, but they are oftentimes required by conventional cemeteries to prevent the grave from collapse due to heavy maintenance equipment and ground settling. Also known as burial vault, grave vault, cemetery vault. [See Outer Burial Container]

**Wake** A period of keeping *watch* or *vigil* with the body of the deceased that may involve prayer, music, reading, storytelling or other rituals and family traditions; derived from a time when witnesses stayed by the body to be certain the person did not “wake up.”

**Weeds** A weed is a plant that is not valued where it is growing. It usually is known to have vigorous growth and can be native or non-native.

### **Wildlife Habitat**

A combination of food, water, shelter, and space arranged to meet the needs of birds, butterflies, beneficial insects, and small animals. Trees, shrubs, and other plants provide shelter and food.

**Woodland burial** A burial in the forest among the trees; gravesites are left alone to naturalize with little or no interference from groundskeepers other than to provide access to the gravesite.

**Xeriscaping** Landscaping that conserves water by using plants with low water needs, soil amendments that retain moisture, and mulching to reduce evaporation; intended to eliminate or greatly reduce artificial irrigation.

## **Green Burial Massachusetts, Inc.**

### **Examples of Green Burial Rules in Massachusetts Cemeteries**

**This document contains information compiled in June 2023.**

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**Barre - <https://www.townofbarre.com/index.asp?SEC=3C64DD49-9F3A-419C-B788-83040822547A&DE=70DABAC8-F5B6-49EF-88F7-F0E271D53626>**

#### **Green Burial Rules**

1. Green Burials are only allowed where permitted by the Cemetery Commission which is currently only in Jane King Cemetery.
2. The body of the deceased is to be prepared in an environmentally friendly way. Embalming and other preservatives as well as pesticides and/or weed killers are not permitted in this area.
3. The decedent's representative shall employ a licensed Funeral Director to oversee natural burials to ensure that all Massachusetts Regulations pertaining to the handling and transportation of bodies are followed.
4. Vaults are not utilized in green burials. Burial in a casket is not required. However, if one is used, it must be made of biodegradable material such as shroud, pine or cardboard container. Any clothing or shroud used to cover the body is to be readily biodegradable.
5. Burial depth will be three - four feet and the grave will be mounded to allow for settling.
6. Rules for fees, plantings and memorials are the same as for other town cemeteries.
7. Sequential burial will be used to minimize disturbance to the land, vegetation, and graves. One may pre-purchase the right to be buried; however, the actual site isn't assigned until time of need.
8. Town residents (only) may purchase the right to bury. A single lot is 5ft x 10ft; and the location of the grave will be at the discretion of the Cemetery Commission.

#### **Bolton -**

**[https://www.townofbolton.com/sites/g/files/vyhlf2836/f/uploads/rules\\_and\\_regulations\\_26\\_july\\_2022.pdf](https://www.townofbolton.com/sites/g/files/vyhlf2836/f/uploads/rules_and_regulations_26_july_2022.pdf)**

#### **Definitions**

"Green Burial" or "Natural Burial" is understood to be a burial method with fewer environmental impacts than a traditional burial. The body is not embalmed, caskets or burial shrouds are made of biodegradable material, and no concrete grave liner or vault is used. The body is placed directly in the soil to biodegrade naturally. The gravesite may have a natural stone marker or no marker at all.

#### **4. Interments**

- a. All burials shall be under the personal supervision of a Cemetery Committee member or the Committee's designate.

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- b. No interment will be made until all fees provided for in the then-current fee schedule adopted by the Committee has been paid. Any outstanding obligations due the Town, such as special service charges, must be paid before a grave is opened.
- c. All non-cremated burials shall be made in a concrete box of one-piece construction, together with a one- or two-piece cover of sufficient strength to permanently support the weight above it. See items f-m below for exceptions for Green Burial.
- d. All non-cremated burials shall be at a depth of approximately six feet, unless otherwise approved by the Committee or their designate.
- e. All cremation burials shall be at a depth of approximately eighteen inches. The location will be recorded on lot record cards.
- f. Green Burials will be permitted in the designated areas of West and Pan Cemetery.
- g. Green Burial containers may include caskets or shrouds, and must be made of natural, biodegradable and non-toxic/non-hazardous materials (e.g., untreated softwoods, wicker, bamboo, cardboard, wool, fiber, cloth, seagrass).
- h. No embalming fluids may be used in the preparation of the body. Removable medical devices are to be removed prior to burial. Any items buried with the body must be biodegradable.
- i. Shrouded bodies must be entirely wrapped and must be supported by a solid softwood board, such as pine, which stays in the grave. Plywood and particle board are not acceptable.
- j. Graves are dug to a depth of 4 feet. Graves will be mounded and mulched and allowed to return to their natural state. Cut flowers may be placed on top of a recent burial; otherwise, no decorations are allowed in the Green Burial section.
- k. Grave markers are permitted, but not required. Flat, natural fieldstone or granite markers should be no larger than 1' x 2". The stone may be engraved, but not polished. The top should be flush with the ground.
- l. Vaults and grave liners are not permitted in the Green Burial section.
- m. The Green Burial area will be maintained to preserve the natural environment.

**Brewster - [https://www.brewster-ma.gov/sites/g/files/vyhlf6286/f/uploads/cemetery\\_rules\\_and\\_regulations\\_updated\\_2020.pdf](https://www.brewster-ma.gov/sites/g/files/vyhlf6286/f/uploads/cemetery_rules_and_regulations_updated_2020.pdf)**

#### **IV. RULES FOR TOWN OF BREWSTER GREEN BURIAL**

1. The Town of Brewster does not provide interment services at any of the Town cemeteries. The services of a contractor approved by the Brewster Department of Public Works (DPW) should be secured for excavation for interment in Section "C".
2. A burial vault (partial, inverted, or otherwise), vault lid, concrete box, slab or partitioned liner should not be used.
3. The deceased should not be embalmed prior to a green burial.

Compiled June 2023. Please consult original sources for current rules.

4. A burial container is not required, but if used, it should be a biodegradable one such as wicker, cardboard, or untreated soft wood, and must be nontoxic/nonhazardous. If a shroud is used, it must be made of natural fibers like wool, fiber, cloth, cardboard, seagrass, bamboo, wicker, hemp, or paper maché.
5. Only one full body burial is permitted in each gravesite.
6. The deceased may be brought to the cemetery by a funeral director or the deceased's family and friends.
7. If not using the services of a funeral director, arrangements must be made for a town representative to be present to oversee procedures at the cemetery.
8. The funeral director or family is responsible for arranging for the deceased to be transferred from the transport vehicle to the burial site, making sure to meet the necessary strength and mobility standards required for the task.
9. Burial depth will be three and one-half (3½) feet to the bottom of the container or shroud.
10. Graves will be mounded and allowed to return to their natural state following burial.
11. The site marker should be a flat natural fieldstone or quarried stone, no larger than 2 feet by 1 foot and set without a foundation.
12. Natural wreaths and flowers are permitted. No plantings, artificial flowers, vases, potted plants or other decorations are permitted.
13. Unless a tree is deemed unsafe, unhealthy or contrary to conservation goals, all live trees will be left in place.
14. Pathways will be mowed.

**Cambridge – Mt. Auburn - <https://viewer.joomag.com/cemetery-services-guidelines-for-natural-burial-at-mount-auburn/0812115001458581681>**

**Chesterfield -**

**[https://www.townofchesterfieldma.com/sites/g/files/vyhlf7606/f/uploads/cemetery\\_rules\\_regs\\_4\\_12\\_21\\_final.pdf](https://www.townofchesterfieldma.com/sites/g/files/vyhlf7606/f/uploads/cemetery_rules_regs_4_12_21_final.pdf)**

Green Burials In the case of a “green” burial which foregoes the use of a vault/grave liner and even of a casket, where ground subsidence issues and relevance to equipment access and use may be of special concern, the Cemetery Commission reserves its prerogative to restrict such burials to certain lots or a designated area of a Town cemetery as it and/or the Cemetery Superintendent may determine. Such a burial may be in whatever shroud or container the family chooses as long as it is biodegradable.

Compiled June 2023. Please consult original sources for current rules.

greenburialma.org

#### **Chilmark -**

**[https://www.chilmarkma.gov/sites/g/files/vyhlf8411/f/pages/chilmark\\_cemetery\\_regulations\\_and\\_policies\\_2021.pdf](https://www.chilmarkma.gov/sites/g/files/vyhlf8411/f/pages/chilmark_cemetery_regulations_and_policies_2021.pdf)**

B. "Green Burial" is defined, for the purpose of these regulations, as a burial where the deceased is buried in a casket made of soft wood or other biodegradable materials like cardboard or wicker or is buried in a shroud made of natural fabric. The casket, shroud or natural burial trundle (wooden tray with handles used for transport or lowering) rests directly on the earth at a depth of 3.5ft - 4ft. No embalming chemicals, cement vault, grave liner, hardwoods, metals, plastics or non-biodegradable items are allowed in the grave.

C. Burial sites in the so called "King Plot" measure 4'x4' and are suitable for cremains only and one (1) upright or one (1) flat stone.

D. Cement liners and embalming are not required for burials.

#### **Gill -**

**[https://gillmass.org/files/Gill\\_Cemetery\\_Commission\\_Guidelines\\_for\\_Riverside\\_Woods\\_Jan2020.pdf](https://gillmass.org/files/Gill_Cemetery_Commission_Guidelines_for_Riverside_Woods_Jan2020.pdf)**

##### **Riverside Woods Natural Burial Ground**

1. The body of the deceased is to be prepared in an environmentally friendly way as described by the Green Burial Council standards for natural burial; embalming is not permitted. Any clothing, shroud, or coffin used to cover the body is to be readily biodegradable. Non-degradable objects may not be buried with the body.

2. The body may be brought to the cemetery by a funeral director, or by family and friends of the deceased. A board and straps may be used to lower the body into the grave or a contracted lowering device may be used. Arrangements must be made in advance with the Cemetery Commissioners if a funeral director is not used.

3. The deceased's family and friends may participate in the burial of the body to the extent they desire, subject to approval by the Cemetery Commissioners.

4. Shrouded burials are allowed with a biodegradable burial board. Burial in a casket is not required, However, if one is used, it must be made of biodegradable material such as pine, sea grasses, willow, or cardboard container.

5. Burial depth will be three - four feet to the bottom of the grave and the grave will be mounded to allow for settling.

6. Grave marker must be made from natural rock, such as fieldstone or river rock. Marble, granite and other impermeable rock/stone is not permitted. Grave markers may not exceed 400 square inches in size (or 18" by 18") and may not rest more than 3" above grade lying flat to the ground. No foundation is allowed. The grave marker may be engraved with the deceased's name, the date of birth, date of their death.

7. We use sequential burial to minimize disturbance to the land, vegetation, and graves. One may pre-purchase the right to be buried; however the actual site isn't assigned until time of need.

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8. The location of the grave will be at the discretion of the Cemetery Commission. Space will be saved so that partners may be buried in adjacent lots.
9. There shall be no planting or cutting of vegetation except with the written permission of the Cemetery Commission.
10. Winter burials will be at the discretion of the Cemetery Commission and weather conditions.

### **Lexington - <https://www.lexingtonma.gov/175/Green-Burials>**

#### **GREEN BURIALS**

The Town of Lexington offers Green Burials at Westview Cemetery. In addition to the standard Westview Cemetery Rules and Regulations, Green Burials must also abide by the following rules.

##### **Rules for Green Burials**

Green Burials may only be performed in the sections designated for Green Burials.

Remains must be properly cared for, secured, and kept in refrigeration before arriving at Westview Cemetery for a Green Burial.

Funeral home service is required to handle remains for a Green Burial.

Green Burials must use an approved type of decomposing wood coffin. No interment may be made without an approved wood coffin.

Only one body burial per grave is allowed in any Green Burial sections.

No concrete vault liners, cremation burials, or disinterment will be allowed in any Green Burial sections.

Grave markers for Green Burials will be Two feet x One foot flush markers made of either granite or bronze. No other markers will be allowed in any Green Burial sections.

All other rules and regulations of Westview Cemetery must be followed. For more information on green burials visit Green Burial Massachusetts' website.

### **Montague**

#### **Policy for Natural Burials – Highland Woods Cemetery**

1. The natural burial section of Highland Cemetery is reserved for burial that does not use a vault (partial, inverted or otherwise), concrete liner, slab, or partitioned liner.
2. No embalming is permitted during body preparation. Clothing or a shroud in which the body is wrapped is to be readily biodegradable. The Cemetery Commission reserves the right to refuse a body that is not properly prepared. Non-biodegradable objects may not be buried with the body.
3. Burial containers are to be limited to those made from biodegradable materials such as untreated softwoods, cardboard, wicker, fiber, etc.
4. Shrouded bodies must be entirely wrapped and be supported on a solid softwood board for lowering. Plywood and particle support boards are not acceptable.

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5. The body of the deceased may be brought to the cemetery by a funeral director, or by family of the deceased with the proper paperwork from the Board of Health.
6. The deceased's family and friends may fill in the grave to the extent they desire, with advance notice to the Cemetery Commission.
7. A board and straps may be used to lower the body into the grave or a contracted lowering device may be used.
8. Burial depth will be 3.5 - 4 feet from the natural surface to the bottom of the grave and the grave will be mounded for settling to return to its natural state.
9. Grave markers are permitted but not required. Natural fieldstone, quarried stone or river rock may be used. Marble, granite and other impermeable rock/stone is not permitted. The grave marker must not be polished. Grave markers may not exceed approximately 18" x 18" inches and may not rest more than 3" above grade lying flat to the ground. No foundation is permitted. The Town shall not be responsible for damage to any markers.
10. No plantings, vases or potted plants are permitted. No artificial flowers or other decorations may be placed on graves. Natural wreaths and flowers are permitted provided that are rested on the ground directly in front of the marking or at the foot of the grave if no marker is used and do not contain and packaging, decorations, ribbons or the like. The Town of Montague shall not be liable for items left at a grave, or damage to any such items to weather, vandalism theft or wear and tear.
11. The cemetery adheres to sequential burial to minimize disturbance to the land, vegetation and graves. One may pre-purchase the right to be buried, however, the actual site is not assigned until the time of need. The location of the grave is at the discretion of the Cemetery Commission. Space may be saved so that partners may be buried in adjacent plots.
12. Only one body is allowed per gravesite. One cremation burial may be included in the same gravesite as one body.
13. Non-Montague residents are permitted to be buried in Highland Woods.
14. All graves are opened and filled-in by a paid contractor, unless family members or friends of the deceased elect to fill-in the grave.
15. Gravesite size is 4 feet x 8 feet.
16. This policy shall supersede all provisions of the Rules and Regulations of the Montague Cemetery Commission only with respect to so-called "Green Burials" or "Natural Burials". All other provisions of said Rules and Regulations shall apply in the Highland Woods Cemetery to the extent that they are not inconsistent with this Policy.

**Wellfleet - <https://www.wellfleet-ma.gov/cemetery-commissioners>**

10A.Green Burial shall mean a burial that allows the body to decompose naturally, returning all elements to the earth through environmentally sound practices. A Green Burial may incorporate the following essential elements: an un-embalmed body wrapped in a biodegradable shroud (cotton, wool, silk, hemp, etc.) and buried on a natural burial trundle (wooden tray with handles), or in a coffin made solely of biodegradable materials (cardboard, wood, willow, bamboo, seagrass, felt, etc.), or placed directly onto the earth without a trundle or a coffin.

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10B.Green burial graves shall be a minimum of 4 feet deep (to the bottom of the remains. Green Burials require a backfill height of 3-5 feet to allow for the natural settling of earth.

**Wenham –**

**[https://cms4files1.revize.com/wenhamma/Wenham%20Cemetery%20Rules%20%20Regulations\\_16NOV2021\\_%20\(1\).pdf](https://cms4files1.revize.com/wenhamma/Wenham%20Cemetery%20Rules%20%20Regulations_16NOV2021_%20(1).pdf)**

Green Burials, defined as a burial without embalming and not utilizing permanent vaults and/or caskets, SHALL be available only at Iron Rail Cemetery and SHALL be conducted only in accordance with any Massachusetts state regulations. Green burials SHALL use a shroud or biodegradable container. The burial SHALL be at a minimum depth of four feet. A flat marker of at least one foot square centered at the head of the burial SHALL be required if no permanent gravestone is being emplaced.

**West Tisbury – [https://www.westtisbury-](https://www.westtisbury-ma.gov/sites/g/files/vyhlf8396/f/uploads/cemetery_rules_and_regulations_11-06-19.pdf)**

**[ma.gov/sites/g/files/vyhlf8396/f/uploads/cemetery\\_rules\\_and\\_regulations\\_11-06-19.pdf](https://www.westtisbury-ma.gov/sites/g/files/vyhlf8396/f/uploads/cemetery_rules_and_regulations_11-06-19.pdf)**

In the case of a Green Burial, burial in a casket is not required. However if one is used, it must be of biodegradable material such as pine or cardboard.

viii. In the case of a Green Burial where vault/grave liner and possibly a casket may not be used, where ground subsidence issues and equipment access may be of concern, the Cemetery Commission reserves the right to restrict such burials to certain plots or a designated area of a town cemetery as the Cemetery Superintendent or Cemetery Commission deems necessary.

ix. In the case of Green Burials the body of the deceased is to be prepared in an environmentally friendly way; embalming is not permitted. Any clothing or shroud used to cover the body is to be of biodegradable material. Non-degradable objects may not be buried with the body.

x. In the case of Green Burials the body may be brought to the cemetery by an undertaker, or by family and friends of the deceased. A board and straps may be used to lower the body into the grave.

xi. In the case of Green Burials participation in preparation of the grave and in the burial of the body is subject to the approval of the Cemetery Superintendent.

xii. In the case of Green Burials burial will be at a depth of 4 feet. A stone marker not larger than nine inches by twelve inches, engraved with the deceased's name, and the year of birth and death, may be placed flat to the ground at the foot of the grave.

**Westford – <https://www.westfordma.gov/DocumentCenter/View/11057/Green-Burial-Booklet-Final-4-12-22>**

Green Burial in Westford

General Information and Guidelines

The Westford Cemetery Department offers the option for “green” or natural burial in a designated section at Pine Grove Cemetery. In a natural burial, a deceased person's body is not embalmed, and is laid to rest in a biodegradable shroud or casket. The grave is 3-4 feet deep, and no grave liner or vault is

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used or permitted. Graves are mounded and allowed to settle, and the native flora is maintained or restored. This section will be mown and landscaped somewhat differently than the rest of the cemetery, creating a more naturalistic appearance.

While today green burial may be considered a relatively new practice in the United States, nearly all burials were natural prior to the Civil War. Many people now choose green burial as a sustainable way of caring for the dead, as it promotes efficient decomposition, nourishes the soil, conserves natural resources, reduces carbon emissions, and restores and preserves native habitat. Some people choose natural burial for religious reasons. Others desire to reduce burial costs by making or purchasing a simple shroud or casket, and forgoing the purchase of embalming services and a grave liner or vault. To learn more about green burial, visit the Green Burial Massachusetts website:

<https://greenburialma.org/>

We offer the following guidelines for choosing a natural burial in Westford to help you plan ahead.

#### Choosing a Green Burial Lot

A green burial section at Pine Grove Cemetery has been developed with 148 lots. Please make an appointment with the Cemetery Department to view the site and purchase the lot(s) of your choice.

A printable price structure and information on “Burial Fees, Rights and Services” can be found on the Cemetery Department webpage on the Town website:

<https://westfordma.gov/1055/CemeteryDepartment>.

Requests for green burials outside the green burial section will be considered on a case-by-case basis.

#### Home Funerals and Conventional Funeral Home Options

Green burial is compatible with a myriad of funerary customs. Some people choose to hire a funeral director who is knowledgeable about green burial to prepare their loved one’s body and hold a service in a conventional funeral home.

Others choose a “home funeral” (also called a “home vigil” or “home wake”), in which the body of the deceased is kept at home – typically for 1-3 days – allowing family members and friends to gather and grieve together in a comfortable environment. Families who opt for home funerals may choose to take on the role of a funeral director, including preparing the body for vigil and burial, coordination of legal paperwork, obtaining the burial permit, holding a service, arranging the burial with the Cemetery Department, and transporting the body. A home funeral guide can assist families with this option. Some funeral directors are also willing to assist with a home funeral or assist with certain aspects while the family handles others. For example, the family may wish to prepare their loved one’s body for burial and arrange a vigil in the home, while hiring a funeral director only to handle the legal paperwork and transportation.

To learn more about home funerals, visit the National Home Funeral Alliance website:

<https://www.homefuneralalliance.org/>

To learn more about working without a funeral director, visit the Funeral Consumers Alliance of Eastern Massachusetts website: <https://fcaemass.org/resources/caring-for-your-own-dead/>

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[greenburialma.org](https://greenburialma.org)

Whether you opt for a home funeral or a more conventional arrangement with a funeral director, all applicable state laws must be followed. Pre-planning, when possible, is always advised.

#### Preparing the Body for Natural Burial

Any clothing, jewelry, or adornment to be interred with the body must be made of natural, biodegradable material.

It is important to keep the body cool to slow decomposition. There are simple methods for this to be done at home, such as the use of Techni-Ice packs or a similar cooling product. Many funeral homes have onsite refrigeration or use other cooling techniques. We recommend discussing this with a home funeral guide or funeral director. Caskets and shrouds must be free of visible bodily fluids upon arrival at the cemetery.

#### Shrouds and Shrouding Boards

A shroud is a cloth used to wrap and cover a body after a person has died. Green burial shrouds must be made of natural, biodegradable materials such as wool, cotton, linen, bamboo, or hemp. A shrouded body may be placed inside a biodegradable casket, but a casket is not required. A shrouded body without a casket must be entirely wrapped and placed on an untreated softwood (such as white pine) or wicker shrouding board, which meets the same biodegradability requirements as caskets (see below).

The board will help stabilize the body while being transported and lowered into the grave and will remain inside the grave. Plywood and particle board are not acceptable. A board with carrying handles that is at least as wide and as long as the body is recommended; please notify the Cemetery Department if a board will exceed 28-inches in width and 84-inches in length. Some shrouds have carrying handles sewn into the cloth and sleeves sewn into the bottom in which a narrower board can be inserted; the narrower board is acceptable since the body and board are held snugly together with ties, providing stability.

#### Caskets

Caskets may be constructed from untreated softwood, wicker, cardboard, or other natural, biodegradable materials, and must not be painted with toxic paint or varnish. They should be of sufficient strength to support the weight of the body. Wooden caskets should be held together with wooden dowels and non-toxic glues rather than metal fasteners. To minimize environmental impact, we recommend obtaining locally-made caskets. Some people prefer to make their own, using locallysourced or repurposed materials. Handmade caskets should conform to standard casket size; please notify the Cemetery Department if an oversized casket will be required.

#### The Green Burial Process

One full body burial is allowed in each green burial grave.

Families or funeral directors planning a natural burial must arrange for at least six people to be present at the cemetery who can safely lift and carry the shrouded body or casket a maximum of 100 feet from the vehicle to the gravesite. These individuals may also lower the body into the grave, if pre-arranged with the Cemetery Department; otherwise, a mechanical lowering device will be used.

Compiled June 2023. Please consult original sources for current rules.

Graves will be opened by cemetery personnel. Families and friends are welcome to help fill the graves after the body is lowered using shovels provided by the Cemetery Department. Personnel will complete the burial after the family departs. Cut flowers may be placed in and on top of the grave.

#### Perpetual Care of Natural Graves

Once a green burial grave is closed, the soil will be mounded, mulched, and allowed to settle, which could take a few weeks or several months. In keeping with green burial principals of sustainability and habitat preservation, cemetery personnel will re-seed or plant settled graves with native plant vegetation. No other plantings are allowed. Flower vases and decorations are not permitted in this section.

#### Memorialization

Upright headstones are not permitted on natural burial graves. Individual grave markers placed flush with the ground are permitted if desired, but not required. Markers must be flat, no larger than 2' W x 1' L, a minimum of 4" thick, and made of unpolished, locally-sourced, natural or quarried stone. Engraving of markers is permitted prior to placement. The Cemetery Department reserves the right to remove any marker that does not comply.

A Monument Permit Application must be submitted and approved by the Cemetery Department prior to placement of any marker. The monument company of your choice will have this form or it can be obtained from the Cemetery Department office or webpage by clicking [here](#).

Another option for memorialization is to have the decedent's name, year of birth, and year of death engraved on a large, granite, shared memorial stone that is situated in the natural burial area and owned by the cemetery. For more information about this option, please contact the Cemetery Department.

The Town of Westford Regulations for Municipal Cemeteries is available on the Westford Cemetery Department webpage by clicking [here](#) and at the Westford Cemetery Office.

Westford Cemetery Department personnel are committed to serving the community and visitors to our cemeteries. We are dedicated to maintaining and preserving our cemeteries and looking after the final resting places of our beloved departed citizens entrusted to our care. Please contact us if you need assistance, have any questions about green burials, or are interested in purchasing a green burial lot.

**Worthington – <https://worthington-ma.us/municipal-directory/cemetery-commissioners/>**

#### Rules for Green Burials:

Open to anyone—not just town residents

Available in any cemetery where plots are available (North and Ringville) and in any plot that has been purchased but not used

Burial will be in whatever shroud or biodegradable container the family chooses

The burial will be at a depth of four feet

A permanent flat marker of at least one foot by one foot centered and at the head of the burial is required

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[greenburialma.org](http://greenburialma.org)



Where to Find Green Burial

Conservation Cemetery

Resources

[MA Rules and Regulations](#)

[Library](#)

[Organizations](#)

[Products & Services](#)

[Caring for Your Own Dead in  
Massachusetts](#)

How You Can Help

## Massachusetts Rules and Regulations

Massachusetts General Law and Massachusetts Rules and Regulations for burial, cremation, and acting as your own funeral director.

### Trial Court Law Libraries

[Massachusetts law about burial, cremation, and funerals](#)

### Mass. Department of Environmental Protection

[Information for Local Boards of Health on Home Burials and Green Burials](#)

### Community Sanitation Program

[Issues to consider in preparing for disposition of decedents](#)

### Mass. General Laws Chapter 114

[Cemeteries and Burials](#)

### Mass. Division of Professional Licensure

[Consumer Fact Sheet on Funeral Directors](#)



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# NEW HAMPSHIRE FUNERAL RESOURCES & EDUCATION

[HOME](#)[HOW TO](#)[RESOURCES](#)[GREEN BURIAL](#)[PRESENTATIONS](#)[CONTACT](#)

*Welcome to NHFREA, where it is our mission to support informed funeral consumer choice through education and advocacy*

## *Making New Hampshire Funeral Information Easy to Find*

What to do when someone dies is a mystery to most of us. But there is movement to regain the lost skills and self-reliance of previous generations, driven by a vision of creating more affordable, eco-friendly, meaningful and authentic ways of memorializing and caring for our own dead ourselves, in our own homes, in our churches, and in our communities. This movement is gaining momentum, guided by ethical and environmentally conscious values, seeking more congruent methods and practices that reflect our vision for the planet and provide a sense of place for those left behind.

For many, that will mean learning how to conduct a home funeral; for others, it will mean searching for a funeral director who will honor their unique ideas; for still others it will mean advocating for change in our municipal cemetery, hospital, and government laws and policies. However this reform in funeral practices and responsibility resonates with you, we are here to educate, to support, and to nurture new ideas that will change the way we do death in the best possible ways.

## *Quick Find*

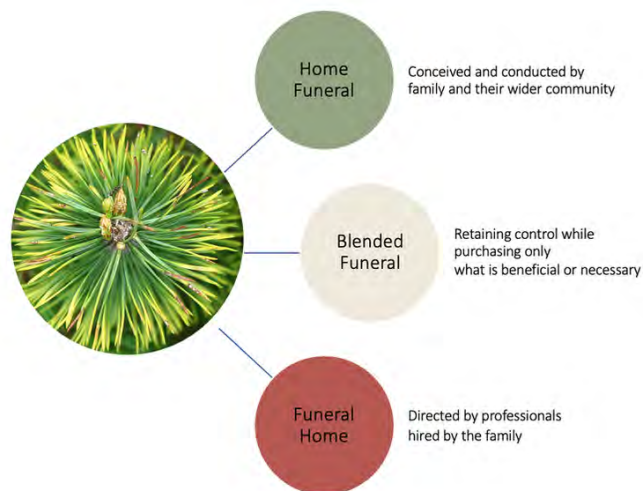
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- [Take our Green Burial Survey](#)
- [Find a Green Burial Cemetery](#)
- [2020 NH Funeral Home Survey and Cost Comparison Guide](#)
- [See our Vermont site here](#)
- [Funerary Artisans Collective website](#)
- Take the [Green Burial MasterClass](#) online any time
- [Learn more](#) about cremated remains scattering



In New Hampshire, no one is required to purchase the services of a funeral director or funeral home. Families may conduct any or all tasks commonly performed by a funeral home (except embalming which is not required by New Hampshire law), and may bury on their own property if certain provisions are met. Sometimes called "family-led after-death care" or "home funerals" this may include:

- bathing and dressing the deceased;
- sheltering the deceased at home;
- spending time with the deceased (sometimes called a wake, vigil, or viewing);
- filing the death certificate and obtaining a burial/transit permit;
- making arrangements for final disposition (generally burial or cremation);
- transporting the body home (or to another location) for care and viewing, and to place of final disposition;
- making arrangements for any ceremony.

### 3 Approaches to Funerals



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#### *Find a Speaker*

##### **Eco-friendly, Affordable, and Meaningful Funerals series**

OSHER Dartmouth

online

October 13, 20, 27

9 am

##### **Making a Clean (Energy) Getaway: Eco-friendly funeral practices and products**

Sanbornton Library

Sanbornton NH

April 18 or 25, 2024 (TBD)

6 pm

##### **Partnering with End-of-Life Doulas and After-Death Care Educators for Hospice Personnel**

St Anselm College Student Center

Manchester NH

March 7, 2024

##### **Burial on Land with Existing and Proposed Conservation Easements in New Hampshire**

February 2024

TBA



**Free and paid online classes at Redesigning the End.com**

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*Green Funeral Services*

*Douglas and After-Death Care: Bridging Both Worlds*

*Hospice and Home Funerals In-Service Series*

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JOIN US ON FACEBOOK

## *Meet Lee Webster, Funeral Reform Advocate*



As a writer, researcher, hospice volunteer, home funeral guide, conservationist, web designer, and frequent speaker on the benefits of home funerals and green burial, Lee Webster's career and volunteer service spans years in public relations and development for nonprofits, conservation groups, health agencies, private secondary schools, colleges and universities. She serves as the Executive Director of **New Hampshire Funeral Resources, Education & Advocacy**, is a former President and Vice Chair of Education of the **Green Burial Council**, and was a six-year VP and President of the **National Home Funeral Alliance**. She is a founding member of the **National End-of-Life Doula Alliance**, the **National Hospice and Palliative Care Organization's End-of-Life Doula Council**, and the **Conservation Burial Alliance**.

She is the author of several home funeral and green burial books, including **Changing Landscapes: Exploring the growth of ethical, compassionate, environmentally sustainable green funeral practices** and **The After-Death Care Advocate Handbook**, which includes titles previously published individually such as *Essentials for Practicing Home Funeral Guides*, *Building Bridges Along the Death Care Continuum: Advocating for home funerals in hospitals, hospices, and care facilities*, and the *Planning Guide and Workbook for Home Funeral Families*. She is a contributor to **The Future of the Corpse**, a collaborative book written with Columbia University's DeathLab. She has published articles and been interviewed for pieces that can be found in various news outlets, magazines, podcasts, and blogs, including *Natural Transitions*, *American Funeral Director*, *FuneralOne*, *Funeral Business Advisor*, *Newsweek*, *PhillyVoice*, *the New Yorker*, *the New York Times*, *The New Republic*, *DeathTalk*, *EOL University*, *The Wall Street Journal*, and many others. Webster is also responsible for content and maintenance of various death care websites through SideEffects Publishing, Inc.

Lee has developed several cornerstone courses for professionals and lay people seeking to learn more about green funerals and burials, including **Green Funeral Service**, **Doulas and After-Death Care: Bridging Both Worlds**, and **Hospice and Home Funerals In-Service Series**. Also co-taught with Holly Blue Hawkins through **Redesigning the End** is the 12-week online **Green Burial MasterClass** that covers the technical and ethical aspects of natural burial. She also assisted with instruction at the **Gamliel Institute** supporting David Zinner and Holly Blue Hawkins in teaching *Jewish and Green: Cemetery Management for the 21st Century*. All four courses are the first of their kind. She guest lectures and teaches frequently at colleges, universities, life-long learning programs, including OSHER at Dartmouth College, OLLI at UNH, Dartmouth's Aging Resource Center, and mortuary schools.

## How To

Learn About the Law  
Have a Home Funeral  
Complete Paperwork  
Perform Body Care  
Arrange Disposition  
Transport the Dead  
Create Ceremony  
Go Out Greener  
Pay for a Funeral  
Work With Professionals

## Resources

Articles, White Papers, Books  
In the News  
Community Advocacy  
Find Locally Made Products  
Find a Green Burial Cemetery  
Find It Fast

## Presentations

Find a Speaker for In-Services,  
Presentations, Events

## Learn More

About Green Burial  
Home Funeral Stories  
Funeral Price Survey  
Pandemic Care  
For Professionals  
Glossary  
FAQs

## Contact

Lee Webster  
PO Box 456  
Holderness NH 03245  
nhfrea@gmail.com  
603.236.9495



Search



*New Hampshire Funeral Resources, Education & Advocacy Designed and content provided by Lee Webster*  
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Where to Find Green Burial

Conservation Cemetery

Resources

How You Can Help

## Frequently Asked Questions

### What is Green Burial?

Green burial is a way of returning bodies to the earth after death. Called “green” burial for its ecological soundness, it is also commonly known as natural burial.

A green or natural burial uses no embalming, no metal casket, and no burial liner or vault; the marker, if used is typically flat. Proponents often refer to it as “traditional” burial because it reclaims the Civil War—one that is still used by some 90% of people elsewhere in the world. Because only biodegradable materials are used, in green burial a human body and its burial container enrich the soil.

### How is this Different from Conventional Burial?

For some, conventional burial—with embalming, metal or hardwood casket, and burial vault—offers comfort and predictability. But it can be very expensive, often at a time when families can least afford the expense. It also inhibits decomposition of the body and creates “landfills” of non-biodegradable and sometimes hazardous materials. By one estimate, each year we bury approximately:

- 4.3 million gallons of embalming fluid;
- 64,500 tons of steel, 2,700 tons of copper and bronze, and 20-plus million board feet of hardwoods, much of it tropical (for caskets); and
- 1.6-plus million tons of reinforced concrete and another 14,000 tons of steel, for burial vaults and foundations (*Green Burial Council 2014*).

In addition, we need to consider the resource consumption (water, fossil fuels) and byproducts (carbon dioxide, heavy metals, heat) in the manufacturing of these buried materials.

### What About Cremation?

Cremation is generally much less expensive than conventional burial. It permits greater flexibility, as cremated remains may be buried or scattered at the family’s convenience. Alternatively, cremated remains may be incorporated into various art forms, placed in coral reef balls, or even shot into space.

However, cremation requires sufficient fossil fuel to sustain a temperature of 1400° – 1700° F for about 90 minutes to four hours depending upon the manufacturer and age of the equipment. Cremation also produces a variety of air pollutants—particulate matter, carbon monoxide, mercury and dioxin, among others—resulting partly from the substances burned and partly from the combustion process itself.

In the context of an individual’s life time use of fossil fuels, a single cremation has a relatively small carbon footprint. Nationwide, however, the energy consumed by cremations in one year would drive a car to the moon over 2500 times (*Green Burial Council 2014*).

What about using the “ashes” as fertilizer in a memorial garden or to plant a tree? Unfortunately, cremated remains have high pH and salt levels, which can be harmful or even deadly to plant life.

## How Does Green Burial Work?

With green burial, a body is not embalmed. Refrigeration, dry ice or ice packs will cool the body if immediate burial is not possible or desired (see [National Home Funeral Alliance](#) for more information on home wakes). The body is enclosed in a biodegradable container, such as a pine box, a cardboard coffin or a natural-fiber shroud, and placed directly into the earth rather than into a concrete "outer burial container."

A flat memorial stone may be used, or a tree or other planting may serve as a grave marker (often in combination with some form of computer mapping such as GPS). Burial at a depth of 3½ to 4 feet will permit access by aerobic bacteria to enhance decomposition.

## Why Might One Want a Green Burial?

Any burial that uses green techniques will help to conserve resources, protect groundwater, and return bodily nutrients to the soil. For many people, protection of our resources is reason enough to want a more ecologically friendly exit.

For many proponents of dedicated natural burial ground in the U.S., though, green burial is much more than a benign form of burial. It is also a way of actively pursuing land preservation and restoration, in meadow or woodland settings where people can hike and picnic as well as bury loved ones.

We at Green Burial Massachusetts aim to open one or more burial grounds that will conserve land as well as restore death to its rightful place in cycle of life.

## Is Green Burial an Option in Massachusetts?

If you have sufficient land, it may be possible to have a green burial on your property. You'll need to get approval ahead of time from your local board of health.

Towns and private cemeteries are increasingly permitting natural burial, essentially by not requiring use of a burial vault. Please visit our [cemetery database](#) or give us a call (617) 393-5011 for a listing of the towns we know of in which a green burial is possible. As we learn of other towns and cities where natural burial is available, we'll add them to our website. And please [tell us](#) if you know of one we should add!

We do not yet have a dedicated green cemetery in Massachusetts, but we are working on it. See the [Valley Conservation Cemetery Project](#). New York has one ([Greensprings Natural Cemetery Preserve](#), near Ithaca; (607) 564-7577). Maine has two ([Cedar Brook Burial Ground](#), near Portland; (207) 637-2085; and Baldwin Hill Conservation Cemetery, Fayette, ME, about three hours drive north of Boston, [info@baldwinhillcemetery.org](mailto:info@baldwinhillcemetery.org) or phone at (207) 377-2848).

## What Can I Do to Further Green Burial in Massachusetts?

- Call the cemetery you're thinking of using and ask whether green burial is permitted. If it's privately owned, speak to someone on its board of directors. If it's a municipal cemetery, speak to the local Cemetery Commission.
- Cemetery Commissions often lack members. Why not volunteer to serve on yours?
- Similarly, call any funeral home you're considering and ask whether they will assist with a green burial. Cemeteries and funeral directors need to hear that this is something people want.
- Opt for a "greener" burial, even if your cemetery requires a vault: skip the embalming; choose a coffin made of local softwood (pine is good) or another biodegradable container; ask to invert the vault, omitting the lid, so the body and its container rest directly on the earth.
- Host a talk by a Green Burial Massachusetts speaker to increase awareness of and support for this ecologically friendly burial option.
- If you have land that might be suitable for this purpose, consider donating it to GBM. We are now incorporated as a non-profit.
- Join us! GBM is actively working with land trusts to establish one or more conservation cemeteries in Massachusetts. We welcome your energy, talents and skills.

Green Burial Massachusetts is a statewide, all-volunteer 501(c)(3) nonprofit whose mission is twofold: to start the first green cemetery open to all in Massachusetts, and to educate the public about green burial.

[Downloadable FAQ .pdf here.](#)



SUBSCRIBE

GBM is a nonprofit, tax-exempt charitable organization under Section 501(c)(3) of the Internal Revenue Code. Donations to GBM are tax-deductible to the full extent provided by law.

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# Changing Landscapes: Exploring the growth of ethical, compassionate, and environmentally sustainable green funeral practices

Paperback – January 12, 2017

by [Lee Webster](#) (Author)

4.6

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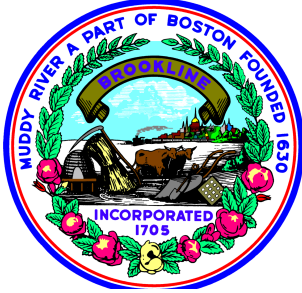
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TOWN OF BROOKLINE  
*Massachusetts*

OFFICE OF TOWN COUNSEL

Joe Callanan, Town Counsel  
Jonathan Simpson, First Assistant Town Counsel  
John J. Buchheit, Associate Town Counsel  
Michael Downey, Associate Town Counsel

TOWN OF BROOKLINE  
OFFICE OF TOWN COUNSEL

MEMORANDUM

TO: Erin Chute,  
Commissioner of Public Works

FROM: Jonathan Simpson, First Assistant Town Counsel

DATE: December 11, 2023

SUBJECT: *Use of Perpetual Care Trust Fund for Salary of Cemetery Business Assistant*

.....

I have been asked to give an opinion on whether money from a perpetual care trust fund may be used to pilot a part-time Cemetery Business Assistant. It is my understanding the Commissioner of Public Works and Director of Parks and Open Space have proposed a new part-time position whose responsibilities would include managing cemetery lot sales, handling customer visits and inquiries, overseeing accounts payable/receivable, liaising with funeral homes, database management, mapping, scanning, and office functions. Their proposal would utilize \$38,000 per year from the perpetual care trust fund identified as TW23, an expandable perpetual care trust fund where the interest from TW24 is deposited. TW24 is a non-expandable fund containing 50% of the proceeds from the sales of cemetery lots.

TW23 is a perpetual trust fund governed by M.G.L. c. 114, s. 15 because it is funded by the proceeds of sales of cemetery lots. Section 15 states, in pertinent part, that proceeds from the sales of cemetery lots "shall be paid into the town treasuries, be kept separate from other funds,

and be appropriated to reimburse the towns for the cost of the land, its care, improvement and embellishment, or the enlargement of the cemetery.”

Whether it is proper to use the funds in TW23 for the business assistant position is, therefore, a question of statutory interpretation, and we are not aware of any legal authority or written guidance that informs how broadly you can interpret the list of legitimate uses for the proceeds of sales of cemetery lots. An argument can certainly be made that “care, improvement, and embellishment” of the cemetery land should be read narrowly to only include work with a direct, physical impact on the land itself, such as lawn care or drainage improvements. Multiple attorneys at the Department of Revenue’s Division of Local Services have recommended such an interpretation verbally. However, as noted above there is no written authority that requires such an interpretation. If you wish to interpret Section 15 as encompassing all tasks that benefit the operations of the Walnut Hills Cemetery and allow it to function more effectively, there is nothing in the caselaw preventing you from doing so.

Please do not hesitate to contact me if you have any additional questions.

|          |                                         |
|----------|-----------------------------------------|
| Current: | Proposed, to be effective July 1, 2024: |
|----------|-----------------------------------------|

|                    |           |         | Set in: | Rate:     | % increase: | New rate: | Rounded:  | Available in<br>Section #: | Scarce? | Notes: |
|--------------------|-----------|---------|---------|-----------|-------------|-----------|-----------|----------------------------|---------|--------|
| <b>BURIAL LOTS</b> |           |         |         |           |             |           |           |                            |         |        |
| Single grave       | Full-body | Upright | 2020    | \$ 2,575  | 15.0%       | \$ 2,961  | \$ 3,000  | 21                         | yes     | 1      |
| Double grave       | Full-body | Upright | 2018    | \$ 5,150  | 20.0%       | \$ 6,180  | \$ 6,200  | 24                         | yes     | 1, 2   |
| Four grave lot     | Full-body | Upright | 2018    | \$ 10,300 | 20.0%       | \$ 12,360 | \$ 12,400 | 24                         | yes     | 1, 2   |
| Single grave       | Full-body | Flat    | 2018    | \$ 1,700  | 10.0%       | \$ 1,870  | \$ 1,900  | 21, 18                     | no      | 3      |
| Single grave       | Cremated  | Flat    | 2008*   | \$ 990    | 2.0%        | \$ 1,010  | \$ 1,000  | 21                         | no      | 4      |
| Single grave       | Full-body | Wall    | 2018    | \$ 3,900  | 15.0%       | \$ 4,485  | \$ 4,500  | 21                         | yes     |        |
| Single grave       | Cremated  | Wall    | 2015    | \$ 2,550  | 10.0%       | \$ 2,805  | \$ 2,800  | 21                         | no      | 4      |

**GRAVE OPENING**

|                                             |             |  |      |          |       |          |          |
|---------------------------------------------|-------------|--|------|----------|-------|----------|----------|
| M-F 7:30 - 3:30                             | Full-body   |  | 2018 | \$ 1,250 | 20.0% | \$ 1,500 | \$ 1,500 |
| M-F after 3:30                              | Full-body   |  | 2018 | \$ 2,000 | 20.0% | \$ 2,400 | \$ 2,400 |
| Sat & Holidays                              | Full-body   |  | 2018 | \$ 2,000 | 20.0% | \$ 2,400 | \$ 2,400 |
| Sunday                                      | Full-body   |  | 2018 | \$ 2,300 | 20.0% | \$ 2,760 | \$ 2,760 |
| M-F 7:30 - 3:30                             | Urn         |  | 2018 | \$ 620   | 20.0% | \$ 744   | \$ 740   |
| M-F after 3:30                              | Urn         |  | 2018 | \$ 930   | 20.0% | \$ 1,116 | \$ 1,120 |
| Sat, Sun, Hol's                             | Urn         |  | 2018 | \$ 930   | 20.0% | \$ 1,116 | \$ 1,120 |
| Disinterment                                | [full-body] |  | 2018 | \$ 2,300 | 20.0% | \$ 2,760 | \$ 2,760 |
| Foundation setting for headstones, per s.f. |             |  | 2018 | \$ 160   | 20.0% | \$ 192   | \$ 190   |
| Flat marker setting, per s.f.               |             |  | 2018 | \$ 160   | 20.0% | \$ 192   | \$ 190   |

**NOTES:**

- Implementation of October 2023 expansions will increase supply. What the Trustees voted in October:  
Add 136 new full-body upright marker lots to Section 21.  
Add 56 new full-body upright marker lots, laid out as "doubles", to Section 24. See also note 2.
- Chair has proposed a higher draft value for percentage increase for "doubles" and "quads" because these are laid out, in Section 24, with extra "aisle" space of three feet between the actual lot boundaries.
- Possibly even more will be available in future if Sections 17 and 22 are used for this lot type.
- Halvorson study of Section 21 included proposed changes, not acted on by the trustees in October 2023, that would have reduced cremation lots and increased full-body lots, both for flat markers.

***FY14 FINANCIAL PLAN -  
CHARGE-OFFS and OVERHEAD CHARGES***

|              | FY18      | FY19      | FY20      | FY21      | FY22*     | FY23      | FY24 |
|--------------|-----------|-----------|-----------|-----------|-----------|-----------|------|
| Total Budget | \$285,228 | \$279,519 | \$288,188 | \$260,372 | \$231,597 | \$254,857 |      |
| Personnel    | \$186,410 | \$194,987 | \$207,812 | \$215,238 | \$196,373 | \$197,253 |      |
|              | 65.40%    | 69.80%    | 72.10%    | 82.70%    | 84.80%    | 77.40%    |      |

|                                         |                          |
|-----------------------------------------|--------------------------|
| FY18-24 COLAs per the AFSCME agreements |                          |
| FY18                                    | 3.0%.5% effective 3/1/18 |
| FY19                                    | 2.0%                     |
| FY20                                    | 2.0%                     |
| FY21                                    | 2.5%.5% effective 9/1/20 |
| FY22                                    | 1.0%                     |
| FY23                                    | 3.0%                     |
| FY24                                    | 3.0%                     |



# TOWN of BROOKLINE

Massachusetts

## Walnut Hills Cemetery Old Burying Ground

### Trustees

Abbe Cohen, Chairman  
Dorothy Baldini  
Katharine Begien

### Trustees

Mary J. Harris  
Donalda Hingston  
Joslin Ham Murphy

### CEMETERY RATES EFFECTIVE AUGUST 12, 2000

### W/5% INCREASE

|                                                                                    |                   |                                |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------|--------------------------------|
| Single Grave                                                                       | \$1000.00         | \$1050.00                      |
| Double Grave                                                                       | \$2,000.00        | \$2100.00                      |
| Four Grave Lot                                                                     | \$4,000.00        | \$4200.00                      |
| Grave Opening                                                                      |                   |                                |
| Monday – Friday 7:30 AM to 3:30 PM                                                 | \$600.00          | \$630.00                       |
| Monday – Friday after 3:30 PM                                                      | \$900.00          | \$945.00                       |
| Saturday                                                                           | \$900.00          | \$945.00                       |
| Urn Grave Opening                                                                  |                   |                                |
| Monday – Friday 7:30 AM to 3:30 PM                                                 | \$350.00          | \$367.50                       |
| Monday – Friday after 3:30 PM                                                      | \$525.00          | \$551.25                       |
| Saturday                                                                           | \$525.00          | \$551.25                       |
| Disinterment                                                                       | \$750.00          | \$787.50                       |
| Foundation Setting for Headstones                                                  | \$75.00 per sq ft | W/\$100 per sq. ft<br>\$100.00 |
| Two grave lot (3 ft x 1 ft) would be \$225.00. No more than 1 stone permitted      |                   | \$300.00                       |
| Four grave lot (4 ft x 1 ft) would be \$300.00. No more than 2 stones permitted.   |                   | \$400.00                       |
| One-piece tablet (monolith) \$125.00 minimum                                       |                   | \$100/sq ft                    |
| Flat Marker Setting                                                                |                   |                                |
| Single grave (2 ft x 1 ft plus 4 in. deep) would be \$200.00 at \$100.00 per sq ft |                   | \$200.00                       |
| Double grave (3 ft x 1 ft plus 4 in. deep) would be \$255.00 at \$85.00 per sq ft  |                   | \$300.00                       |
| Oversize grave based on actual size at \$75.00 per sq ft                           |                   | \$100/sq ft                    |



**TOWN of BROOKLINE**  
*Massachusetts*  
**Walnut Hills Cemetery**  
**Old Burying Ground**

**Trustees**

*Abbe Cohen, Chairman*  
*Dorothy Baldini*  
*Katharine Begien*

**Trustees**

*Mary J. Harris*  
*Donalda Hingston*  
*Joslin Ham Murphy*

**CEMETERY RATES EFFECTIVE NOVEMBER 1, 2003**

|                |           |
|----------------|-----------|
| Single Grave   | \$1050.00 |
| Double Grave   | \$2100.00 |
| Four Grave Lot | \$4200.00 |

|                                    |          |
|------------------------------------|----------|
| Grave Opening                      |          |
| Monday – Friday 7:30 AM to 3:30 PM | \$630.00 |
| Monday – Friday after 3:30 PM      | \$945.00 |
| Saturday                           | \$945.00 |

|                                    |          |
|------------------------------------|----------|
| Urn Grave Opening                  |          |
| Monday – Friday 7:30 AM to 3:30 PM | \$368.00 |
| Monday – Friday after 3:30 PM      | \$552.00 |
| Saturday                           | \$552.00 |

|              |          |
|--------------|----------|
| Disinterment | \$788.00 |
|--------------|----------|

|                                                                                  |                    |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------|
| Foundation Setting for Headstones                                                | \$100.00 per sq ft |
| Two grave lot (3 ft x 1 ft) would be \$300.00. No more than 1 stone permitted    |                    |
| Four grave lot (4 ft x 1 ft) would be \$400.00. No more than 2 stones permitted. |                    |
| One-piece tablet (monolith) \$125.00 minimum \$100/sq ft                         |                    |

|                                                                                    |  |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--|
| Flat Marker Setting                                                                |  |
| Single grave (2 ft x 1 ft plus 4 in. deep) would be \$200.00 at \$100.00 per sq ft |  |
| Double grave (3 ft x 1 ft plus 4 in. deep) would be \$300.00 at \$100.00 per sq ft |  |
| Oversize grave based on actual size at \$100.00 per sq ft                          |  |



# TOWN of BROOKLINE

Massachusetts

## Walnut Hills Cemetery Old Burying Ground

### Trustees

Abbe Cohen, Chairman  
Dorothy Baldini  
Katharine Begien

### Trustees

Mary J. Harris  
Donalda Hingston  
Joslin Ham Murphy

### CEMETERY RATES EFFECTIVE

JULY 1, 2004 *Increase*

|                |           |
|----------------|-----------|
| Single Grave   | \$1100.00 |
| Double Grave   | \$2200.00 |
| Four Grave Lot | \$4400.00 |

|                                    |          |
|------------------------------------|----------|
| Grave Opening                      |          |
| Monday – Friday 7:30 AM to 3:30 PM | \$660.00 |
| Monday – Friday after 3:30 PM      | \$990.00 |
| Saturday                           | \$990.00 |

|                                    |          |
|------------------------------------|----------|
| Urn Grave Opening                  |          |
| Monday – Friday 7:30 AM to 3:30 PM | \$386.00 |
| Monday – Friday after 3:30 PM      | \$580.00 |
| Saturday                           | \$580.00 |

|              |          |
|--------------|----------|
| Disinterment | \$826.00 |
|--------------|----------|

|                                                                                  |                    |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------|
| Foundation Setting for Headstones                                                | \$105.00 per sq ft |
| Two grave lot (3 ft x 1 ft) would be \$315.00. No more than 1 stone permitted    |                    |
| Four grave lot (4 ft x 1 ft) would be \$420.00. No more than 2 stones permitted. |                    |
| One-piece tablet (monolith) \$130.00 minimum \$105.00/sq ft                      |                    |

|                                                                                    |  |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--|
| Flat Marker Setting                                                                |  |
| Single grave (2 ft x 1 ft plus 4 in. deep) would be \$210.00 at \$105.00 per sq ft |  |
| Double grave (3 ft x 1 ft plus 4 in. deep) would be \$315.00 at \$105.00 per sq ft |  |
| Oversize grave based on actual size at \$105.00 per sq ft                          |  |



**TOWN of BROOKLINE**  
*Massachusetts*  
**Walnut Hills Cemetery**  
**Old Burying Ground**

**Trustees**

*Abbe Cohen, Chairman*  
*Dorothy Baldini*  
*Katharine Begien*

**Trustees**

*Mary J. Harris*  
*Donalda Hingston*  
*Joslin Ham Murphy*

**CEMETERY RATES EFFECTIVE**

**JULY 1, 2006** *Increase*

|                |           |
|----------------|-----------|
| Single Grave   | \$1220.00 |
| Double Grave   | \$2440.00 |
| Four Grave Lot | \$4880.00 |

|                                    |           |
|------------------------------------|-----------|
| Grave Opening                      |           |
| Monday – Friday 7:30 AM to 3:30 PM | \$ 740.00 |
| Monday – Friday after 3:30 PM      | \$1110.00 |
| Saturday                           | \$1110.00 |

|                                    |           |
|------------------------------------|-----------|
| Urn Grave Opening                  |           |
| Monday – Friday 7:30 AM to 3:30 PM | \$ 430.00 |
| Monday – Friday after 3:30 PM      | \$ 650.00 |
| Saturday                           | \$ 650.00 |

|              |           |
|--------------|-----------|
| Disinterment | \$ 920.00 |
|--------------|-----------|

|                                                                                  |                    |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------|
| Foundation Setting for Headstones                                                | \$115.00 per sq ft |
| Two grave lot (3 ft x 1 ft) would be \$345.00. No more than 1 stone permitted    |                    |
| Four grave lot (4 ft x 1 ft) would be \$460.00. No more than 2 stones permitted. |                    |
| One-piece tablet (monolith) \$235.00 minimum \$115.00/sq ft                      |                    |

|                                                                                    |  |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--|
| Flat Marker Setting                                                                |  |
| Single grave (2 ft x 1 ft plus 4 in. deep) would be \$235.00 at \$115.00 per sq ft |  |
| Double grave (3 ft x 1 ft plus 4 in. deep) would be \$345.00 at \$115.00 per sq ft |  |
| Oversize grave based on actual size at \$115.00 per sq ft                          |  |



# TOWN of BROOKLINE

Massachusetts

## Walnut Hills Cemetery Old Burying Ground

### Trustees

Abbe Cohen, Chairman  
Dorothy Baldini  
Katharine Begien

### Trustees

Mary J. Harris  
Donalda Hingston  
Joslin Ham Murphy

### CEMETERY RATES EFFECTIVE

JULY 1, 2007      *increase*

|                |           |
|----------------|-----------|
| Single Grave   | \$1280.00 |
| Double Grave   | \$2560.00 |
| Four Grave Lot | \$5120.00 |

|                                    |           |
|------------------------------------|-----------|
| Grave Opening                      |           |
| Monday – Friday 7:30 AM to 3:30 PM | \$800.00  |
| Monday – Friday after 3:30 PM      | \$1180.00 |
| Saturday                           | \$1180.00 |

|                                    |          |
|------------------------------------|----------|
| Urn Grave Opening                  |          |
| Monday – Friday 7:30 AM to 3:30 PM | \$455.00 |
| Monday – Friday after 3:30 PM      | \$685.00 |
| Saturday                           | \$685.00 |

|              |           |
|--------------|-----------|
| Disinterment | \$1000.00 |
|--------------|-----------|

|                                                                                  |                 |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|
| Foundation Setting for Headstones                                                | \$120 per sq ft |
| Two grave lot (3 ft x 1 ft) would be \$240.00. No more than 1 stone permitted    |                 |
| Four grave lot (4 ft x 1 ft) would be \$480.00. No more than 2 stones permitted. |                 |
| One-piece tablet (monolith) \$240.00 minimum    \$120.00/sq ft                   |                 |

|                                                                                    |  |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--|
| Flat Marker Setting                                                                |  |
| Single grave (2 ft x 1 ft plus 4 in. deep) would be \$240.00 at \$120.00 per sq ft |  |
| Double grave (3 ft x 1 ft plus 4 in. deep) would be \$360.00 at \$120.00 per sq ft |  |
| Oversize grave based on actual size at \$120.00 per sq ft                          |  |



**TOWN of BROOKLINE**  
*Massachusetts*  
**Walnut Hills Cemetery**  
**Old Burying Ground**

**Trustees**

Abbe Cohen, Chairman  
Dorothy Baldini  
Katharine Begien

**Trustees**

Mary J. Harris  
Donalda Hingston  
Joslin Ham Murphy

**CEMETERY RATES EFFECTIVE**

**JULY 1, 2008** *increased*

|                |           |
|----------------|-----------|
| Single Grave   | \$1350.00 |
| Double Grave   | \$2700.00 |
| Four Grave Lot | \$5400.00 |
| Cremation Lot  | \$1000.00 |

|                                    |           |
|------------------------------------|-----------|
| Grave Opening                      |           |
| Monday – Friday 7:30 AM to 3:30 PM | \$900.00  |
| Monday – Friday after 3:30 PM      | \$1500.00 |
| Saturday                           | \$1500.00 |

|                                    |          |
|------------------------------------|----------|
| Urn Grave Opening                  |          |
| Monday – Friday 7:30 AM to 3:30 PM | \$500.00 |
| Monday – Friday after 3:30 PM      | \$800.00 |
| Saturday                           | \$800.00 |

|              |           |
|--------------|-----------|
| Disinterment | \$1000.00 |
|--------------|-----------|

|                                   |                 |
|-----------------------------------|-----------------|
| Foundation Setting for Headstones | \$130 per sq ft |
|-----------------------------------|-----------------|

Two grave lot (3ft x 1 ft) would be \$260.00. No more than 1 stone permitted  
Four grave lot (4 ft x 1 ft) would be \$520.00. No more than 2 stones permitted.  
One-piece tablet (monolith) \$260.00 minimum \$130.00/sq ft

**Flat Marker Setting**

Single grave (2 ft x 1 ft plus 4 in. deep) would be \$260.00 at \$130.00 per sq ft  
Double grave (3 ft x 1 ft plus 4 in. deep) would be \$390.00 at \$130.00 per sq ft  
Oversize grave based on actual size at \$130.00 per sq ft



# TOWN of BROOKLINE

Massachusetts

## Walnut Hills Cemetery Old Burying Ground

### Trustees

Abbe Cohen, Chairman  
Dorothy Baldini  
Katharine Begien

### Trustees

Mary J. Harris  
Donalda Hingston  
Joslin Ham Murphy

### CEMETERY RATES EFFECTIVE

JULY 1, 2009 *INCREASE*

|                |           |
|----------------|-----------|
| Single Grave   | \$1500.00 |
| Double Grave   | \$3000.00 |
| Four Grave Lot | \$6000.00 |
| Cremation Lot  | \$990.00  |

### Grave Opening

|                                    |           |
|------------------------------------|-----------|
| Monday – Friday 7:30 AM to 3:30 PM | \$950.00  |
| Monday – Friday after 3:30 PM      | \$1600.00 |
| Saturday                           | \$1600.00 |

### Urn Grave Opening

|                                    |          |
|------------------------------------|----------|
| Monday – Friday 7:30 AM to 3:30 PM | \$550.00 |
| Monday – Friday after 3:30 PM      | \$840.00 |
| Saturday                           | \$840.00 |

### Disinterment

\$1050.00

### Foundation Setting for Headstones

\$135 per sq ft

Two grave lot (3ft x 1 ft) would be \$405.00. No more than 1 stone permitted  
Four grave lot (4 ft x 1 ft) would be \$540.00. No more than 2 stones permitted  
One-piece tablet (monolith) \$270.00 minimum at \$135.00/sq ft

### Flat Marker Setting

Single grave (2 ft x 1 ft plus 4 in. deep) would be \$270.00 at \$135.00 per sq ft  
Double grave (3 ft x 1 ft plus 4 in. deep) would be \$405.00 at \$135.00 per sq ft  
Oversize grave based on actual size at \$135.00 per sq ft



# **TOWN of BROOKLINE**

*Massachusetts*

**Walnut Hills Cemetery**

**Old Burying Ground**

## **Trustees**

*Abbe Cohen, Chairman*

*Dorothy Baldini*

*Katharine Begien*

## **Trustees**

*Mary J. Harris*

*Donalda Hingston*

*Joslin Ham Murphy*

## **CEMETERY RATES EFFECTIVE**

**JULY 15, 2010**

|                                                                                    |                 |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|
| Double Grave – Full Body Upright Marker                                            | \$5000          |
| Four Grave Lot – Full Body Upright Marker                                          | \$10,000        |
| Single Grave – Full Body Flat Marker                                               | \$1500          |
| Single Grave - Cremated Remains Flat Marker                                        | \$990           |
| Single Grave – Full Body Stone Wall Memorialization                                | \$3600          |
| Single Grave – Cremated Remains Stone Wall Memorialization                         | \$2400          |
| * 6 Grave Lot – 12 Cremated Remains with Flat Markers                              | \$6000          |
| Grave Opening                                                                      |                 |
| Monday – Friday 7:30 AM to 3:30 PM                                                 | \$1050          |
| Monday – Friday after 3:30 PM                                                      | \$1700          |
| Saturday/Sunday                                                                    | \$1700          |
| Urn Grave Opening                                                                  |                 |
| Monday – Friday 7:30 AM to 3:30 PM                                                 | \$550           |
| Monday – Friday after 3:30 PM                                                      | \$840           |
| Saturday/Sunday                                                                    | \$840           |
| Disinterment                                                                       | \$2000          |
| Foundation Setting for Headstones                                                  | \$140 per sq ft |
| Two grave lot (3ft x 1 ft) would be \$420.00. No more than 1 stone permitted       |                 |
| Four grave lot (4 ft x 1 ft) would be \$560.00. No more than 2 stones permitted    |                 |
| One-piece tablet (monolith) \$280.00 minimum at \$140.00/sq ft                     |                 |
| Flat Marker Setting                                                                | \$140 per sq ft |
| Single grave (2 ft x 1 ft plus 4 in. deep) would be \$280.00 at \$140.00 per sq ft |                 |
| Double grave (3 ft x 1 ft plus 4 in. deep) would be \$420.00 at \$140.00 per sq ft |                 |
| Oversize grave based on actual size at \$140.00 per sq ft                          |                 |



# TOWN of BROOKLINE

Massachusetts

## Walnut Hills Cemetery Old Burying Ground

### Trustees

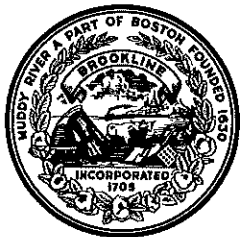
Abbe Cohen, Chairman  
Robert Cook  
Gerard Hayes  
Donalda Hingston  
Richard Leary  
Joslin Ham Murphy

Director of Parks and Open Space  
Erin Chute Gallentine

### CEMETERY RATES EFFECTIVE

JULY 1, 2013

|                                                                                    |                 |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|
| Double Grave – Full Body Upright Marker                                            | \$5000          |
| Four Grave Lot – Full Body Upright Marker                                          | \$10,000        |
| Single Grave – Full Body Flat Marker                                               | \$1500          |
| Single Grave - Cremated Remains Flat Marker                                        | \$990           |
| Single Grave – Full Body Stone Wall Memorialization                                | \$3600          |
| Single Grave – Cremated Remains Stone Wall Memorialization                         | \$2400          |
| Grave Opening                                                                      |                 |
| Monday – Friday 7:30 AM to 3:30 PM                                                 | \$1050          |
| Monday – Friday after 3:30 PM                                                      | \$1700          |
| Saturday                                                                           | \$1700          |
| Sunday                                                                             | \$2000          |
| Urn Grave Opening                                                                  |                 |
| Monday – Friday 7:30 AM to 3:30 PM                                                 | \$550           |
| Monday – Friday after 3:30 PM                                                      | \$840           |
| Saturday                                                                           | \$840           |
| Disinterment                                                                       | \$2000          |
| Foundation Setting for Headstones                                                  | \$140 per sq ft |
| Two grave lot (3ft x 1 ft) would be \$420.00. No more than 1 stone permitted       |                 |
| Four grave lot (4 ft x 1 ft) would be \$560.00. No more than 2 stones permitted    |                 |
| One-piece tablet (monolith) \$280.00 minimum at \$140.00/sq ft                     |                 |
| Flat Marker Setting                                                                | \$140 per sq ft |
| Single grave (2 ft x 1 ft plus 4 in. deep) would be \$280.00 at \$140.00 per sq ft |                 |
| Double grave (3 ft x 1 ft plus 4 in. deep) would be \$420.00 at \$140.00 per sq ft |                 |
| Oversize grave based on actual size at \$140.00 per sq ft                          |                 |



# TOWN of BROOKLINE

Massachusetts

## Walnut Hills Cemetery Old Burying Ground

### Trustees

Robert Cook, Chairman  
Nina Brown  
Gerard Hayes  
Richard Leary  
Peggy Maguire  
Joslin Ham Murphy

Director of Parks and Open Space  
Erin Chute Gallentine

### CEMETERY RATES EFFECTIVE

JAN 1, 2015

|                                                            |          |
|------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| Double Grave – Full Body Upright Marker                    | \$5000   |
| Four Grave Lot – Full Body Upright Marker                  | \$10,000 |
| Single Grave – Full Body Flat Marker                       | \$1650   |
| Single Grave - Cremated Remains Flat Marker                | \$990    |
| Single Grave – Full Body Stone Wall Memorialization        | \$3800   |
| Single Grave – Cremated Remains Stone Wall Memorialization | \$2550   |

### Grave Opening

|                                    |        |
|------------------------------------|--------|
| Monday – Friday 7:30 AM to 3:30 PM | \$1200 |
| Monday – Friday after 3:30 PM      | \$1900 |
| Saturday & Holidays*               | \$1900 |
| Sunday                             | \$2200 |

### Urn Grave Opening

|                                    |       |
|------------------------------------|-------|
| Monday – Friday 7:30 AM to 3:30 PM | \$600 |
| Monday – Friday after 3:30 PM      | \$900 |
| Saturday, Sunday & Holidays*       | \$900 |

### Disinterment

\$2200

### Foundation Setting for Headstones

\$155 per sq ft

Two grave lot (3ft x 1 ft) would be \$465. No more than 1 stone permitted  
Four grave lot (4 ft x 1 ft) would be \$620. No more than 2 stones permitted  
One-piece tablet (monolith) \$310 minimum at \$155/sq ft

### Flat Marker Setting

Single grave (2 ft x 1 ft plus 4 in. deep) would be \$310 at \$155/ sq ft  
Double grave (3 ft x 1 ft plus 4 in. deep) would be \$465 at \$155/ sq ft  
Oversize grave based on actual size at \$155/ sq ft

\*Town Recognized Holidays: New Year's Day, Martin Luther's King Day, Washington's Birthday, Patriots' Day, Memorial Day, Bunker Hill Day, Independence Day, Labor Day, Columbus Day, Veteran's Day, Thanksgiving Day and Christmas Day

96 Grove Street Brookline, Massachusetts 02445-6863  
Telephone: (617) 730-2179 Facsimile: (617) 739-7580



# **TOWN of BROOKLINE**

*Massachusetts*

## **Walnut Hills Cemetery Old Burying Ground**

### **VETERANS LOT ELIGIBILITY, RATES & SERVICES**

The Town of Brookline will provide veterans with a lot in the Veteran's section of the Walnut Hills Cemetery without cost. However all other burial fees must be paid by the veteran or veteran's family as discussed below. Eligible Veterans are defined by Massachusetts state law (MGL CH 4, S7, CI 43.) He or she must have been a resident in Brookline for at least 5 years at the time of death or have entered military service from the Town of Brookline as confirmed by a military Report of Transfer or Discharge (DD Form 214) regardless of current residency. There will be no charge for the lot, but all other costs such as liners, grave openings, and marker foundations will be charged. The spouse of an eligible veteran may also be buried in the same lot. A veteran's lot provides for the interment of one full body remains and one cremated remains. With this form, these restrictions on the burial of a veteran and his or her spouse (or family member) in the Veteran's Lot section of the Cemetery must be agreed to in writing before the first burial. Below are the current charges for burial services in the Veteran's Lot.

#### **CEMETERY RATES EFFECTIVE**

**JULY 1, 2016**

Veterans Lot Single Grave – Full Body with Flat Marker  
Single Cremated Remains

No Charge  
No Charge

#### **Grave Opening**

Monday – Friday 7:30 AM to 3:30 PM

\$1200

Monday – Friday after 3:30 PM

\$1900

Saturday & Holidays\*

\$1900

Sunday

\$2200

*Interment liners are paid for by the family and installed by a 3<sup>rd</sup> party*

#### **Urn Grave Opening**

Monday – Friday 7:30 AM to 3:30 PM

\$600

Monday – Friday after 3:30 PM

\$900

Saturday, Sunday & Holidays\*

\$900

#### **Disinterment**

\$2200

#### **Flat Marker Setting**

\$310

Single grave (2 ft x 1 ft plus 4 in. deep) would be \$310 at \$155/ sq ft

#### **Veterans Marker**

A flat marker is secured through the U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs Office. The VA Form 40-1330, Claim for Standard Government Marker can be downloaded from their website. The Cemetery Supervisor will review and sign the completed form, return it to the VA and, when shipped, accept delivery and install the marker.

\*Town Recognized Holidays: New Year's Day, Martin Luther's King Day, Washington's Birthday, Patriots' Day, Memorial Day, Bunker Hill Day, Independence Day, Labor Day, Columbus Day, Veteran's Day, Thanksgiving Day and Christmas Day

Veterans Name: \_\_\_\_\_

Street Address: \_\_\_\_\_

City/Town: \_\_\_\_\_ State: \_\_\_\_\_ Zip: \_\_\_\_\_

Telephone: \_\_\_\_\_

The above individual is:

- ☐ A Veteran, as defined in MGL CH 4, S 7, C 43
- ☐ A current Brookline resident and resident for 5 consecutive years
- ☐ Entered military service from the Town of Brookline as confirmed by a military Report of Transfer or Discharge (DD Form 214)
- ☐ A Town employee for 20 years (as verified by the Human Resources Department)

*The Veterans Eligibility Requirements for the Walnut Hills Cemetery, as determined by the Walnut Hills Cemetery Trustees and defined above, are hereby verified and approved by the Town of Brookline Director of Veterans Affairs:*

\_\_\_\_\_  
Print Name Signature Date

**To be signed by the eligible Veteran and/or spouse:**

*The below certifies under the pains and penalties of perjury that he/she complies with the Walnut Hills Cemetery Veterans Lot eligibility requirements, services, fees and interment provisions, he/she has read and understands the Cemetery Rules and Regulations, Walnut Hills Inscription Guidelines and the Monument Design Standards of the Walnut Hills Cemetery:*

\_\_\_\_\_  
Veteran Signature Date

\_\_\_\_\_  
Spouse/Family Member Signature Date

**To be signed by the Cemetery Supervisor:**

*The Veterans Eligibility Requirements for the Walnut Hills Cemetery, as determined by the Walnut Hills Cemetery Trustees and defined above, are hereby verified and approved by the Walnut Hills Cemetery Supervisor:*

\_\_\_\_\_  
Print Name Signature Date

96 Grove Street Brookline, Massachusetts 02445-6863  
Telephone: (617) 730-2179 Facsimile: (617) 739-7580

- *Under Massachusetts State Law, holidays that fall on a Sunday are observed on a Monday.*



# TOWN of BROOKLINE

Massachusetts

## Walnut Hills Cemetery Old Burying Ground

### Trustees

Robert Cook, Chairman  
Nina Brown  
Gerard Hayes  
Richard Leary  
Peggy Maguire  
Joslin Ham Murphy

Director of Parks and Open Space  
Erin Chute Gallentine

### CEMETERY RATES EFFECTIVE

JAN 1, 2017

|                                                            |          |
|------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| Double Grave – Full Body Upright Marker                    | \$5000   |
| Four Grave Lot – Full Body Upright Marker                  | \$10,000 |
| Single Grave – Full Body Flat Marker                       | \$1650   |
| Single Grave - Cremated Remains Flat Marker                | \$990    |
| Single Grave – Full Body Stone Wall Memorialization        | \$3800   |
| Single Grave – Cremated Remains Stone Wall Memorialization | \$2550   |

### Grave Opening

|                                    |        |
|------------------------------------|--------|
| Monday – Friday 7:30 AM to 3:30 PM | \$1200 |
| Monday – Friday after 3:30 PM      | \$1900 |
| Saturday & Holidays*               | \$1900 |
| Sunday                             | \$2200 |

### Urn Grave Opening

|                                    |       |
|------------------------------------|-------|
| Monday – Friday 7:30 AM to 3:30 PM | \$600 |
| Monday – Friday after 3:30 PM      | \$900 |
| Saturday, Sunday & Holidays*       | \$900 |

|              |        |
|--------------|--------|
| Disinterment | \$2200 |
|--------------|--------|

### Foundation Setting for Headstones

\$155 per sq ft

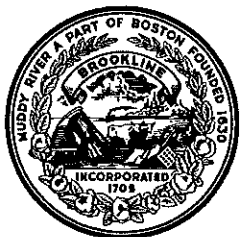
Two grave lot (3 ft x 1 ft) would be \$465. No more than 1 stone permitted  
Four grave lot (4 ft x 1 ft) would be \$620. No more than 2 stones permitted  
One-piece tablet (monolith) \$310 minimum at \$155/sq ft

### Flat Marker Setting

Single grave (2 ft x 1 ft plus 4 in. deep) would be \$310 at \$155/ sq ft  
Double grave (3 ft x 1 ft plus 4 in. deep) would be \$465 at \$155/ sq ft  
Oversize grave based on actual size at \$155/ sq ft

\*Town Recognized Holidays: New Year's Day, Martin Luther's King Day, Washington's Birthday, Patriots' Day, Memorial Day, Bunker Hill Day, Independence Day, Labor Day, Columbus Day, Veteran's Day, Thanksgiving Day and Christmas Day

96 Grove Street Brookline, Massachusetts 02445-6863  
Telephone: (617) 730-2179 Facsimile: (617) 739-7580



# TOWN of BROOKLINE

Massachusetts

## Walnut Hills Cemetery Old Burying Ground

### Trustees

Robert Cook, Chairman  
Nina Brown  
Gerard Hayes  
Peggy Maguire  
Joslin Ham Murphy

Director of Parks and Open Space  
Erin Chute Gallentine

### CEMETERY RATES EFFECTIVE

JULY 1, 2018

|                                                            |          |
|------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| Double Grave – Full Body Upright Marker                    | \$5,150  |
| Four Grave Lot – Full Body Upright Marker                  | \$10,300 |
| Single Grave – Full Body Flat Marker                       | \$1,700  |
| Single Grave - Cremated Remains Flat Marker                | \$990    |
| Single Grave – Full Body Stone Wall Memorialization        | \$3,900  |
| Single Grave – Cremated Remains Stone Wall Memorialization | \$2,550  |

### Grave Opening

|                                    |         |
|------------------------------------|---------|
| Monday – Friday 7:30 AM to 3:30 PM | \$1,250 |
| Monday – Friday after 3:30 PM      | \$2,000 |
| Saturday & Holidays*               | \$2,000 |
| Sunday                             | \$2,300 |

### Urn Grave Opening

|                                    |       |
|------------------------------------|-------|
| Monday – Friday 7:30 AM to 3:30 PM | \$620 |
| Monday – Friday after 3:30 PM      | \$930 |
| Saturday, Sunday & Holidays*       | \$930 |

|              |         |
|--------------|---------|
| Disinterment | \$2,300 |
|--------------|---------|

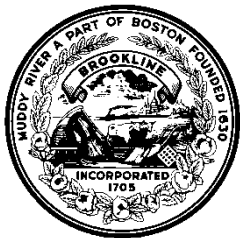
|                                   |                 |
|-----------------------------------|-----------------|
| Foundation Setting for Headstones | \$160 per sq ft |
|-----------------------------------|-----------------|

Two grave lot (3ft x 1 ft) would be \$480. No more than 1 stone permitted  
Four grave lot (4 ft x 1 ft) would be \$640. No more than 2 stones permitted  
One-piece tablet (monolith) \$320 minimum at \$160sq ft

### Flat Marker Setting

Single grave (2 ft x 1 ft plus 4 in. deep) would be \$320 at \$160sq ft  
Double grave (3 ft x 1 ft plus 4 in. deep) would be \$480 at \$160 sq ft  
Oversize grave based on actual size at \$160 sq ft

\*Town Recognized Holidays: New Year's Day, Martin Luther's King Day, Washington's Birthday, Patriots' Day, Memorial Day, Bunker Hill Day, Independence Day, Labor Day, Columbus Day, Veteran's Day, Thanksgiving Day and Christmas Day



**TOWN of BROOKLINE**  
Massachusetts  
**Walnut Hills Cemetery**

**Trustees**

Randolph Meiklejohn, Chair  
Lisa Farber  
Gerry Hayes  
Peggy Maguire  
Joslin Ham Murphy

**Parks and Open Space Division**

Alexandra Vecchio, Director

Meeting of the Walnut Hills Cemetery Trustees  
Wednesday, March 20, 2024  
9:30 AM- 10:30 AM  
Hybrid Meeting

**TO ATTEND IN PERSON, PLEASE GO TO THE FOLLOWING LOCATION:**  
Brookline Town Hall, 333 Washington Street, Brookline, MA 02445, Room 111

**TO ATTEND VIRTUALLY, REGISTER IN ADVANCE FOR THIS WEBINAR:**  
[https://brooklinema.zoomgov.com/webinar/register/WN\\_KVjmOF09QFSaRNzAZ\\_D5dQ](https://brooklinema.zoomgov.com/webinar/register/WN_KVjmOF09QFSaRNzAZ_D5dQ)

**TO ACCESS THE MEETING BY PHONE, DIAL:** US: +1 669 254 5252 or +1 646 828 7666  
**Webinar ID:** 160 501 1693    **Password:** 86579452  
International numbers available: <https://brooklinema.zoomgov.com/j/ucErySF4gM>

**Meeting Files Link**  
<https://www.brooklinema.gov/DocumentCenter/Index/5197>

**AGENDA**

- 9:30 AM Welcome, Approval of the October 16, 2023 Meeting Minutes and the December 6, 2023 Meeting Minutes, and Signing of Deeds
- 9:35 AM Review, Discussion, and Possible Votes on the Fiscal Year 2025 Cemetery Rates
- 10:00 AM Discussion of Green Burials
- 10:10 AM Staff Update
- 10:30 AM Adjourn



# TOWN of BROOKLINE

Massachusetts

## Walnut Hills Cemetery Old Burying Ground

### **Trustees**

Lisa Farber  
Gerard Hayes  
Peggy Maguire  
Randolph Meiklejohn, Chair  
Joslin Ham Murphy

**Director of Parks and Open Space**  
Alexandra Vecchio

### Walnut Hills Cemetery Trustees Meeting

Tuesday, October 16, 2023

9:30 am -10:15 am

Room 111, Brookline Town Hall / Hybrid Webinar

**Trustees Present:** Gerard Hayes, Lisa Farber, Randolph Meiklejohn, Peggy Maguire, and Joslin Ham Murphy

**Trustees Absent:** n/a

**Staff Present:** Alexandra Vecchio, Director of Parks and Open Space; Jessica Smith, Conservation Assistant

### Meeting documents:

[Jessica ZW can we put Document Center link here, as done in 09/20/23 minutes?]

1. Walnut Hills Cemetery Sections 21 and 22 Study, Halvorson
2. Walnut Hills Cemetery Schematic Design Options for Upright Markers, 01/24/23, Halvorson

### Welcome

Randolph Meiklejohn opened the meeting. Randolph Meiklejohn discussed the process of circulating the minutes to the trustees, he introduced the materials on the wall (which can be found here: <https://www.brooklinema.gov/DocumentCenter/Index/4701>), and site visit to the Library Edge and Allandale Edge sites in the cemetery.

### Discussion and Vote on Proposed Layout Revision in Section 21

Randolph Meiklejohn introduced the agenda item. Randolph Meiklejohn discussed how the agenda item had come from the iterative review of the build-out options in the form of questioning if there was not any other space within the cemetery. He discussed the drawings from the packet and the expansion areas that had been looked at by the trustees. He discussed the added plots that the Landscape Architect found to increase the number of upright marker full burial lots in Section 21, in the red outline on the site map. He discussed the areas designated as flush marker burial plots, many of which have not been sold, which some of those are along the memorial wall. He discussed that most of the upright marker burial lots have been sold. He stated that the trustees had not discussed the area having a mix of lots and the June 21st design showing the curving rows of full burial upright marker lots. He stated that the new design, on page 5 of the Section 21 study, continues and has more

curving rows closer to the road and discussed the layout further. He asked A. Vecchio about the scattering sites and discussed how they were unsold. He added that this would add 136 new full burial plots and is what the drawing represents. Joslin Murphy asked that with the new modification to the layout it would provide 136 new full burial lots that permit upright headstones. Randolph Meiklejohn confirmed it did and achieved that by using open space, overwriting scattering lots, and overwriting cremation lots. Joslin Murphy stated that in the original design the corner of Section 21 was intended for both flush markers and cremation but somehow upright markers were sold and permitted. She added that she thinks it is a great use of that area but raises the question of care for what is sold where and she is in favor. Randolph Meiklejohn asked if there was a policy that when that dictate what type of marker is allowed in a certain area. Peggy Maguire stated that to her understanding it is designated. She discussed the designated areas for flush and cremation lots as well as upright. She added that if there is an area designated for upright that is what it should be used for and maintained as. Randolph Meiklejohn stated the discussion is identifying a policy area for work down the road. He added that if upright marker space is limited and flush marker space is broadly available and redirect people to put lots in the designated areas. He added that that policy is not in place. Joslin Murphy discussed that historically people were directed to purchase in certain areas and could pick. Randolph Meiklejohn discussed the nuances of that practice. Randolph Meiklejohn offered the motion he had drafted which states “That the Trustees recommend the Town use the Layout Revision Study site plan proposing 136 new full-body upright burial lots, as indicated on the drawing distributed 10/12/2023, to modify the layout of Section 21”. Joslin Murphy seconded the motion. Randolph Meiklejohn took a roll call vote. Lisa Farber voted in favor, Peggy Maguire voted in favor, Joslin Murphy voted in favor, Gerard Hayes voted in favor, and Randolph Meiklejohn voted in favor.

Gerard Hayes asked to discuss at some point in time scattering and green burials. Randolph Meiklejohn asked Alexandra Vecchio if the town has had buyers for scattering locations in the cemetery. Alexandra Vecchio responded and that there hasn’t been in the last 10 to 12 years. Joslin Murphy, Randolph Meiklejohn, and Gerard Hayes discussed the Halvorson contract, price survey and adding green burials to the next meeting’s agenda.

### **Discussion and Vote on Creation of New Upright Marker Full Burial Lots in Proposed New Sections**

Randolph Meiklejohn discussed the background of the agenda item and the discussion regarding the buildouts of the cemetery. Randolph Meiklejohn stated that he had a motion he had prepared and a recommendation to buildout the Library Edge side of the cemetery. He offered a motion reading “That the Trustees recommend the Town proceed to site investigations, final design and a cost estimate for a future expansion of the cemetery using the Library Edge Schematic Design Option of 01/24/2023”. Gerard Hayes asked if it was an alternative to the Allandale side or an addition to that side. Randolph Meiklejohn responded with where the Trustees are now both options are available and stated that he described the motion as not proposing any action on the Allandale Edge. Gerard Hayes stated that he recalled there was discussion regarding the Allandale Edge side. Randolph Meiklejohn asked the trustees if they had any comments on the motion.

Joslin Murphy responded to Gerard Hayes stating that both options were on the table and discussed but there was no explicit discussion or agreement regarding the Allandale Edge side. Joslin Murphy asked Alexandra Vecchio what the motion means. Alexandra Vecchio responded that currently they have schematic designs/preliminary designs and to get a cost estimate as well as a final design it requires getting a refined number on the allocation of the space, a geotechnical analysis, and

opening another contract with a design firm. She added that it is for understanding what is beneath the surface, the cost of final design, and the cost to construct. She explained that it would be for preparing the construction bid documents to be put out to bid of a company to complete the work necessary. She stated that at the point of having a final design and construction costs the trustees would have the say to either move forward with the project or not and require additional information prior to pursuing construction. Joslin Murphy asked if the town is experiencing 19 or 20 upright burials per year. Randolph Meiklejohn responded that it was his estimate from a memo in March and that it was the average number of upright marker lots sold in a 15-year period from 2008 to 2023. Peggy Maguire clarified that it was lot sold, not occupied. Joslin Murphy stated that by adding 136 new upright full-body markers in Section, is it premature to expand. Joslin Murphy and Randolph Meiklejohn discussed the number of sales as well as if the decision was premature. Joslin Murphy stated she would likely make an amendment to the motion. She discussed that if the "Section 24 Expansion" of the Library Edge option with 56 graves were added, as well as a few more lots from other areas would create a total of 180 to 190 new grave sites. She added an expansion would be premature but adding the 56 would work as an interim expansion step. Randolph Meiklejohn stated that a significant amount of staff time, consultant time, and trustees' time has been allocated to exploring the options. He added that to ensure the maximum return on the investment of time and resources, it makes sense to arrive at a decision. Joslin Murphy responded that the conversation has resulted in an area that would provide another 136 lots and that it is premature but if someone feels the need to add more there are 56 new graves as an alternative to an expensive build out. Lisa Farber asked what Joslin Murphy meant by expensive work. Lisa Farber and Joslin Murphy discussed what the work would be needed for the two options.

Joslin Murphy asked how much an estimate would cost. Alexandra Vecchio responded that she isn't exactly sure but generally it would be close to \$100,000 for geotechnical analysis and then develop full plans and documents for construction of the site. Peggy Maguire asked if Halvorson would be qualified to complete the geotechnical analysis and Alexandra Vecchio responded that they would not be. She added that whoever the successful firm is would either have someone on staff or hire a specialist. Joslin Murphy stated that there would have to be a request for proposal (RFP) for the design services.

Gerard Hayes stated he is not in favor of delaying the project for a later date and asked if a study could be done in phases. Alexandra Vecchio asked if he was referring to a closer estimate for the design contract and the construction costs would only be determined if trustees decided to move forward with a design contract. Randolph Meiklejohn asked if once design contract is complete could the trustees wait a couple of years before building. Alexandra Vecchio responded that they could and rebid it or decide its cost prohibited and not move forward. She added that given construction costs if they decide to move forward with the design contract and wait there could be issues if there is too large of a gap. She added this is because an estimated cost of construction could be off within 6 months. Joslin Murphy and Alexandra Vecchio discussed what the motion meant in regards to construction and the design contract. Randolph Meiklejohn stated that it is not a sign off on construction. Alexandra Vecchio stated that this buildout project would come back before the trustees again prior to construction. Joslin Murphy responded that Gerard's question was nuanced as he wanted to know how much it would cost. Alexandra Vecchio stated that \$100,000 was a ballpark estimate and she could consult with the Engineering Director regarding an estimate for the geotechnical work which would include rock work as well as test pits. Joslin Murphy stated that she was in favor of waiting for an estimate.

Peggy Maguire stated that she is not inclined to wait as waiting for several years would increase the cost to the fund and wants to know more options for the future with the Library Edge.

She added that she is more inclined to focus on the Library Edge as it needs attention and is an appropriate location.

Lisa Farber stated that she would be interested in the Allandale Edge as during the site walk it seemed more promising. Joslin Murphy stated that although she is not in favor of the development of either edge she does agree with Lisa Farber. She added that between both edges, which both yield the same number of burials, the cost difference is much lower on the Allandale Edge versus Library Edge. She added that she was unsure what that would mean for the cost estimate of the study. Alexandra Vecchio responded that the trustees could opt to conduct test pits in both areas to assess the extent of geotechnical work needed at each site. She added that this would provide additional information before securing a full design contract for either location. She stated that the cost estimate would be closer to the tens of thousands for that kind of test pit and analysis. Peggy Maguire stated that she would feel more comfortable with that option and Lisa Farber agreed.

Randolph Meiklejohn discussed why he decided to include the Library Edge instead of the Allandale Edge in his motion. Joslin Murphy stated that she appreciated the thoughtful analysis and that it supports her suggestion from earlier regarding the strip in the master plan (i.e. the 56 lots proposed in Section 24) be the next expansion site. She added that that the Allandale Edge area is the older more historic part of the cemetery. She stated that she doesn't believe by delaying the buildout it would be an issue and that by building out the strip to include an additional 56 graves would allow for more space prior to completing a full build out of the edges. Joslin Murphy pointed out the areas on the map. Randolph Meiklejohn stated that there are several decisions the trustees could make and that they are mutually exclusive. He stated the options being taking test pits on both edges prior to proceeding with a design contract or proceed with the buildout of the 136 lots and additional 56 lots and then pause. He added there was no reason to do both options but rather go with either one. Gerard Hayes stated that he thinks it is a great suggestion to do test pits in both sites and Peggy Maguire agreed. Alexandra Vecchio stated that the motion is for a full design and analysis of the library Edge which was raised, seconded, and requires a vote. She added that the alternative is to complete geotechnical analysis on the Library or Allandale Edges that will inform a potential future design contract. She added that the other option is to pursue no geotechnical analysis and instead commit to the perimeter addition of grave sites along the Library Edge site. Joslin Murphy stated that she is worried about the discussion of studies and not taking into account the historical context and she agrees with Randolph Meiklejohn that if developed it should be with the Library Edge side. She additionally discussed the possibility of ledge and needing analysis with Alexandra Vecchio for the additional 56 graves.

Randolph Meiklejohn asked procedurally what the next step would be as he agreed with Joslin Murphy. He discussed amendment language with Alexandra Vecchio. Randolph Meiklejohn proposed that the trustees amend the motion to include only the 56 lawn graves proposed within the Library Edge option. Joslin Murphy and Randolph Meiklejohn discussed the language of the amendment. Joslin Murphy and Randolph Meiklejohn stated that the amendment should read as "That the Trustees recommend the Town proceed to site investigations, final design and a cost estimate for expansion of cemetery using the "Section 24 Expansion 56 graves" area of the Library Edge Schematic Design Option of 01/24/2023". Joslin Murphy seconded. Randolph Meiklejohn called a roll call vote. Lisa Farber voted in favor, Peggy Maguire voted in favor, Joslin Murphy voted in favor, Gerard Hayes voted in favor, and Randolph Meiklejohn voted in favor.

### **Other Business**

Peggy Maguire discussed asking to collect items for the December agenda. She discussed prioritizing, reevaluating, and remarketing the pricing of upright graves versus flush markers giving priority to flush markers. Joslin Murphy asked to add the hold policy or practice to the agenda.

Alexandra Vecchio shared the news of new cemetery supervisor, discussed their qualifications, and start date. She discussed revisiting overall structure of staff at the cemetery.

### **Adjourn**

Peggy Maguire moved to adjourn. Seconded by Joslin Murphy. Randolph Meiklejohn took a roll call vote. Lisa Farber voted in favor, Peggy Maguire voted in favor, Joslin Murphy voted in favor, Gerard Hayes voted in favor, and Randolph Meiklejohn voted in favor.

DRAFT



**TOWN of BROOKLINE**  
Massachusetts  
**Walnut Hills Cemetery**  
**Old Burying Ground**

**Trustees**

Lisa Farber  
Gerard Hayes  
Peggy Maguire  
Randolph Meiklejohn, Chair  
Joslin Ham Murphy

**Director of Parks and Open Space**  
Alexandra Vecchio

“RM EDITS version”

Walnut Hills Cemetery Trustees Meeting  
Wednesday, December 6, 2023  
9:30 AM  
Room 103, Brookline Town Hall  
Zoom Webinar

**Trustees Present:** Gerard Hayes, Lisa Farber, Randolph Meiklejohn, and Joslin Ham Murphy

**Trustees Absent:** Peggy Maguire

**Staff Present:** Alexandra Vecchio, Director of Parks and Open Space; Jessica White, Parks Assistant; Erin Chute, Commissioner of Public Works

Please click below to access all meeting documents:

<https://www.brooklinema.gov/DocumentCenter/Index/4880>.

1. September 20, 2023 Draft Meeting Minutes
2. October 4, 2023 Draft Meeting Minutes
3. October 10, 2023 Draft Meeting Minutes
4. A Spreadsheet of comparable municipal cemetery lot costs.
5. A PDF of comparable municipal cemeteries lot detailed rate costs.
6. Rate Increase Study worksheet
7. A PDF of Brookline's detailed Historic Rates
8. A draft Proposal for FY2025 rate increase for Walnut Hills Cemetery
9. A memo From Randolph Meiklejohn: \_Green Burials Study Materials
10. A memo from Erin Chute\_ Sale of Lots and Staffing Memo
11. A scan of Green Burial Study Materials

**Welcome and Approval of the Walnut Hills Cemetery Trustees Meeting Minutes**

Randolph Meiklejohn opened the meeting. A roll call was taken to confirm attendance. All Trustees were present except Peggy Maguire.

Randolph Meiklejohn discussed the new practice of editing the minutes with the change tracker and then sending them to the Trustees for review and approval.

Gerry Hayes had a question on the last paragraph of page 4 on the September 20, 2023, minutes regarding the Columbarium. He would like to include an agenda item to discuss a columbarium in the future.

Joslin Murphy moved for approval of the September 20, 2023, Walnut Hills Cemetery Minutes. Lisa Farber seconded it. All in favor. A roll call vote was taken.

Joslin Murphy moved to approve the October 4, 2023, Walnut Hills Cemetery Minutes. Gerry Hayes seconded it. All in favor. A roll call vote was taken.

The October 16, 2023, Walnut Hills Cemetery Meeting Minutes will be voted on at the March 2024 Meeting.

### **Introduction to Green Burials**

Randolph Meiklejohn presented the Trustees with a memo regarding Green Burials that includes a homework assignment, which can be found here: <https://www.brooklinema.gov/DocumentCenter/Index/4880>.

The Trustees will discuss the homework program and a system for divvying up the cemetery visits at the March meeting.

He stated that green burials have come up occasionally in recent and past meetings. He stated that it's complicated and would like the Trustees to know more about it. Randolph Meiklejohn has limited knowledge of green burials, so he looked online and pulled together some green burial resources for today's meeting. Randolph Meiklejohn discussed these resources in the packet, which can be found here: <https://www.brooklinema.gov/DocumentCenter/Index/4880>.

### **Review, Discussion, and Possible Votes of the Fiscal Year 2025 Cemetery Rates**

Randolph Meiklejohn stated the FY2025 rates are proposed to be effective on July 1, 2024. He hopes that between this meeting today, where we can unfold all the materials, and the scheduled March meeting, the Trustees can decide on possible rate increases.

The Trustees discussed the following documents, which can be found in the meeting files document here: <https://www.brooklinema.gov/DocumentCenter/Index/4880>.

1. Single-page spreadsheet of comparable municipal cemeteries lot costs.
2. A multi-page PDF of comparable municipal cemeteries lot detailed rate costs.
3. A PDF of Brookline's detailed Historic Rates since the year 2000
4. A draft Proposal for FY2025 rate increase for Walnut Hills Cemetery

Alexandra Vecchio stated that the rates were last increased in 2018. The rates have been voted and re-adapted without changes since then, but there has been a longer gap than in previous years. Joslin Murphy stated that there is a case law out there that states that fees should not exceed the actual cost, and they wondered if this was calculated in the proposed rates sheet. Alexandra Vecchio stated that she does not have the answer either. Joslin Murphy stated that we need to be mindful of

that. Joslin Murphy stated that while looking at possible increases, she understood the focus to be looking at it as a marketing question to make flat markers more attractive. Randolph Meiklejohn stated that the trustees could consider all rates annually or at a shorter interval than what has been done in recent years.

Gerry Hayes feels that Randolph Meiklejohn is a little high in some areas of his draft proposal for the FY2024 rate increases. He feels that these need to be discussed. Gerry Hayes disagrees with the single cremation two percent increase; he thinks it should be more.

Joslin Murphy stated that she is curious about what Erin Chute and Alexandra Vecchio think about the marketing piece. She feels that the Trustees should try to encourage more cremation because of the space consideration and flat marker spaces because there are so many. Erin Chute stated that she wanted to build on Joslin's statement about the cremated remains and the flat markers. She stated that we have looked at all of the different internment options in the past and intentionally kept the cremated remains prices low. She stated that we wanted it to be affordable and encourage people to opt for cremated remains, enabling us to serve people in the future. She stated that we might only be a cemetery allowing only burial of cremated remains at some point. She stated that there was a time when things were shifting where people were going from full body to cremated remains, but she does not think we saw the uptick as much as we thought we were going to. She stated that people are now thinking about a whole host of different burial options. She feels that we will see the shape of burials change in the next ten years. She used hybrid green burials as an example. She thinks we want to encourage cremation to remain an option and anything that enables us to serve more people in the community. She stated that the flat markers supported the landscape master plan, which called for keeping the upright markers around the perimeter to keep a sense of openness in the center. She stated that is the reason why we wanted that to be an affordable, desirable option that supports our long-term vision for the cemetery's grounds. Gerry Hayes asked if what he heard Erin Chute say was that the price differential did not attract more sales in the area you wanted it to. Erin Gallentine stated that it was not as much as they thought. Alexandra Vecchio noted that from her lived experience for the last year and a half, we have had people coming to us looking for upright full body lots, and the prices have yet to drive them to look at other options. This has led to their being added to the waitlist. She stated that there could be a tipping point in the future, but anecdotally, the experience over the last year and a half is that price is not driving that shift. She stated that we could undoubtedly track that if there is a change in the rates next year, but she has seen that people want to be buried the way they want to be buried, and it's not enough of a shift to drive them the other way. Erin Chute stated that you could get a full-body burial and two cremated remains with a single full-body lot. She stated that with that one lot, you could have three interments.

Randolph Meiklejohn stated that when you get back to studying the comparable municipal rates, Belmont had a cemetery that sold out in 1988, and they built a new one that opened in 2007. He stated that full body burial there (you cannot have an upright marker) has three-zone choices that cost \$4,000.00, \$6,000.00 or \$8,000.00. The cremated remains prices are \$1,300.00, \$2,000.00, or \$2,600.00. He stated that Halvorson designed it, and it is a meadow. They distinguish between zones. Joslin Murphy likes the concept of zoning, but she is still unsure how that would translate to the newer side of Walnut Hills.

Turning to the draft proposal for FY 2025 rates, Randolph Meiklejohn stated that he did more detailed work in this proposal to propose new pricing for different types of lots, and less with the rates for current services (such as grave openings); these are handled as a group. The placeholder number for increasing all of the services rates is twenty percent, which equals three percent per year, and that was getting in the ballpark of the Town employee compensation increases during that time (2018 to 2024). Erin Chute feels that three percent per year is a minimum. She stated that the benefits and all the costs associated with the employees have increased by more than three percent per year.

She stated that could be more if warranted. Randolph Meiklejohn stated that Joslin Murphy raised the legal question of fees exceeding the actual cost and asked the Parks and Open Space Division to comment back to the Trustees about that. Erin Chute stated that she had started to look into what it costs to run the cemetery per year, and she thinks that is something that she needs a little more time to look into because there are a lot of other services that support the cemetery that aren't in the budget. She gave a few examples of those services. She stated that our revenue is far less than what it costs to run the cemetery. Even with the annual transfer to the general fund of one hundred thousand dollars from the income to help support the cemetery operations, that is still only less than a third of what it costs to run the cemetery. She stated that we can look at the costs of what it takes from start to finish of each of those services at Walnut Hills, but there is ongoing support that is needed for those graves, and she feels that it would be helpful for her to understand where the Trustees would like her to stop in terms of what those services cost. Joslin Murphy stated that because of the law about fees, she feels that the Trustees need to be careful about the service costs while calculating. She thinks we need to capture those other expenses in the price of lots. Gerry Hayes stated that when we look at costs for the cemetery, we need to keep in mind that that piece of land up there is also being operated as a park and an open space as well as the cemetery. He feels that a certain amount of the cost of maintaining the whole thing has to be taken on by the population taxes as a whole as opposed to not only the lot owners. Erin Chute stated that it has never been supported just by lot owners. However, Gerry Hayes pointed out that Walnut Hills Cemetery is an integral part of our open space network with environmental benefits and an important green space. He thinks we want to continue discussing the cemetery as that type of property. Randolph Meiklejohn said he will dedicate much time to this topic on the March agenda. He stated that he would like the Trustees to study these materials and work on the proposal worksheet between now and then. He would like opinions from the Trustees on the relative increases for the different types of burial lots.

### **Review and Discussion of Cemetery Staffing and Budget**

Erin Chute presented the Trustees with a memo of December 6, 2023, "Re: Walnut Hills Cemetery Sales, Lots and Staffing", which can be found here: <https://www.brooklinema.gov/DocumentCenter/Index/4880>.

Erin Chute stated that we have been looking for a Cemetery Supervisor and have been waiting for one since April. This position has been advertised four times. She discussed the interviews that have taken place. She stated that municipalities need help filling job openings, especially in public works, across the country. There has been a tremendous number of retirements with very little workforce that has been coming up. She stated that there is a shortage nationwide of commercial drivers. She stated that we have worked through our professional association plan with the State and have created an internal program to train people to get their commercial driver's licenses. She stated that this position is incredibly challenging because we have the operations piece, the business piece, and then having someone who can also meet with grieving families. Erin Chute stated that we were fortunate to have John Ronan in that role. She stated that Jessica White has put in extra hours and work to help keep the cemetery running. The general Foreman, Greg Paulk, has stepped in to help manage all the cemetery operations. Erin Chute stated that we will move to a time of need sale selling as a temporary measure. She noted that she can only remember moving to a time of need sales during COVID-19. Randolph Meiklejohn and Alexandra Vecchio discussed the waiting list. Randolph Meiklejohn asked if people who are not in need can join the waiting list. Erin Chute feels that it would get complicated. Gerry Hayes asked what the rationale would be to go to the time of need sales. Erin Chute states that it is all about staffing. Erin Chute stated that Alexandra Vecchio had

proposed this approach at a previous meeting and wanted to bring it up again. The strategy would consist of splitting the cemetery Supervisor position that deals with the grounds and the operations and then having someone else do all the data management and all the customer service with funeral homes and families. She thinks this will give the division a better chance of getting the right people. She stated in 2008 there were four employees at the cemetery, a cemetery supervisor, and three additional staff. Then there was a market crash, and a whole host of cuts were made across all departments, moving into 2009, and since then, there have been three people at the cemetery. Her proposal will move the staffing up to 3.5 employees. She proposes a 2-year pilot where the cemetery tries a Cemetery Business Assistant, under twenty hours per week and non-benefited. It would be hourly; they would only be paid for their hours, and the funding would come from TW23. She stated that TW23 has over \$500,00.00 in the account. She sees this as a direct benefit to the perpetual care of the cemetery because this person will be doing all of the sales will be managing the revenues that are coming into our trust funds, and this will enable the cemetery supervisor to spend all of his time on supporting the grounds, the grounds maintenance, long-term care, and those cemetery services. She feels that this approach will give us a lot of information, and then there could be further conversation about long-term funding strategy.

Gerry Hayes asked if the Human Resources Department had been consulted. He thinks this is a great idea. Erin Chute stated that she has yet to speak with Human Resources. Still, she has spoken with the Deputy Town Administrator of Finance, who approves part-time positions that are non-benefited and are not part of the operating budget. Erin Chute also talked to the Town Administrator about support for the part-time, non-benefited position. Alexandra Vecchio stated that she has previously worked with Jennifer Stallion in the Human Resources Department. Still, it was to discuss the process because the part-time, non-benefited positions don't go to the HR board. She stated there is no opposition to running it by the HR Director; just procedurally, it's something other than what they would necessarily have to sign off on.

Joslin Murphy stated that she fully supports this concept and has spoken to Erin Chute about it. She stated that Director Vecchio had brought his before the Trustees months ago. Joslin Murphy stated that she believes that accessing the TW23 for administrative purposes is not legal. She stated that we are Trustees and we have a responsibility to maintain the accounts for the purposes that they're intended for. She asked if Alexandra ever got a legal opinion from Town Counsel, and she knows from being a director that there is Personnel money with John Ronan's position being open. She feels there has to be money left in the Personnel budget. Erin Chute stated that Town Counsel has been swamped and unable to answer the question, Alexandra Vecchio and Erin Chute are awaiting a response. Erin Chute stated that she feels perpetual care and care of the grounds is a big umbrella. She sees this as directly supporting our ability to support the grounds. Joslin Murphy stated that if Town Counsel says it is legal, she will support it. Joslin Murphy is afraid that if we deplete the perpetual care fund for administrative purposes, then we are depleting that fund for purposes of requiring future property, which is one of the purposes of the fund. Joslin Murphy is hesitant to make a motion before hearing from Town Counsel. Gerry Hayes believes that the Trustees need to move this along fairly soon; he fears the risk of the operation falling apart.

Gerry Hayes moved to authorize \$38,000.00 per year for two years from TW23 for the Cemetery Business Assistant position contingent upon approval from Town Counsel and Human Resources. Lisa Farber seconded it. A roll call vote was taken.

Gerry Hayes- Yes  
Lisa Farber- Yes

Randolph Meiklejohn - Yes  
Joslin Murphy- No

The vote passed. Three in favor and one opposed.

Erin Chute will report back to the Trustees with an opinion from the Town Counsel and Human Resources. She stated that a decision in everyone's best interest will be made.

Joslin Murphy asked Erin Chute why she needed to wait two years to build it into the operating budget. Erin Chute stated that 2018 was the last time the dollar amount from the cemetery trust to support the operations was increased, and the operations have increased in cost since then. Erin Chute looked at the approach of increasing that amount to support this function, and the answer right now is the Town is going into a deficit budget. She thinks the Town needs a few years to help support any expansion. Erin Chute and Joslin discussed the cemetery employees currently assigned to the cemetery full-time.

Alexandra Vecchio stated that the Community Preservation Act Committee has applications open right now and several applications to the CPAC from the Parks and Open Space Division. She stated that we have a proposal that's being submitted for tree maintenance, planting, and management at several sites. The proposal is for \$250,000.00, to be split across Larz Anderson, Walnut Hills Cemetery, and inventories at five smaller parks to add them to the GIS Database. The Trustees voted in September 2024 for the acceptance of the Tree Replacement Master Plan; the minutes have been approved for that vote, and this vote would be approval of a letter of support from the cemetery Trustees to support the implementation of that master plan as part of the CPA application. Joslin Murphy asked if there was a separate application for the Old Burial Ground. Alexandra Vecchio stated that we did an eligibility application for that, but after further discussion with the Friends of the Old Burial Ground, they talked about holding off on that for another year. This is because some funds will help prepare their construction bid documents for repairing the Foster Fence there, so they felt the CPA funds would be better suited for the actual construction. There is a two-part process for CPA application: an eligibility check and the actual application. The Old Burying Ground went through the eligibility check but will only submit part of the application this year. This will be looked at next year.

Gerry Hayes moved to authorize Chair Randolph Meiklejohn to write the letter, as Alexandra Vecchio described, supporting this application for the cemetery portion of the \$250,000.00 Community Preservation Act proposal for the tree replacement work in various open spaces. Joslin Murphy seconded it. A roll call vote was taken. All in Favor.

Gerry Hayes-Yes  
Lisa Farber-Yes  
Joslin Murphy- Yes  
Randolph Meiklejohn -Yes

#### **Possible Vote on Annual Transfer from Cemetery Lots/Graves Special Revenue Fund SW01 to General Fund**

Gerry Hayes moved to approve the annual transfer of \$100,000.00 from the Cemetery Lots/Grave Special Revenue Find SW01 to the General Fund. Seconded by Lisa Farber. A roll call vote was taken. All in favor

Gerry Hayes-Yes  
Lisa Farber-Yes  
Joslin Murphy- Yes  
Randolph Meiklejohn -Yes

**Adjourn**

Meeting Adjourned.

DRAFT



**TOWN OF BROOKLINE**  
*Massachusetts*  
**DEPARTMENT OF PUBLIC WORKS**

*Erin E. Chute*  
Commissioner

## **Memorandum**

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To: Walnut Hills Cemetery Trustees  
From: Erin E. Chute, Commissioner of Public Works  
Alexandra Vecchio, Director of Parks and Open Space  
Date: December 6, 2023  
Re: Walnut Hills Cemetery Sale of Lots and Staffing  
Cc: Joe Callanan, Town Counsel  
Melissa Goff, Deputy Town Administrator of Finance

I hope that this message finds you well. I am writing to address the ongoing challenges we face in filling the Cemetery Supervisor Position at the Walnut Hills Cemetery and to propose measures aimed at enhancing our operations to ensure continued excellence in service delivery and an excellent standard of care for the grounds.

As you are aware, the Cemetery has been without a full-time supervisor since April 2023. During this time Jessica Zarni White, Parks Administrative Assistant, and Greg Paulk, Parks General Foreman, have performed the basic duties to keep the cemetery running while also managing their existing work. While I am extremely grateful for their hard work and willingness to support the Division during this challenging time, it is not a sustainable model for either the Department or the employees.

Despite exhaustive efforts to recruit a suitable candidate for the Cemetery Supervisor role, we have encountered considerable difficulty in finding an individual whose qualifications align with the diverse responsibilities demanded by the position. The Supervisor position has been posted four (4) times over the past 7 months. During that time, we interviewed nine (9) candidates and made an offer to one candidate. Unfortunately, that candidate withdrew from consideration after accepting the Town's original offer, deciding to remain at his current job. Recruitment for this position has been particularly difficult as the position requires someone with both field-based skills as well as cemetery business administration knowledge to handle customer inquiries, accounts payable/receivable, lot sales, buybacks, town clerk filings, documentation, and use of the cemetery software for mapping, scanning and data management. Several factors have contributed to the challenge of filling this role:

**Specialized Skill Set:** The Cemetery Supervisor position necessitates a unique skill set encompassing managerial proficiency and a comprehensive understanding of cemetery operations. This specific blend of expertise has been difficult to find in prospective candidates.

Competitive Market: The current employment landscape, particularly in specialized fields such as cemetery management, has presented obstacles in attracting and securing qualified applicants. Limited interest and a shortage of suitable candidates have compounded our efforts.

Given the ongoing challenges with filling the role and the staff's limited capacity while managing their existing duties, the Department intends to move to Time-of-Need Sales until we recruit, hire, and train a new Cemetery Supervisor. I wanted to make sure you all were aware of this change before we implemented this temporary change at Walnut Hills Cemetery.

After much consideration of the multifaceted demands and the complexities of cemetery management, Director Vecchio and I would like to propose the creation of a new part-time role that will help the Town better support the long-term care, maintenance and service at the cemetery: a Cemetery Business Assistant. This position would undertake various crucial responsibilities including managing lot sales, handling customer visits and inquiries, overseeing accounts payable/receivable, liaising with funeral homes, database management, mapping, scanning, and office functions. This individual would be responsible for managing the sales of lots and services that are then deposited into the Cemetery Trust Funds and for scheduling the annual fund performance presentation by the Town Treasurer. I recommend the introduction of this role as a part-time position to allow the Department the ability to assess the efficacy and benefits of the role within our operations. The Town will then seek a Cemetery Supervisor with a focus on the operations. This arrangement is intended to increase the ability of the Town to improve the overall care of the cemetery grounds, cemetery operations, and cemetery business/customer service.

In order to support this new position and the operations at the Walnut Hills Cemetery, I recommend utilizing \$38,000 per year from TW23. The account currently has over 500K and can support this expenditure. The position will be evaluated after 2 years in terms of the benefit to the cemetery operations and impact on "perpetual care" of the grounds. If the position is determined to be successful after the pilot the proper long-term, funding mechanism can be discussed.

Thank you for your attention and consideration.